6 UNITS · 60 LESSONS · ENGLISH TO MANDARIN CHINESE

轻松学中文

Learn Mandarin

Book & Workbook

Easy Mandarin Chinese for English speakers: pinyin, tones, characters and real conversations.



ā	字	你好	的	说	读
Pinyin & Tones	Characters & Writing	First Words & Phrases	Grammar Made Easy	Everyday Conversations	Reading & Culture

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to use this book

This book and the interactive web app at **learnmandarin.zyeemzia.com** are the same course. Write and practise in the book; use the web app to hear every word and sentence, take quizzes, review words with flashcards and play games.

1. Listen first

Open the same lesson in the web app and tap each word to hear it. Copy the sound, not the spelling.

2. Read aloud

Say every example and sentence out loud. Your mouth learns Mandarin sounds faster than your eyes do.

3. Use a pencil

Use a pencil for quizzes and writing so you can erase and retry. Answers are at the end of each unit.

4. Little but daily

15 minutes a day, 5 days a week: two or three lessons a week. Steady beats fast.

3′	7′	3′	2′
Review the last lesson	New lesson	Read aloud & write	Quiz or flashcards

Learner's name .....

Start date ..... My goal .....

Pronunciation help: pinyin with tone marks is printed under every word.

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AT A GLANCE

Pinyin & Tones

Initials

The consonant that starts a syllable. Mandarin has 21, plus y and w as spelling helpers.

b	p	m	f	d	t
b /bà/	**p** /pà/	**m** /mā/	**f** /fā/	**d** /dà/	**t** /tā/
爸爸 dad	朋友 friend	妈妈 mum	米饭 cooked rice	弟弟 younger brother	天气 weather

n	l	g	k	h	j
n /nà/	**l** /lā/	**g** /gē/	**k** /kě/	**h** /hē/	**j** /jī/
你 you	老师 teacher	哥哥 older brother	咖啡 coffee	好 good	家 home, family

q	x	zh	ch	sh	r
q /qī/	**x** /xī/	**zh** /zhī/	**ch** /chī/	**sh** /shí/	**r** /rì/
钱 money	谢谢 thank you	中国 China	茶 tea	书 book	人 person

z	c	s	y	w
z /zì/	**c** /cí/	**s** /sì/	**y** /yá/	**w** /wǒ/
再见 goodbye	菜 dish, vegetable	三 three	医生 doctor	晚上 evening

Finals

Everything after the initial: simple vowels, vowel glides and finals ending in n or ng.

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a	o	e	i	u	ü
a /ā/ 大 big	**o** /ò/ 伯伯 uncle (dad's older brother)	**e** /è/ 喝 to drink	**i** /yī/ 米 rice (grain)	**u** /wǔ/ 书 book	**ü** /yú/ 女 woman, female

er	ai	ei	ao	ou	an
er /èr/ 儿子 son	**ai** /ài/ 白 white	**ei** /fēi/ 黑 black	**ao** /hǎo/ 猫 cat	**ou** /ōu/ 狗 dog	**an** /ān/ 饭 meal

en	ang	eng	ong	ia	ie
en /mén/ 很 very	**ang** /máng/ 汤 soup	**eng** /lěng/ 灯 lamp, light	**ong** /dōng/ 红 red	**ia** /jiā/ 下 down, below	**ie** /yě/ 谢谢 thank you

iao	iu (iou)	ian	in	iang	ing
iao /yào/ 小 small	**iu** /liù/ 九 nine	**ian** /tiān/ 钱 money	**in** /xīn/ 今天 today	**iang** /xiǎng/ 两 two (of something)	**ing** /tīng/ 名字 name

iong	ua	uo	uai	ui (uei)	uan
iong /yòng/ 熊 bear	**ua** /huā/ 西瓜 watermelon	**uo** /duō/ 国 country	**uai** /kuài/ 筷子 chopsticks	**ui** /duì/ 水 water	**uan** /huān/ 玩 to play

un (uen)	uang	üe	üan	ün
un /chūn/ 困 sleepy	**uang** /huáng/ 床 bed	**üe** /yuè/ 学 to study	**üan** /yuǎn/ 元 yuan (money)	**ün** /yún/ 裙子 skirt

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Tones

The pitch of the voice. Four main tones plus a light neutral tone change the meaning of a syllable.

mā	má	mǎ	mà	ma
1st tone (high and level) /mā/	**2nd tone (rising)** /má/	**3rd tone (low, dipping)** /mǎ/	**4th tone (falling)** /mà/	**Neutral tone (light)** /ma/
妈妈 mum	茶 tea	好 good	不 not, no	谢谢 thank you

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UNIT 1

Pinyin & Tones

The sounds of Mandarin: initials, finals, the four tones and how to read pinyin

1. How a Mandarin Syllable Works
2. The Four Tones + the Neutral Tone
3. Initials, Group by Group
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5. Finals and the ü Sound
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7. Tone Changes
8. Pinyin Spelling Rules
9. Pinyin Reading Lab

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音

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1 · 8 MINUTES

How a Mandarin Syllable Works

Initial + final + tone: the three parts of every syllable

- Name the three parts of a Mandarin syllable
- See why one character = one syllable
- Know what pinyin is for

Welcome to Mandarin! Before characters, we learn the sounds. Chinese is written in characters, but learners (and Chinese children) use **pinyin**, the official Roman-letter spelling, to see how each character sounds.

Three parts

Good news: Mandarin syllables are very regular. Every syllable has the same three parts: an **initial**, a **final** and a **tone**.

The recipe

1 **Initial**
The consonant at the start, like m, h or zh. Some syllables have no initial at all.

2 **Final**
Everything after the initial: a vowel, a glide like ao, or a vowel + n / ng.

3 **Tone**
The pitch of your voice: high, rising, dipping or falling. It is shown by a mark over a vowel.

Taking syllables apart

Character	Initial	Final	Tone	Pinyin
妈	m	a	1st	mā
好	h	ao	3rd	hǎo
中	zh	ong	1st	zhōng
学	x	üe (written ue)	2nd	xué
是	sh	i	4th	shì
爱	(none)	ai	4th	ài

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One character = one syllable

Each Chinese character is read as exactly one syllable. A word of two characters has two syllables.

How to say it: Count the characters and you know how many syllables to say.

你好 nǐ hǎo　中国 Zhōngguó　谢谢 xièxie

DID YOU KNOW?

Mandarin has only about 400 basic syllables (around 1,300 with tones), while English has thousands. That is why tones matter so much: they keep words apart.

Tones change meaning

Same initial, same final, different tone: a completely different word. Tap each one and listen.

妈	麻	马	骂
mā	má	mǎ	mà
mother	hemp; numb	horse	to scold

MEMORY TRICK

Think of a syllable as a sandwich: the initial is the top slice, the final is the filling, and the tone is the sauce. Leave out the sauce and it is a different meal!

TIP

Pinyin letters do not always sound like English letters. q, x, c and zh are the big surprises. We meet them all in this unit.

Sounds in this lesson

m — **m** /mā/ 妈妈 mum	a — **a** /ā/ 大 big	mā — **1st tone (high and level)** /mā/ 妈妈 mum
h — **h** /hē/ 好 good	ao — **ao** /hǎo/ 猫 cat	mǎ — **3rd tone (low, dipping)** /mǎ/ 好 good

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Tap each character, listen, then say it out loud. Name its initial, final and tone.

妈

好

中

学

是

爱

Quick quiz

QUIZ

1. What are the three parts of a Mandarin syllable?
   - ○ A) Root, prefix, suffix
   - ○ B) Vowel, accent, stress
   - ○ C) Initial, final, tone
   - ○ D) Letter, word, phrase
2. How many syllables does a character have?
   - ○ A) One
   - ○ B) Two
   - ○ C) It depends
   - ○ D) Three
3. In 好 hǎo, what is the final?
   - ○ A) h
   - ○ B) hǎ
   - ○ C) o
   - ○ D) ao
4. Which syllable has no initial?
   - ○ A) mā
   - ○ B) ài
   - ○ C) shì
   - ○ D) hǎo
5. What is pinyin?
   - ○ A) A kind of character
   - ○ B) The official Roman-letter spelling of Mandarin sounds
   - ○ C) A Chinese dialect
   - ○ D) The name of the 4th tone
6. 妈 mā and 马 mǎ differ only in their…
   - ○ A) initial
   - ○ B) final
   - ○ C) number of syllables
   - ○ D) tone

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UNIT 1 · LESSON 2 · 12 MINUTES

The Four Tones + the Neutral Tone

High, rising, dipping, falling, and light

- Say the four tones clearly
- Recognise the tone marks
- Hear the difference between tones
- Use the light neutral tone

Tones are the music of Mandarin. Every syllable is said with a pitch shape, and the shape is part of the word. Do not worry: with a little daily practice, your ears and voice will learn them.

The tones

mā — **1st tone (high and level)**
/mā/
妈妈 mum

má — **2nd tone (rising)**
/má/
茶 tea

mǎ — **3rd tone (low, dipping)**
/mǎ/
好 good

mà — **4th tone (falling)**
/mà/
不 not, no

ma — **Neutral tone (light)**
/ma/
谢谢 thank you

1st tone: high and level

Start high and stay high, like singing one long note.

How to say it: Mark: ¯ (a flat line).

妈	八	书
mā	bā	shū

2nd tone: rising

Start in the middle and go up, like asking "Huh?" or "What?".

How to say it: Mark: ´ (a line going up).

麻	茶	来
má	chá	lái

3rd tone: low and dipping

Go low, dip down, and (when the syllable is said alone) come back up.

How to say it: Mark: ˇ (a little valley).

马	好	你
mǎ	hǎo	nǐ

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4th tone: falling

Start high and drop sharply, like a firm "No!".

How to say it: Mark: ` (a line going down).

骂 是 不
mà shì bù

Neutral tone: light

Short, soft and quick, with no mark. It often appears on the second half of a word or on little grammar words.

How to say it: No mark at all.

吗 妈妈 谢谢
ma māma xièxie

Tones at a glance

Tone	Mark	Pitch	Feels like
1st	ā	high, flat	singing a long note
2nd	á	middle → high	a surprised "What?"
3rd	ǎ	low, dip (→ up)	a doubtful "Well...?"
4th	à	high → low	a firm "No!"
neutral	a	short, light	a quick, soft beat

MEMORY TRICK

Draw the tone in the air with your hand as you say it: flat line, up, dip, down. Your voice follows your hand.

Same sound, four meanings

汤	糖	躺	烫
1st tone · tāng	**2nd tone · táng**	**3rd tone · tǎng**	**4th tone · tàng**
soup	sugar, sweets	to lie down	very hot (to touch)

DID YOU KNOW?

Mixing up tones can be funny: ask for 汤 tāng (soup) with the wrong tone and you might be asking for 糖 táng (sugar)!

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About the 3rd tone

Most people speak the 3rd tone low and only rise at the end of a sentence or when the syllable is said alone. Practise the low part first: it is the most important.

Tap and repeat each row. Exaggerate the tones: big tones now, natural tones later.

妈 麻 马 骂 吗

八 拔 把 爸

汤 糖 躺 烫

书 熟 鼠 树

Quick quiz

QUIZ

7. Listen. Which tone do you hear? (listen in the web app: 马)
   - ○ A) 1st tone
   - ○ B) 2nd tone
   - ○ C) 3rd tone
   - ○ D) 4th tone

8. Listen. Which tone do you hear? (listen in the web app: 烫)
   - ○ A) 1st tone
   - ○ B) 2nd tone
   - ○ C) 3rd tone
   - ○ D) 4th tone

9. Listen. Which tone do you hear? (listen in the web app: 书)
   - ○ A) 1st tone
   - ○ B) 2nd tone
   - ○ C) 3rd tone
   - ○ D) 4th tone

10. Listen. Which tone do you hear? (listen in the web app: 茶)
    - ○ A) 1st tone
    - ○ B) 2nd tone
    - ○ C) 3rd tone
    - ○ D) 4th tone

11. Which tone mark looks like a little valley?
    - ○ A) ǎ
    - ○ B) á
    - ○ C) à
    - ○ D) ā

12. Which word means "horse"?
    - ○ A) mā
    - ○ B) má
    - ○ C) mǎ
    - ○ D) mà

13. How is the neutral tone written?
    - ○ A) With no mark
    - ○ B) With a dot
    - ○ C) With a circle
    - ○ D) With two lines

14. Which tone sounds like a firm "No!"?
    - ○ A) 1st tone
    - ○ B) 2nd tone
    - ○ C) 4th tone
    - ○ D) Neutral tone

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UNIT 1 · LESSON 3 · 12 MINUTES

Initials, Group by Group

b p m f · d t n l · g k h

- Say the lip, tongue-tip and back-of-tongue initials
- Hear the difference between b and p, d and t, g and k
- Learn the puff-of-air trick

Mandarin has 21 initials. Teachers group them by where in the mouth you make them. Let us start with the easy groups: most of these sound almost like English.

Lips: b p m f

b
/bà/
爸爸 dad

p
/pà/
朋友 friend

m
/mā/
妈妈 mum

f
/fā/
米饭 cooked rice

Made with the lips. m and f are just like English. The trick is **b** versus **p**.

Tongue tip: d t n l

d
/dà/
弟弟 younger brother

t
/tā/
天气 weather

n
/nà/
你 you

l
/lā/
老师 teacher

Made with the tongue tip behind the top teeth. n and l are just like English. The trick is **d** versus **t**.

Back of the tongue: g k h

g
/gē/
哥哥 older brother

k
/kě/
咖啡 coffee

h
/hē/
好 good

Made at the back of the mouth. The trick is **g** versus **k**, and h is a little rougher than English h.

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The puff-of-air rule

In Mandarin, b/p, d/t and g/k are not about voice. They are about air: b, d, g have **no** puff; p, t, k have a **strong** puff.

How to say it: Hold your hand or a tissue in front of your mouth. No movement: b d g. A clear puff: p t k.

爸 bà　怕 pà　大 dà　他 tā　哥 gē　可 kě

b or p?

爸

b · no puff

bà, dad. Soft, like the p in "spin".

怕

p · puff

pà, to be afraid. Like the p in "pie".

d or t?

肚

d · no puff

dù, belly. Soft, like the t in "stop".

兔

t · puff

tù, rabbit. Like the t in "top".

g or k?

哥

g · no puff

gē, older brother.

科

k · puff

kē, subject (of study).

TIP

The h in Mandarin is made further back, with a little friction, a bit like a gentle version of the "ch" in Scottish "loch". Try 喝 hē (to drink) and 好 hǎo (good).

MEMORY TRICK

p, t, k = "puff, tissue, kick": these three blow the tissue away.

Words to try

爸爸
bàba
dad

朋友
péngyou
friend

妈妈
māma
mum

飞机
fēijī
plane

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弟弟	他	你	老师
dìdi	tā	nǐ	lǎoshī
younger brother	he	you	teacher

哥哥	咖啡	好
gēge	kāfēi	hǎo
older brother	coffee	good

Read each pair. Feel the puff on the second one.

爸 怕

大 他

哥 科

饱 跑

弟 替

Quick quiz

QUIZ

15. Listen. Which initial do you hear? (listen in the web app: 怕)

- ○ A) b
- ○ B) p
- ○ C) m
- ○ D) f

16. Listen. Which initial do you hear? (listen in the web app: 大)

- ○ A) t
- ○ B) n
- ○ C) l
- ○ D) d

17. Listen. Which initial do you hear? (listen in the web app: 可)

- ○ A) g
- ○ B) h
- ○ C) d
- ○ D) k

18. What is the real difference between b and p in Mandarin?

- ○ A) b is louder
- ○ B) p has a puff of air, b does not
- ○ C) p is a vowel
- ○ D) b is always 4th tone

19. Which group is made with the lips?

- ○ A) d t n l
- ○ B) g k h
- ○ C) b p m f
- ○ D) j q x

20. Mandarin b sounds most like the English p in...

- ○ A) "spin"
- ○ B) "pie"
- ○ C) "phone"
- ○ D) "pool"

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21. Which word means "teacher"?

- ○ A) 哥哥 gēge
- ○ B) 咖啡 kāfēi
- ○ C) 老师 lǎoshī
- ○ D) 弟弟 dìdi

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q

UNIT 1 · LESSON 4 · 15 MINUTES

The Tricky Initials

j q x · z c s · zh ch sh r

- Say j q x with the tongue tip down
- Say z c s like "ds", "ts", "s"
- Curl the tongue for zh ch sh r
- Say the special "buzzing" i

These ten initials are where pinyin looks least like English. Do not read them with English habits! Take them slowly, one group at a time.

Flat tongue, tip down: j q x

j
/jī/
家 home, family

q
/qī/
钱 money

x
/xī/
谢谢 thank you

Put your tongue tip behind your **lower** front teeth, press the middle of the tongue up, and smile. j has no puff, q has a puff, x is a soft hiss.

Pinyin	Sounds like	Character
j	j in "jeep", tongue tip down	鸡 jī, chicken
q	ch in "cheese", tongue tip down, puff	七 qī, seven
x	sh in "sheep" said with a smile	西 xī, west

WATCH OUT

q is never "kw" and x is never "ks". 七 qī sounds like "chee", 谢谢 xièxie sounds like "shyeh-shyeh".

Tongue at the teeth: z c s

z
/zì/
再见 goodbye

c
/cí/
菜 dish, vegetable

s
/sì/
三 three

Pinyin	Sounds like	Character
z	ds in "kids"	字 zì, character
c	ts in "cats", with a puff	菜 cài, dish
s	s in "sun"	四 sì, four

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WATCH OUT

c is never "k" or "s": 菜 cài sounds like "tsai". And z is not the buzzy z of "zoo": it is "ds", as in "kids".

Curled tongue: zh ch sh r

zh
/zhī/
中国 China

ch
/chī/
茶 tea

sh
/shí/
书 book

r
/rì/
人 person

Curl the tongue tip up and back towards the roof of your mouth. These are a "curled" version of English j, ch, sh and r.

Pinyin	Sounds like	Character
zh	j in "judge", tongue curled	知 zhī, to know
ch	ch in "church", tongue curled, puff	吃 chī, to eat
sh	sh in "shirt", tongue curled	十 shí, ten
r	r in "run" mixed with s in "pleasure"	日 rì, sun, day

The "buzzing" i

After z c s zh ch sh r, the letter i is **not** "ee". Hold the tongue where the initial was and just let the voice buzz on.

How to say it: Compare 西 xī ("shee") with 四 sì ("sz") and 十 shí ("shr").

字 zì　四 sì　知 zhī　吃 chī　十 shí　日 rì

x, s or sh?

西
x · tongue down
xī, west. Smiling "shee".

四
s · teeth
sì, four. A plain hiss and buzz.

十
sh · curled
shí, ten. Tongue curled back.

q, ch or c?

七
q · tongue down
qī, seven.

吃
ch · curled
chī, to eat.

词
c · teeth
cí, word.

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MEMORY TRICK

j q x are "smiley" sounds: tongue down, lips smiling. zh ch sh r are "curly" sounds: tongue curled up. z c s are "snake" sounds: hissing at the teeth.

CULTURE NOTE

In southern China and Taiwan many people pronounce zh ch sh like z c s. Learn the standard curled sounds, but do not be surprised to hear both.

Read each line, feeling where your tongue is.

鸡 七 西

字 词 四

知 吃 十 日

七 吃 词

西 四 十

Quick quiz

QUIZ

22. Listen. Which initial do you hear? (listen in the web app: 七)

- ○ A) q
- ○ B) ch
- ○ C) c
- ○ D) j

23. Listen. Which initial do you hear? (listen in the web app: 十)

- ○ A) x
- ○ B) s
- ○ C) r
- ○ D) sh

24. Listen. Which initial do you hear? (listen in the web app: 菜)

- ○ A) z
- ○ B) c
- ○ C) q
- ○ D) ch

25. Where is the tongue tip for j q x?

- ○ A) Curled back
- ○ B) Down behind the lower teeth
- ○ C) Between the teeth
- ○ D) Touching the lips

26. Pinyin c sounds like...

- ○ A) k in "cat"
- ○ B) s in "city"
- ○ C) ch in "chat"
- ○ D) ts in "cats"

27. In 四 sì, the i sounds like...

- ○ A) a buzz, not "ee"
- ○ B) ee in "see"
- ○ C) i in "sit"
- ○ D) eye

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28. Which group needs a curled tongue?

- ○ A) z c s
- ○ B) j q x
- ○ C) zh ch sh r
- ○ D) b p m f

29. 谢谢 xièxie sounds roughly like…

- ○ A) "shyeh-shyeh"
- ○ B) "ksee-ay ksee-ay"
- ○ C) "zee-ay zee-ay"
- ○ D) "kyeh-kyeh"

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ü

UNIT 1 · LESSON 5 · 15 MINUTES

Finals and the ü Sound

Simple, compound and nasal finals

- Say the six simple vowels, including ü
- Glide through compound finals like ao and iao
- Tell n from ng

Finals are the vowel part of the syllable. There are quite a few, but they are built from just six simple vowels. Learn those first and the rest snap together.

The six simple vowels

a — a — /ā/ — 大 big

o — o — /ò/ — 伯伯 uncle (dad's older brother)

e — e — /è/ — 喝 to drink

i — i — /yī/ — 米 rice (grain)

u — u — /wǔ/ — 书 book

ü — ü — /yú/ — 女 woman, female

Pinyin	Sounds like	Character
a	a in "father"	啊 ā
o	"aw" with round lips	哦 ò
e	"uh" from the back of the throat	饿 è, hungry
i	ee in "see"	一 yī, one
u	oo in "food"	五 wǔ, five
ü	"ee" with "oo" lips	鱼 yú, fish

WATCH OUT

Pinyin e is **not** English e. 饿 è (hungry) sounds like a deep "uh". But inside ie, üe and ei, e sounds like the e in "yes".

Making ü

Say "ee" and hold your tongue still. Now round your lips tightly as if to whistle. That is ü!

How to say it: Smile-and-kiss: tongue says "ee", lips say "oo".

鱼 yú　女 nǚ　绿 lǜ　去 qù

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u or ü?

路	绿
u · lù	**ü · lǜ**
road. Lips round, tongue back.	green. Lips round, tongue forward as for "ee".

The curly er

er
/èr/
儿子 son

二 èr (two) is a special final: say "uh" while curling the tongue tip back, like American "are".

Compound finals: glide from vowel to vowel

ai — /ài/ — 白 white

ei — /fēi/ — 黑 black

ao — /hǎo/ — 猫 cat

ou — /ōu/ — 狗 dog

ia — /jiā/ — 下 down, below

ie — /yě/ — 谢谢 thank you

iao — /yào/ — 小 small

iu — /liù/ — 九 nine

ua — /huā/ — 西瓜 watermelon

uo — /duō/ — 国 country

uai — /kuài/ — 筷子 chopsticks

ui — /duì/ — 水 water

üe — /yuè/ — 学 to study

Final	Sounds like	Character
ai	eye	爱 ài, love
ei	ay in "say"	飞 fēi, to fly
ao	ow in "cow"	好 hǎo, good
ou	o in "go"	狗 gǒu, dog
ie	ye in "yes"	也 yě, also
iao	yow	小 xiǎo, small
iu	yo	六 liù, six

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Final	Sounds like	Character
uo	waw	多 duō, many
ui	way	水 shuǐ, water

Nasal finals: ending in n or ng

an — /ān/ — 饭 meal

en — /mén/ — 很 very

ang — /máng/ — 汤 soup

eng — /lěng/ — 灯 lamp, light

ong — /dōng/ — 红 red

in — /xīn/ — 今天 today

ing — /tīng/ — 名字 name

ian — /tiān/ — 钱 money

iang — /xiǎng/ — 两 two (of something)

iong — /yòng/ — 熊 bear

uan — /huān/ — 玩 to play

un (uen) — /chūn/ — 困 sleepy

uang — /huáng/ — 床 bed

üan — /yuǎn/ — 元 yuan (money)

ün — /yún/ — 裙子 skirt

n or ng?

饭

an · fàn

meal. Tongue tip touches behind the top teeth for n.

放

ang · fàng

to put. Back of the tongue rises for ng, like "sing".

心

in · xīn

heart. Short, clean n.

星

ing · xīng

star. Ends with ng.

WATCH OUT

ian sounds like "yen", not "yan". 天 tiān (sky) sounds like "tyen", and 钱 qián (money) like "chyen".

MEMORY TRICK

n is "front door" (tongue tip at the front), ng is "back door" (tongue at the back, as in "sing").

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Read across each line slowly, gliding smoothly.

啊 哦 饿 一 五 鱼

爱 飞 好 狗

也 小 六 多 水

饭 放 心 星

天 钱 远 云

路 绿

Quick quiz

QUIZ

30. Listen. Which final do you hear? (listen in the web app: 鱼)

- ○ A) u
- ○ B) i
- ○ C) ü
- ○ D) e

31. Listen. Which final do you hear? (listen in the web app: 放)

- ○ A) an
- ○ B) ang
- ○ C) en
- ○ D) eng

32. How do you make ü?

- ○ A) Say "oo" with a smile
- ○ B) Say "uh" with the tongue curled
- ○ C) Say "ah" through the nose
- ○ D) Say "ee" with rounded lips

33. The final ian sounds like...

- ○ A) "yan"
- ○ B) "yawn"
- ○ C) "eye-an"
- ○ D) "yen"

34. Pinyin ao rhymes with...

- ○ A) "go"
- ○ B) "cow"
- ○ C) "say"
- ○ D) "see"

35. Which word means "green"?

- ○ A) lù
- ○ B) liù
- ○ C) lǜ
- ○ D) lè

36. Which pair differs by n and ng?

- ○ A) 心 xīn and 星 xīng
- ○ B) 路 lù and 绿 lǜ
- ○ C) 爱 ài and 飞 fēi
- ○ D) 五 wǔ and 鱼 yú

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UNIT 1 · LESSON 6 · 8 MINUTES

Where the Tone Mark Goes

One simple order: a, then o or e, then the rest

- Put tone marks on the right vowel
- Handle iu and ui correctly
- Write ü with tone marks

A tone mark always sits on a vowel. When a syllable has two or three vowels, which one gets it? There is a simple rule of priority.

Tone mark priority

Look for **a** first. No a? Look for **o** or **e** (they never appear together except in ou, and there o wins). Neither? Put it on the **last** vowel.

How to say it: a → o / e → last vowel

好 hǎo　谢 xiè　多 duō　狗 gǒu　对 duì　六 liù

Three questions

1 **Is there an a?**

好

hǎo

good

Yes: mark the a. Also kuài, tiān, xiǎo.

2 **No a. Is there an o or e?**

谢

xiè

to thank

Mark it: xiè, duō, hēi, gǒu, yuè.

3 **Neither? Mark the last vowel.**

六

liù

six

iu marks the u, ui marks the i: liù, duì, shuǐ.

MEMORY TRICK

"**A** gets it first; **O** and **E** take turns; otherwise the **last** one wins."

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Final	Marked vowel	Example
ao	a	好 hǎo
ia	a	家 jiā
ian	a	天 tiān
ou	o	狗 gǒu
uo	o	国 guó
ei	e	黑 hēi
üe	e	学 xué
iu	u (last)	九 jiǔ
ui	i (last)	水 shuǐ

The dot on i

When i carries a tone mark, the mark replaces the dot.

一 yī　你 nǐ　米 mǐ　是 shì

Marks on ü

ü keeps its two dots and the tone mark goes on top of them.

女 nǚ　绿 lǜ　旅 lǚ

TIP

On a phone or computer you can usually type ü as "v" in pinyin input: "nv" gives 女 nǚ.

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Say each word, then say which vowel carries the mark.

好

谢谢

多

狗

六

对

水

学

Quick quiz

QUIZ

37. Which spelling is correct for "good"?

- ○ A) haǒ
- ○ B) hǎǒ
- ○ C) hǎo
- ○ D) hāo

38. Which spelling is correct for "six"?

- ○ A) liù
- ○ B) lìu
- ○ C) líu
- ○ D) liú

39. Which spelling is correct for "water"?

- ○ A) shǔi
- ○ B) shùi
- ○ C) shúi
- ○ D) shuǐ

40. In xiè, the mark is on e because…

- ○ A) e is the first vowel
- ○ B) there is no a, so e gets it
- ○ C) i cannot take marks
- ○ D) it is a 4th tone

41. In ou, which vowel gets the mark?

- ○ A) u
- ○ B) o
- ○ C) neither
- ○ D) both

42. What happens to the dot on i under a tone mark?

- ○ A) It moves to the side
- ○ B) It becomes two dots
- ○ C) It stays under the mark
- ○ D) The mark replaces it

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变

UNIT 1 · LESSON 7 · 12 MINUTES

Tone Changes

3rd-tone pairs, 不 bù and 一 yī

- Change 3rd + 3rd into 2nd + 3rd
- Use the low "half-3rd" tone
- Know when 不 and 一 change tone

Tones sometimes change when syllables sit next to each other. This is called **tone sandhi**. There are only three common changes, and they make speech flow smoothly.

Rule 1: two 3rd tones in a row

When a 3rd tone comes before another 3rd tone, the first one is said as a **2nd tone**. Pinyin still writes the original marks.

How to say it: 3 + 3 → 2 + 3

你好	很好	水果	可以
nǐ hǎo → ní hǎo	hěn hǎo → hén hǎo	shuǐguǒ → shuíguǒ	kěyǐ → kéyǐ

MEMORY TRICK

Two valleys in a row are hard to walk, so the first one climbs into a hill: ní hǎo!

Rule 2: the half-3rd tone

Before a 1st, 2nd, 4th or neutral tone, a 3rd tone is usually just **low**, without rising back up.

How to say it: Say only the low part of the dip.

老师	很忙	好看	你们
lǎoshī	hěn máng	hǎokàn	nǐmen

Rule 3: 不 bù

不 (not) is normally bù, 4th tone. Before another **4th tone** it becomes **bú**, 2nd tone.

How to say it: bù + 4th → bú + 4th

不是	不对	不要	不好	不来	不吃
bú shì	bú duì	bú yào	bù hǎo	bù lái	bù chī

Rule 4: 一 yī

一 is followed by...	Say 一 as	Examples
nothing (alone, counting, at the end)	yī (1st)	一 yī, 十一 shíyī, 第一 dì-yī

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一 is followed by...	Say 一 as	Examples
a 4th tone	yí (2nd)	一个 yí gè, 一样 yíyàng
a 1st, 2nd or 3rd tone	yì (4th)	一天 yì tiān, 一年 yì nián, 一起 yìqǐ

TIP

Dates and order numbers keep the plain yī: 一月 yīyuè (January), 第一天 dì-yī tiān (the first day). Do not change it there.

TIP

Many textbooks write the changed tones for 不 and 一 (bú shì, yí gè) to help learners, but dictionaries list the original bù and yī. For 3rd + 3rd, pinyin normally keeps the original marks: nǐ hǎo.

不: change or not?

不去

bú qù

not go: 去 is 4th tone, so 不 rises.

不忙

bù máng

not busy: 忙 is 2nd tone, so 不 stays bù.

一: yí or yì?

一共

yígòng

altogether: 共 is 4th tone.

一点儿

yìdiǎnr

a little: 点 is 3rd tone.

Read with the tone changes. Listen and copy the flow.

你好

很好

水果

不是

不好

一个

一天

一起

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Quick quiz

QUIZ

43. How do you actually say 你好?

- ○ A) ní hǎo
- ○ B) nǐ hǎo with two dips
- ○ C) nì hǎo
- ○ D) nī hāo

44. What happens to 3rd + 3rd?

- ○ A) Both become 1st tone
- ○ B) The second becomes 4th
- ○ C) The first becomes 2nd tone
- ○ D) Nothing changes

45. How is 不是 said?

- ○ A) bú shì
- ○ B) bù shì
- ○ C) bǔ shì
- ○ D) bū shì

46. How is 不好 said?

- ○ A) bú hǎo
- ○ B) bǔ hǎo
- ○ C) bù hǎo
- ○ D) bū hǎo

47. How is 一个 said?

- ○ A) yī gè
- ○ B) yí gè
- ○ C) yì gè
- ○ D) yǐ gè

48. How is 一天 said?

- ○ A) yí tiān
- ○ B) yī tiān
- ○ C) yǐ tiān
- ○ D) yì tiān

49. In 第一 (first), 一 is said...

- ○ A) yí
- ○ B) yì
- ○ C) yǐ
- ○ D) yī

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UNIT 1 · LESSON 8 · 12 MINUTES

Pinyin Spelling Rules

y and w, ü after j q x, and short forms

- Spell syllables that start with i, u or ü
- Know when ü is written without dots
- Read iu, ui and un correctly
- Use the apostrophe

Pinyin has a few spelling habits. They do not change the sound: they just make syllables easier to see on the page. Once you know them, reading gets much easier.

Starting with i → y

When a syllable has no initial and starts with i, write y. If i is the only vowel (or before n / ng), write yi.

一	也	要	有	烟	英
i → yī	ie → yě	iao → yào	iou → yǒu	ian → yān	ing → yīng

Starting with u → w

When a syllable has no initial and starts with u, write w. If u is the only vowel, write wu.

五	我	外	为	问	王
u → wǔ	uo → wǒ	uai → wài	uei → wèi	uen → wèn	uang → wáng

Starting with ü → yu

When a syllable starts with ü, write yu, and drop the dots.

鱼	月	远	云
ü → yú	üe → yuè	üan → yuǎn	ün → yún

ü after j q x: no dots

j, q, x (and y) never go with u, so after them ü is written plain u. It still **sounds** like ü!

How to say it: ju, qu, xu, yu = ü sounds.

去	句	学	鱼
qù	jù	xué	yú

ü after n and l: keep the dots

n and l can go with both u and ü, so here the dots matter.

女	努	绿	路
nǚ	nǔ	lǜ	lù

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Short forms

Full form	Written after an initial	Example
iou	iu	六 liù, 九 jiǔ
uei	ui	对 duì, 水 shuǐ
uen	un	春 chūn, 困 kùn

TIP

The hidden vowel is still there in the sound: 六 liù is really "lyoh", 对 duì is "dway".

The apostrophe

When a syllable starting with a, o or e follows another syllable, use an apostrophe so the break is clear.

How to say it: Xī'ān (two syllables, a city) is not xiān (one syllable, first).

西安 先 天安门
Xī'ān xiān Tiān'ānmén

MEMORY TRICK

j, q, x are "too shy" to sit next to plain u, so any u you see after them is really ü wearing a disguise.

Read each word. Think: what is the full form behind the spelling?

一 也 要 有

五 我 外 为

鱼 月 远 云

去 学 女 路

西安 先

Quick quiz

QUIZ

50. How do you write the syllable i on its own with the 1st tone?

- ○ A) ī
- ○ B) yī
- ○ C) yiī
- ○ D) wī

51. How do you write the syllable u with the 3rd tone?

- ○ A) ǔ
- ○ B) yǔ
- ○ C) wǔ
- ○ D) hǔ

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52. In 去 qù, the u sounds like…

- ○ A) ü
- ○ B) oo in "food"
- ○ C) u in "cup"
- ○ D) yoo

53. Why does 女 nǚ keep its dots?

- ○ A) Because it is 3rd tone
- ○ B) Because n is a lip sound
- ○ C) Because nu and nü are both possible
- ○ D) It is a spelling mistake

54. iu is short for…

- ○ A) iou
- ○ B) ieu
- ○ C) iau
- ○ D) yuu

55. What does the apostrophe in Xī'ān show?

- ○ A) A neutral tone
- ○ B) A missing letter
- ○ C) A foreign word
- ○ D) Where one syllable ends and the next begins

56. The final uei with no initial is written…

- ○ A) ui
- ○ B) wei
- ○ C) wui
- ○ D) uei

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读

UNIT 1 · LESSON 9 · 15 MINUTES

Pinyin Reading Lab

Put it all together with real words and sentences

- Read everyday words from pinyin
- Read short sentences with tone changes
- Write pinyin you hear

Time to use everything: initials, finals, tones, spelling rules and tone changes. Read each item, tap to check, and repeat until it feels natural.

Word bank

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
你好	nǐ hǎo	hello 你好！ (nǐ hǎo!) — Hello!
谢谢	xièxie	thank you
再见	zàijiàn	goodbye
对不起	duìbuqǐ	sorry
没关系	méi guānxi	it does not matter
老师	lǎoshī	teacher
学生	xuésheng	student
朋友	péngyou	friend
中国	Zhōngguó	China
中文	Zhōngwén	Chinese (language)

TIP

Some words end in a neutral tone: xièxie, péngyou, xuésheng. Say the last syllable lightly and quickly.

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你好吗?

你	好	吗
you	good, well	(question word)

nǐ hǎo ma?

How are you?

你好 is said ní hǎo (3rd + 3rd). 吗 is a light neutral tone.

我很好。

我	很	好
I	very	good, well

wǒ hěn hǎo.

I am very well.

Three 3rd tones! Most people say wǒ hén hǎo or wó hén hǎo.

我不是老师。

我	不	是	老师
I	not	am, is, are	teacher

wǒ bú shì lǎoshī.

I am not a teacher.

不 becomes bú before the 4th-tone 是.

我学中文。

我	学	中文
I	study	Chinese

wǒ xué Zhōngwén.

I study Chinese.

A first chat

Lín 你好!
nǐ hǎo!
Hello!

Amy 你好!你好吗?
nǐ hǎo! nǐ hǎo ma?
Hello! How are you?

Lín 我很好,谢谢。
wǒ hěn hǎo, xièxie.
I am very well, thanks.

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Amy 再见!
zàijiàn!
Goodbye!

Lín 再见!
zàijiàn!
Goodbye!

CULTURE NOTE

Friends usually do not ask 你好吗 every day. A friendly 你好 or, among friends, 嗨 hāi (hi) is more common. 你好吗 is still a perfect first phrase to learn.

Read each line aloud with good tones.

你好

谢谢

再见

对不起

没关系

你好吗?

我很好。

我不是老师。

我学中文。

Listen and write the pinyin

A teacher or friend reads each item aloud, or press "Listen" in the web app. Write what you hear; answers are at the end of the unit.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____

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Check yourself

☐ I can name the initial, final and tone of a syllable.

☐ I can say the four tones and the neutral tone.

☐ I can say j q x, z c s and zh ch sh r.

☐ I can make the ü sound.

☐ I know where tone marks go.

☐ I can use the tone changes for 3rd + 3rd, 不 and 一.

Give your work today some stars ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆

Quick quiz

QUIZ

57. Listen. Which word is it? (listen in the web app: 谢谢)

- ○ A) zàijiàn
- ○ B) xièxie
- ○ C) nǐ hǎo
- ○ D) duìbuqǐ

58. Listen. Which word is it? (listen in the web app: 朋友)

- ○ A) lǎoshī
- ○ B) xuésheng
- ○ C) Zhōngguó
- ○ D) péngyou

59. What does 对不起 mean?

- ○ A) sorry
- ○ B) thank you
- ○ C) goodbye
- ○ D) hello

60. How do you say "I am not a teacher"?

- ○ A) wǒ shì lǎoshī
- ○ B) nǐ bú shì lǎoshī
- ○ C) wǒ bú shì lǎoshī
- ○ D) wǒ hěn hǎo

61. What does 吗 do at the end of a sentence?

- ○ A) It makes a yes/no question
- ○ B) It means "very"
- ○ C) It means "mother"
- ○ D) It makes it polite

62. 中文 means...

- ○ A) China
- ○ B) teacher
- ○ C) Chinese (language)
- ○ D) student

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UNIT 1

Answer key

Dictation

1. 你好 (nǐ hǎo)
2. 谢谢 (xièxie)
3. 老师 (lǎoshī)
4. 朋友 (péngyou)
5. 中国 (Zhōngguó)
6. 再见 (zàijiàn)

Quiz

1. C) Initial, final, tone
2. A) One
3. D) ao
4. B) ài
5. B) The official Roman-letter spelling of Mandarin sounds
6. D) tone
7. C) 3rd tone
   马 mǎ (horse) has the dipping 3rd tone.
8. D) 4th tone
   烫 tàng (very hot) falls: 4th tone.
9. A) 1st tone
   书 shū (book) is high and level: 1st tone.
10. B) 2nd tone
    茶 chá (tea) rises: 2nd tone.
11. A) ǎ
12. C) mǎ
13. A) With no mark
14. C) 4th tone
15. B) p
16. D) d
17. D) k
18. B) p has a puff of air, b does not
19. C) b p m f
20. A) "spin"
21. C) 老师 lǎoshī
22. A) q
23. D) sh
24. B) c
25. B) Down behind the lower teeth
26. D) ts in "cats"
27. A) a buzz, not "ee"
28. C) zh ch sh r
29. A) "shyeh-shyeh"
30. C) ü
31. B) ang
32. D) Say "ee" with rounded lips
33. D) "yen"
34. B) "cow"
35. C) lǜ
36. A) 心 xīn and 星 xīng
37. C) hǎo
38. A) liù
39. D) shuǐ
40. B) there is no a, so e gets it
41. B) o
42. D) The mark replaces it
43. A) ní hǎo
44. C) The first becomes 2nd tone
45. A) bú shì
46. C) bù hǎo
47. B) yí gè
48. D) yì tiān
49. D) yī
50. B) yī
51. C) wǔ
52. A) ü
53. C) Because nu and nü are both possible
54. A) iou
55. D) Where one syllable ends and the next begins
56. B) wei
57. B) xièxie

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58. D) péngyou

59. A) sorry

60. C) wǒ bú shì lǎoshī

61. A) It makes a yes/no question

62. C) Chinese (language)

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字

UNIT 2

Characters & Writing

Strokes, stroke order, radicals and your first 17 characters

1. What Are Chinese Characters?
2. The Basic Strokes
3. Stroke-Order Rules
4. First Characters: Numbers, People, Sun and Moon
5. First Characters: Nature and Family
6. Common Radicals
7. Building Characters from Parts
8. Simplified and Traditional Characters
9. Copywork and Dictation

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字

UNIT 2 · LESSON 1 · 10 MINUTES

What Are Chinese Characters?

Pictures, ideas, and meaning + sound

- Know what a character is
- Recognise pictographs and ideographs
- Spot the meaning part and the sound part

Chinese is not written with an alphabet. Each **character** (汉字 hànzì) stands for one syllable and carries a meaning. Some started life as little pictures, but most are clever combinations of parts.

DID YOU KNOW?

The oldest known Chinese writing was carved on bones and turtle shells more than 3,000 years ago. Many characters you will learn today come from those ancient shapes.

Type 1: pictographs

A pictograph is a simplified drawing of a thing. Over centuries the curves became straight strokes, but you can still see the picture.

Character	Pinyin	Meaning	The picture
人	rén	person	a person walking, two legs striding
日	rì	sun, day	once a circle with a dot in the middle
月	yuè	moon, month	a crescent moon
山	shān	mountain	three peaks
水	shuǐ	water	a stream with splashes
火	huǒ	fire	flames rising
木	mù	tree, wood	branches above, roots below
口	kǒu	mouth	an open mouth

Type 2: simple ideographs

Ideas that are hard to draw are shown with simple signs.

一 二 三

yī èr sān

one, two, three

one, two and three lines

上

shàng

up, above

a mark above a line

下

xià

down, below

a mark below a line

本

běn

root, origin

a tree 木 with a mark at its base

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Type 3: compound ideographs

Two or more meaningful parts join to make a new idea.

休	明	林	森
xiū	míng	lín	sēn
to rest	bright	woods	forest
a person 亻 leaning on a tree 木	sun 日 + moon 月	two trees	three trees: lots of trees!

好
hǎo
good
woman 女 + child 子

Type 4: meaning part + sound part

Most characters (roughly 80%) combine a **meaning part** (often called the radical) with a **sound part** that hints at the pronunciation.

How to say it: 妈 = 女 (woman: the meaning) + 马 mǎ (horse: just for the sound). So 妈 is a woman who sounds like "ma": mum!

妈	吗	骂
mā	ma	mà

MEMORY TRICK

When you meet a new character, ask two questions: "What is the meaning part?" and "What is the sound part?" You will remember it twice as fast.

TIP

About 2,500 common characters cover around 98% of everyday written Chinese. You do not need tens of thousands!

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Tap each character and say it. Can you see the picture or the idea?

人

日

月

山

水

火

木

口

休

明

林

森

好

妈

Quick quiz

QUIZ

1. A Chinese character stands for…
   - ○ A) one letter
   - ○ B) a whole sentence
   - ○ C) one syllable with a meaning
   - ○ D) a sound with no meaning
2. Which character began as a picture of a mountain?
   - ○ A) 山
   - ○ B) 水
   - ○ C) 日
   - ○ D) 人
3. 明 (bright) is made of…
   - ○ A) tree + tree
   - ○ B) person + tree
   - ○ C) woman + child
   - ○ D) sun + moon
4. In 妈, which part gives the sound?
   - ○ A) 女
   - ○ B) 马
   - ○ C) both
   - ○ D) neither

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5. Most Chinese characters are made of…

- ○ A) pure pictures
- ○ B) a meaning part + a sound part
- ○ C) letters
- ○ D) numbers

6. 休 means "to rest" because it shows…

- ○ A) three trees
- ○ B) the sun over a mountain
- ○ C) a mouth and water
- ○ D) a person by a tree

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丿

UNIT 2 · LESSON 2 · 10 MINUTES

The Basic Strokes

Eight strokes build every character

- Name the eight basic strokes
- Write each stroke in the right direction
- Spot strokes inside characters

Every character is built from a small set of **strokes**: a stroke is one movement of the pen, from touching the paper to lifting it. Learn these eight and you can write anything.

The eight basic strokes

Stroke	Name	How to write it	Found in
一	héng · horizontal	left to right, slightly rising	一二十
丨	shù · vertical	top to bottom, straight down	十中
丿	piě · left-falling	from top right sweeping down to the left	人八
乀	nà · right-falling	from top left down to the right, ending in a flat tail	人大
丶	diǎn · dot	a short press, down and to the right	六小
㇀	tí · rising	from lower left flicking up to the right	打汉
乛	zhé · turn	change direction without lifting the pen	口日
亅	gōu · hook	a quick flick at the end of a stroke	小子

Stroke names

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
横	héng	horizontal stroke
竖	shù	vertical stroke
撇	piě	left-falling stroke
捺	nà	right-falling stroke
点	diǎn	dot
提	tí	rising stroke
折	zhé	turning stroke

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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
钩	gōu	hook

Strokes have a direction

Horizontals go left → right. Verticals go top → bottom. A turn (折) is one single stroke: do not lift the pen at the corner.

How to say it: The top and right side of 口 are ONE stroke (横折).

口 日
kǒu rì

TIP

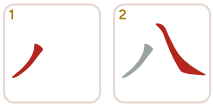
Strokes combine: a horizontal that turns down is 横折 héngzhé; a vertical with a hook is 竖钩 shùgōu. You will see these names in the stroke-order steps.

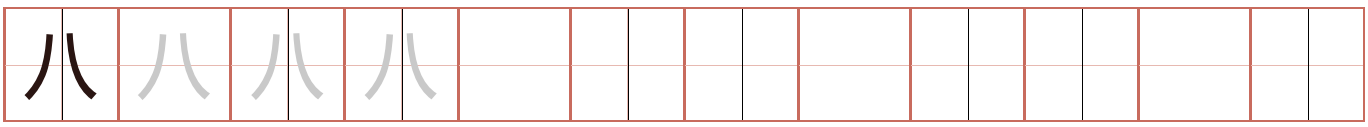
八

bā · eight

1. Stroke 1: 撇, a stroke from the top sweeping down to the left.
2. Stroke 2: 捺, a separate stroke from the top sweeping down to the right.

★ Two strokes parting like a gate opening: 八 means eight, and it is a lucky number in China!





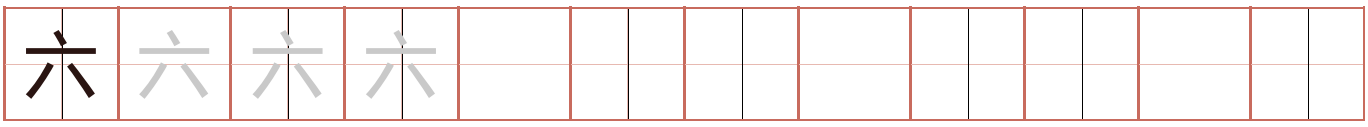
六

liù · six

1. Stroke 1: 点, a dot at the top.
2. Stroke 2: 横, a long horizontal.
3. Stroke 3: 撇, a short stroke down to the left.
4. Stroke 4: 点, a dot on the lower right.

★ A little person with a hat (the dot) and legs apart.





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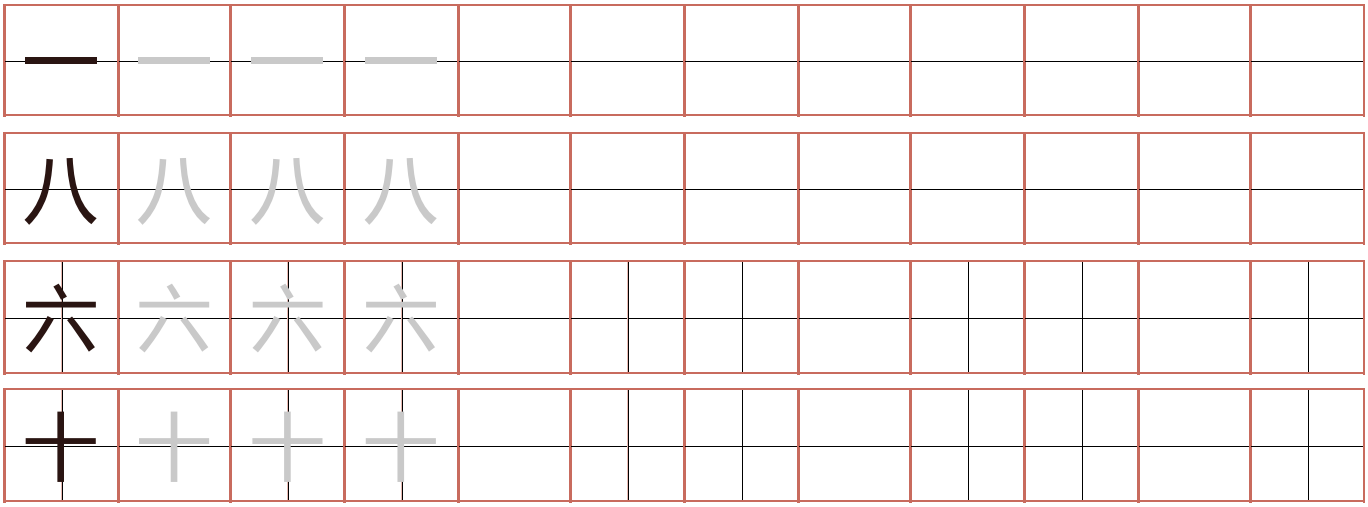
DID YOU KNOW?

Calligraphers practise with 永 yǒng (forever), because this one character contains nearly all the basic strokes. It is called "the eight principles of 永".

MEMORY TRICK

Remember the eight with a story: "Line (横), pole (竖), slide left (撇), slide right (捺), drop (点), flick up (提), bend (折), hook (钩)."

Trace each stroke slowly. Say its name as you write it.



Quick quiz

QUIZ

7. Which way is a horizontal stroke (横) written?
   - ○ A) Left to right
   - ○ B) Right to left
   - ○ C) Bottom to top
   - ○ D) Either way

8. Which stroke sweeps down to the left?
   - ○ A) 捺 nà
   - ○ B) 提 tí
   - ○ C) 撇 piě
   - ○ D) 点 diǎn

9. Which stroke flicks up to the right?
   - ○ A) 提 tí
   - ○ B) 竖 shù
   - ○ C) 撇 piě
   - ○ D) 横 héng

10. How many strokes make the top and right side of 口?
    - ○ A) Two
    - ○ B) Three
    - ○ C) One
    - ○ D) Four

11. What is a stroke?
    - ○ A) One complete character
    - ○ B) One pen movement before lifting
    - ○ C) A radical
    - ○ D) A tone mark

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12. 八 is written with…

- ○ A) 捺 then 撇
- ○ B) 横 then 竖
- ○ C) two dots
- ○ D) 撇 then 捺

☐ Lesson done Date: _____

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顺

UNIT 2 · LESSON 3 · 12 MINUTES

Stroke-Order Rules

Seven rules that tell you which stroke comes first

- Learn the seven main stroke-order rules
- Apply them to new characters
- Know the common exceptions

Chinese people write strokes in a fixed order. It is not just tradition: the right order makes characters faster to write, better balanced, and easier to read in handwriting. A handful of rules covers almost everything.

1. Horizontal before vertical

When a horizontal and a vertical cross, write the horizontal first.

How to say it: 先横后竖 xiān héng hòu shù

十 干

shí gàn

2. Left-falling before right-falling

When 撇 and 捺 meet, write 撇 (down-left) first.

How to say it: 先撇后捺 xiān piě hòu nà

人 八

rén bā

3. Top to bottom

Write the upper strokes or parts before the lower ones.

How to say it: 从上到下 cóng shàng dào xià

三 字

sān zì

4. Left to right

Write the left strokes or parts before the right ones.

How to say it: 从左到右 cóng zuǒ dào yòu

川 林

chuān lín

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5. Outside before inside

Write the frame first, then what is inside it.

How to say it: 从外到内 cóng wài dào nèi

月 同
yuè tóng

6. Inside before closing the box

For a fully closed box, write the left side and top first, then the inside, and close the bottom last.

How to say it: 先里头后封口 xiān lǐtou hòu fēngkǒu

日 回 国
rì huí guó

7. Middle before the sides

When a character has a strong middle stroke with small parts on both sides, write the middle first.

How to say it: 先中间后两边 xiān zhōngjiān hòu liǎngbiān

小 水
xiǎo shuǐ

MEMORY TRICK

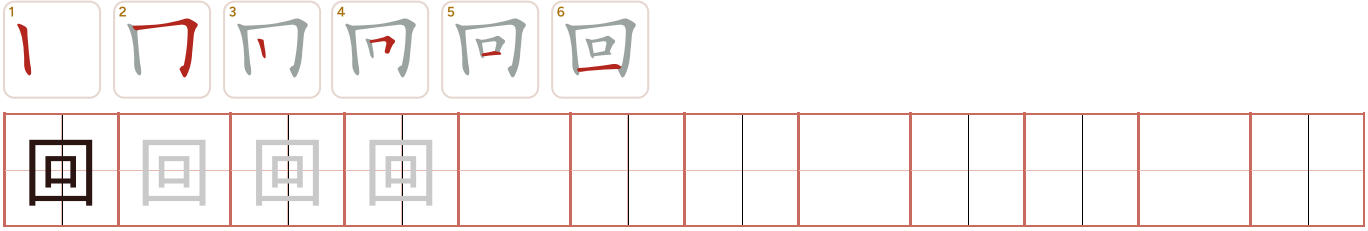
A short chant: "Across, then down. Left slide, then right. Top, then bottom. Left, then right. Outside, then inside, then shut the door. Middle, then the wings."

回

huí · to return

1. Stroke 1: 竖, the left side of the big box.
2. Stroke 2: 横折, the top and right side of the big box in one stroke.
3. Strokes 3–5: the small box inside: left side, top-and-right (横折), then its bottom line.
4. Stroke 6: 横, close the big box at the bottom. Total: 6 strokes.

★ A box inside a box: you go "back" inside before you shut the door.



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Exceptions

WATCH OUT

Some exceptions: a dot at the top right often comes last, as in 书 shū (book). And the "walking" part 辶 in 这 zhè (this) and 进 jìn (to enter) is written after the part it holds.

TIP

On the website, tap a character to watch its stroke order animate, then try the stroke-by-stroke writing quiz.

Say which rule each character follows, then write it in the air.

十

人

三

川

月

日

回

小

Quick quiz

QUIZ

13. In 十, which stroke comes first?

- ○ A) The vertical
- ○ B) Either
- ○ C) Both together
- ○ D) The horizontal

14. In 人, which stroke comes first?

- ○ A) 捺 (down-right)
- ○ B) 撇 (down-left)
- ○ C) Either
- ○ D) A dot

15. In 日, when is the bottom line written?

- ○ A) First
- ○ B) Second
- ○ C) Last
- ○ D) Third

16. In 小, which stroke comes first?

- ○ A) The middle hook
- ○ B) The left dot
- ○ C) The right dot
- ○ D) Any of them

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17. Which rule fits 林 (two trees side by side)?

- ○ A) Inside before closing
- ○ B) Middle before sides
- ○ C) Left to right
- ○ D) Bottom to top

18. Why does stroke order matter?

- ○ A) Faster, better-balanced, readable writing
- ○ B) It changes the meaning
- ○ C) It changes the tone
- ○ D) It is only for exams

19. How many strokes does 回 have?

- ○ A) 4
- ○ B) 5
- ○ C) 8
- ○ D) 6

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UNIT 2 · LESSON 4 · 18 MINUTES

First Characters: Numbers, People, Sun and Moon

一二三十人口日月大

- Write nine basic characters in the correct stroke order
- Remember each one with a picture
- Read simple words made from them

Now the fun part: writing real characters! Each one comes with its stroke order and a memory trick. Write each one several times, saying the strokes aloud.

yī · one

1. 1 stroke: 横, from left to right.
2. Press at the start, move steadily, and lift gently at the end.

★ One line means one. The easiest character there is!



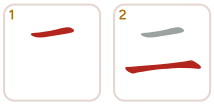


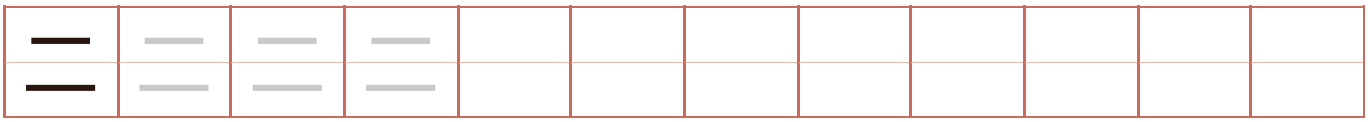


èr · two

1. Stroke 1: a short 横 on top.
2. Stroke 2: a longer 横 underneath.

★ Two lines, two. The bottom line is longer, like a shelf holding the top one.







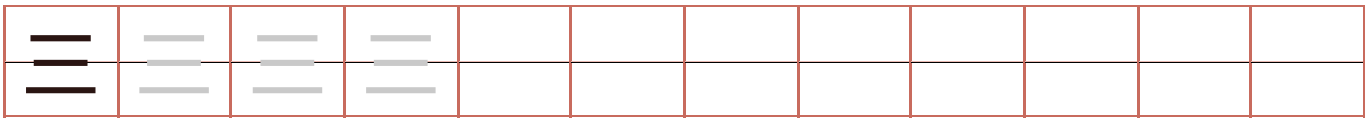
sān · three

1. Stroke 1: a medium 横 on top.
2. Stroke 2: a short 横 in the middle.
3. Stroke 3: the longest 横 at the bottom.

★ Three lines, three. The middle one is the shortest, the bottom one the longest.

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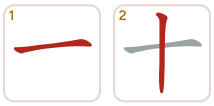


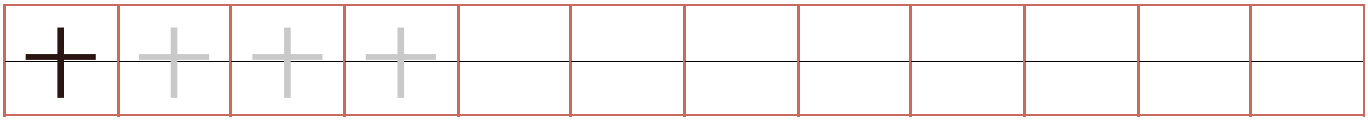
十

shí · ten

1. Stroke 1: 横, from left to right.
2. Stroke 2: 竖, from top to bottom, crossing the middle of the 横.

★ Looks like a plus sign: hold up both hands and add them up: ten!



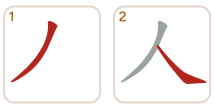


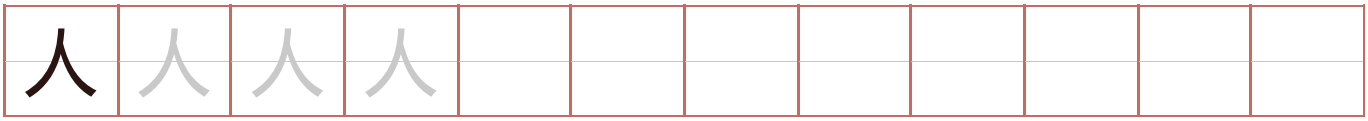
人

rén · person

1. Stroke 1: 撇, start at the top and sweep down to the left.
2. Stroke 2: 捺, start on the 撇 just below its top and sweep down to the right.

★ A person walking: two legs striding along.





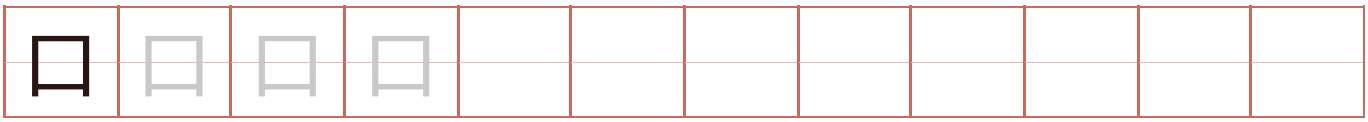
口

kǒu · mouth

1. Stroke 1: 竖, the left side, top to bottom.
2. Stroke 2: 横折, across the top and down the right side in one stroke.
3. Stroke 3: 横, the bottom line closes the box.

★ A wide-open mouth saying "Oh!". Make it a little narrower at the bottom.





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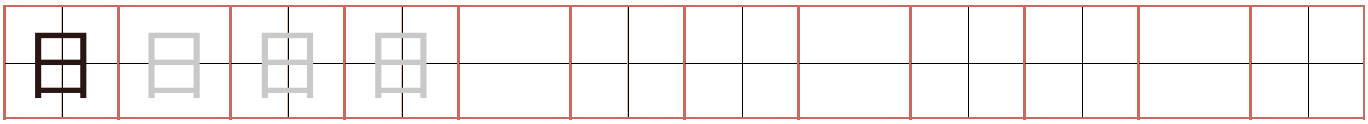
日

rì · sun, day

1. Stroke 1: 竖, the left side.
2. Stroke 2: 横折, the top and right side in one stroke.
3. Stroke 3: 横, the middle line (inside first!).
4. Stroke 4: 横, the bottom line closes the box.

★ A window with the sun shining through. It is taller than it is wide.





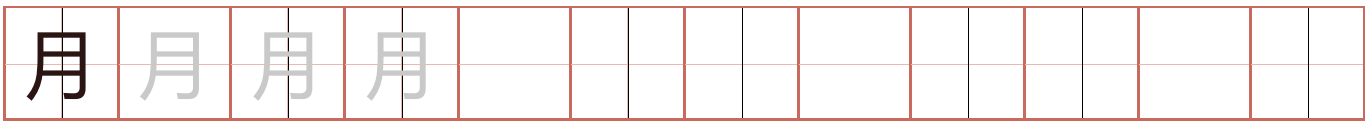
月

yuè · moon, month

1. Stroke 1: 竖撇, down the left side, curving left at the bottom.
2. Stroke 2: 横折钩, across the top and down the right side, ending in a small hook to the left.
3. Stroke 3: 横, the upper line inside.
4. Stroke 4: 横, the lower line inside.

★ A tall crescent moon with two clouds drifting across it. The bottom stays open.





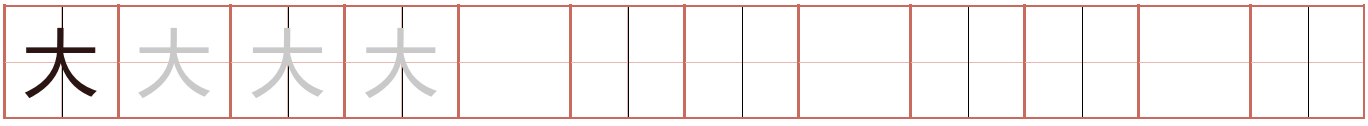
大

dà · big

1. Stroke 1: 横, a long horizontal.
2. Stroke 2: 撇, from above the 横, through it, sweeping down to the left.
3. Stroke 3: 捺, from where the strokes cross, sweeping down to the right.

★ A person 人 stretching their arms wide: "The fish was THIS big!"





Your new characters

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
一	yī	one 一月 (yīyuè) — January

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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
二	èr	two 二十 (èrshí) — twenty
三	sān	three 三月 (sānyuè) — March
十	shí	ten 十一 (shíyī) — eleven
人	rén	person 大人 (dàrén) — adult
口	kǒu	mouth 人口 (rénkǒu) — population
日	rì	sun, day 日子 (rìzi) — day; life
月	yuè	moon, month 二月 (èryuè) — February
大	dà	big 大人 (dàrén) — adult

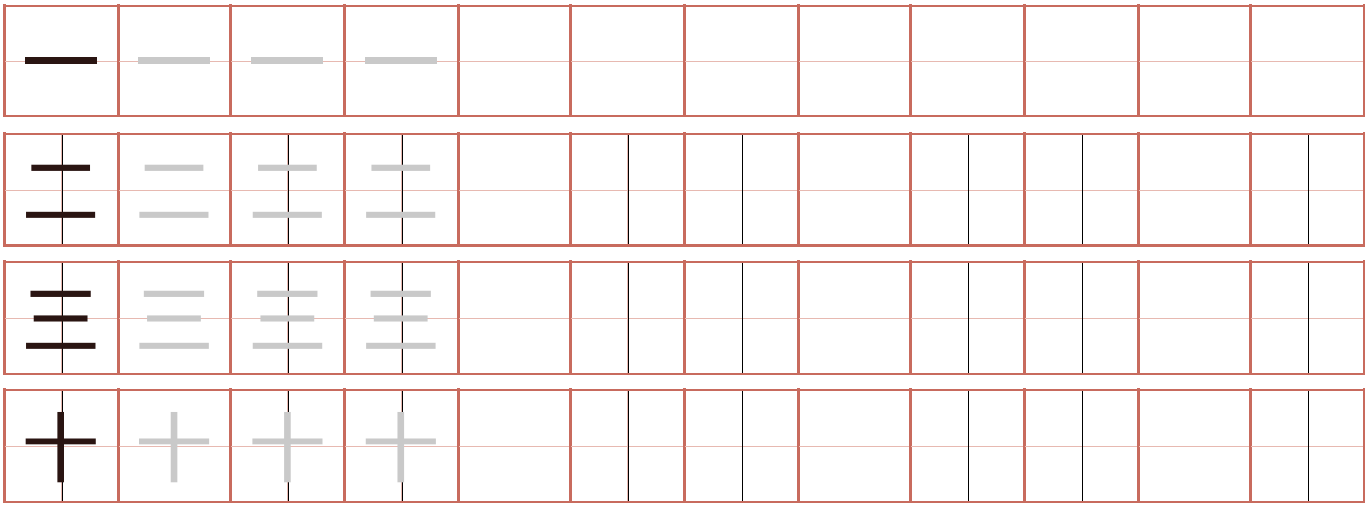
DID YOU KNOW?

Chinese months are just numbers: 一月 is "month one" (January), 二月 "month two" (February), all the way to 十二月 shí'èryuè (December).

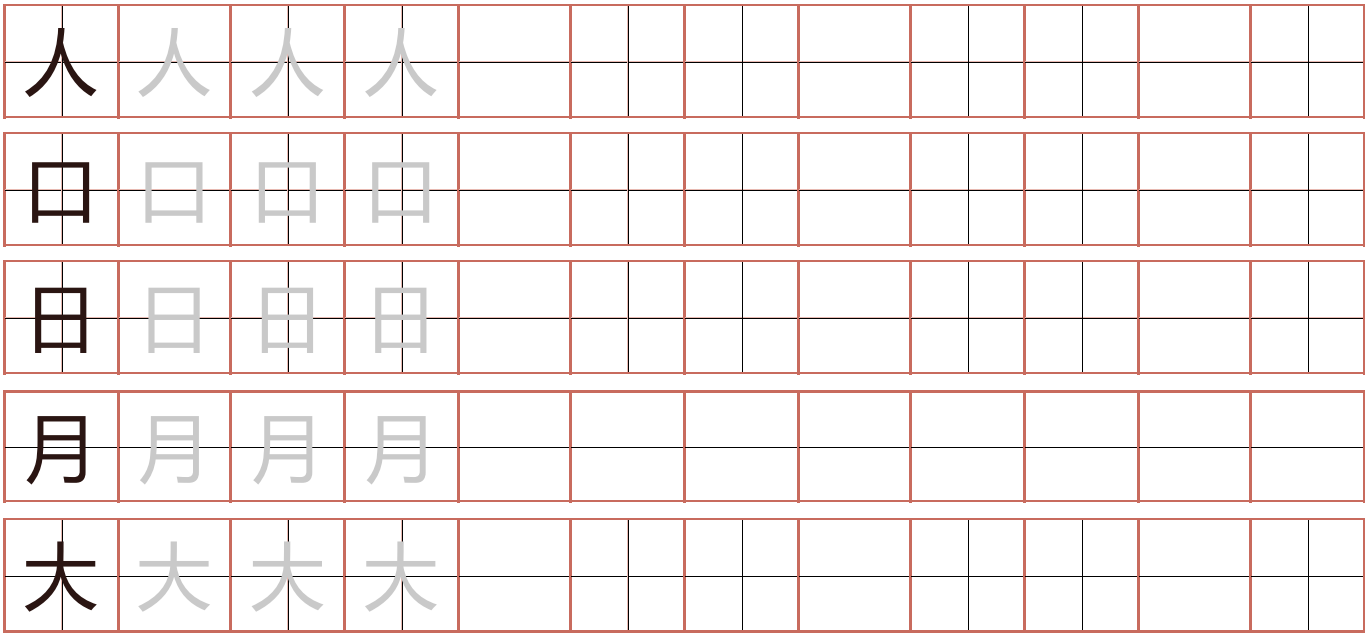
MEMORY TRICK

人 + 一 = 大: a person with arms stretched out is big. Add one more line on top and you get 天 tiān (sky): what is above the big person.

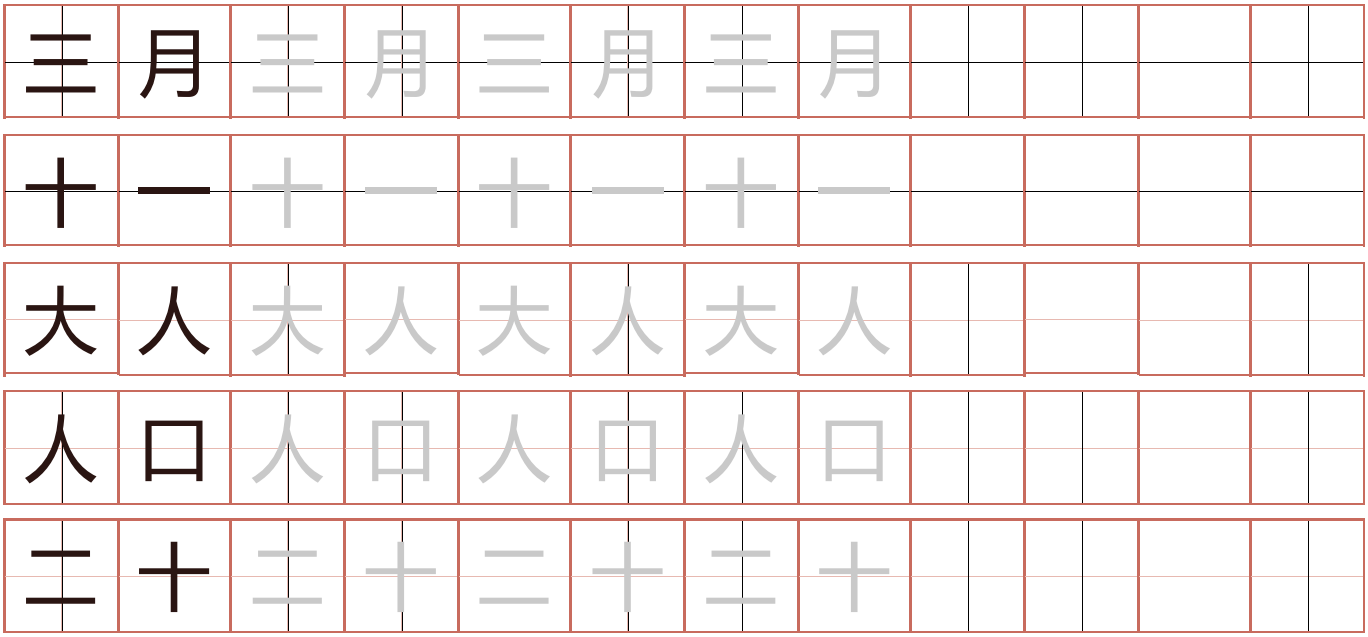
Follow the stroke order. Write each character at least five times.



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Two characters per word: keep them the same size.



Read the characters and words aloud.

一 二 三 十

人 口 日 月 大

一月 二月 三月

十一 二十

大人 人口

Quick quiz

QUIZ

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20. Listen. Which character is it? (listen in the web app: 日)

- ○ A) 月
- ○ B) 日
- ○ C) 口
- ○ D) 十

21. Which character means "big"?

- ○ A) 人
- ○ B) 大
- ○ C) 十
- ○ D) 口

22. How many strokes does 口 have?

- ○ A) 4
- ○ B) 2
- ○ C) 5
- ○ D) 3

23. In 日, which stroke is written third?

- ○ A) The middle line
- ○ B) The bottom line
- ○ C) The left side
- ○ D) The top line

24. What does 三月 mean?

- ○ A) Three moons
- ○ B) Wednesday
- ○ C) March
- ○ D) Thirty days

25. Which line of 三 is the shortest?

- ○ A) The middle one
- ○ B) The top one
- ○ C) The bottom one
- ○ D) They are equal

26. 二十 means...

- ○ A) twelve
- ○ B) two
- ○ C) twenty
- ○ D) February

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UNIT 2 · LESSON 5 · 18 MINUTES

First Characters: Nature and Family

小 中 山 水 火 木 女 子

- Write eight more characters in the correct stroke order
- Use the middle-first rule
- Read words made from your characters

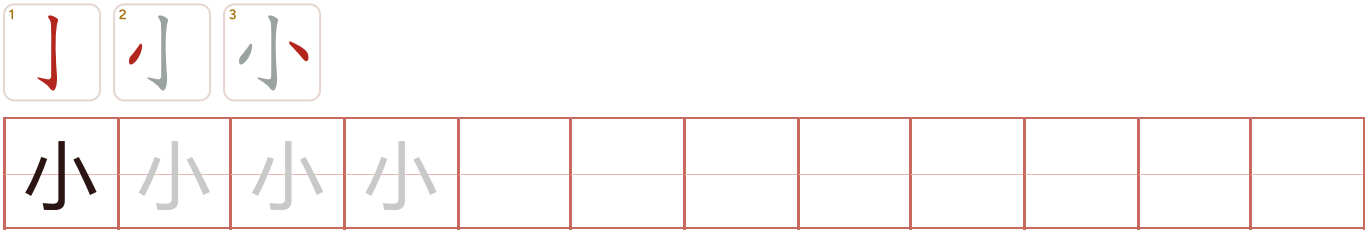
Eight more characters, full of nature and people. Several of them follow the "middle first" rule, so watch the first stroke carefully.

小

xiǎo · small

1. Stroke 1: 竖钩, a vertical line down the middle with a small hook to the left.
2. Stroke 2: 点, a short dot on the left.
3. Stroke 3: 点, a dot on the right.

★ One tall stick with two small crumbs beside it: small things!

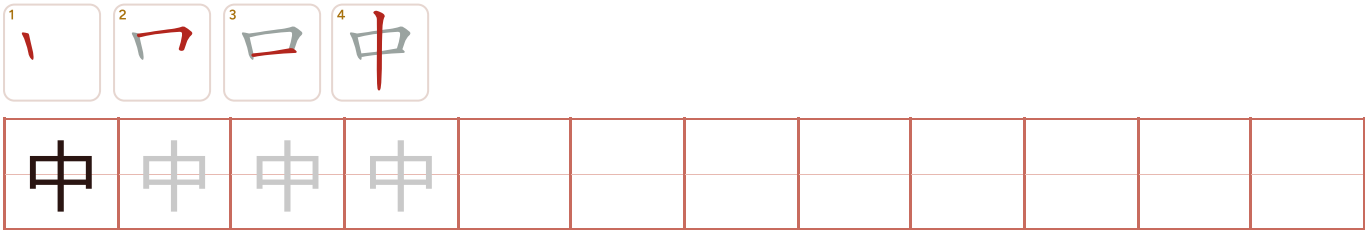


中

zhōng · middle

1. Stroke 1: 竖, the left side of the box.
2. Stroke 2: 横折, the top and right side in one stroke.
3. Stroke 3: 横, close the bottom of the box.
4. Stroke 4: 竖, a long line straight through the middle, written last.

★ An arrow right through the middle of a target. China is 中国, the "Middle Country".



山

shān · mountain

1. Stroke 1: 竖, the tall middle peak.
2. Stroke 2: 竖折, down the left side and along the bottom in one stroke.
3. Stroke 3: 竖, the right peak.

★ Three peaks, the middle one the tallest.

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山 山 山 山

水

shuǐ · water

1. Stroke 1: 竖钩, the long middle line with a hook to the left.
2. Stroke 2: 横撇, on the left: a short horizontal that turns down to the left.
3. Stroke 3: 撇, a short stroke on the upper right.
4. Stroke 4: 捺, sweeping down to the lower right.

★ A river running down the middle with splashes on both sides.



水 水 水 水

火

huǒ · fire

1. Stroke 1: 点, a short dot on the upper left.
2. Stroke 2: 撇, a short stroke on the upper right, pointing down to the left.
3. Stroke 3: 撇, the long main stroke from the top centre down to the left.
4. Stroke 4: 捺, from the middle of stroke 3, sweeping down to the right.

★ A campfire with two sparks jumping out of it.



火 火 火 火

木

mù · tree, wood

1. Stroke 1: 横, the branches.
2. Stroke 2: 竖, the trunk, from top to bottom through the 横.
3. Stroke 3: 撇, the root on the left.
4. Stroke 4: 捺, the root on the right.

★ Branches across, trunk down, roots spreading. Two trees 林 make woods; three trees 森 make a forest.



木 木 木 木

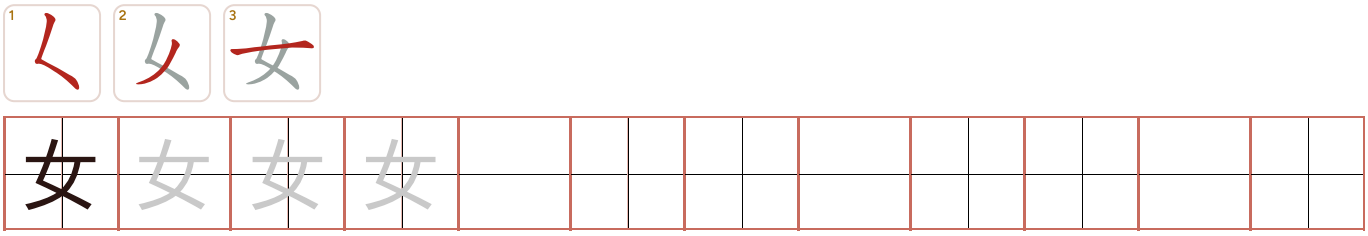
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女

nǚ · woman

1. Stroke 1: 撇点, go down to the left, then turn down to the right, in one stroke.
2. Stroke 2: 撇, from the upper right sweep down to the lower left, crossing stroke 1.
3. Stroke 3: 横, a long line across the middle.

★ A dancer with crossed legs and arms stretched out wide.

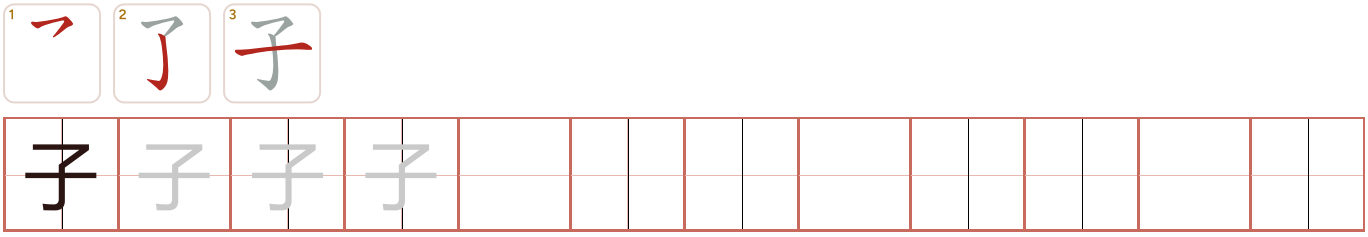


子

zǐ · child

1. Stroke 1: 横撇, a short horizontal that turns down to the left.
2. Stroke 2: 弯钩, a gently curved line down the middle with a hook to the left.
3. Stroke 3: 横, a long line across the middle.

★ A baby wrapped in a blanket, arms stretched out for a hug.



WATCH OUT

In 木 the last stroke is a long 捺. When 木 sits on the left of another character, as in 林 lín, it gets squeezed and that stroke becomes a short dot.

Your new characters

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
小	xiǎo	small 大小 (dàxiǎo) — size
中	zhōng	middle 中国 (Zhōngguó) — China
山	shān	mountain 火山 (huǒshān) — volcano
水	shuǐ	water 山水 (shānshuǐ) — landscape
火	huǒ	fire 火山 (huǒshān) — volcano

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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
木	mù	tree, wood 木头 (mùtou) — wood (material)
女	nǚ	woman, female 女人 (nǚrén) — woman
子	zǐ	child, son 子女 (zǐnǚ) — sons and daughters

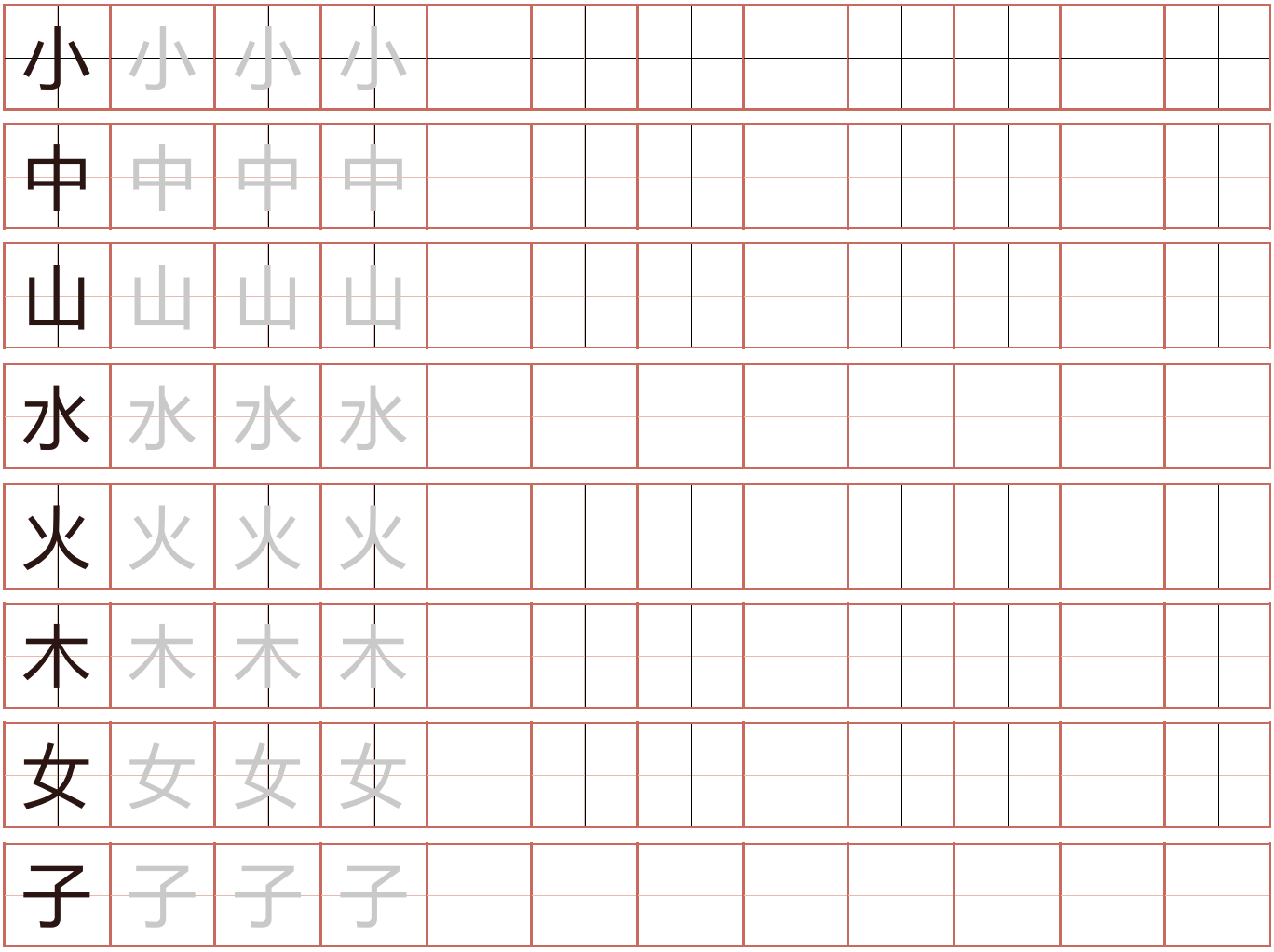
MEMORY TRICK

火 + 山 = 火山 huǒshān, a "fire mountain": a volcano! And 山 + 水 = 山水, "mountains and water", the word for a landscape (and for classic Chinese landscape painting).

CULTURE NOTE

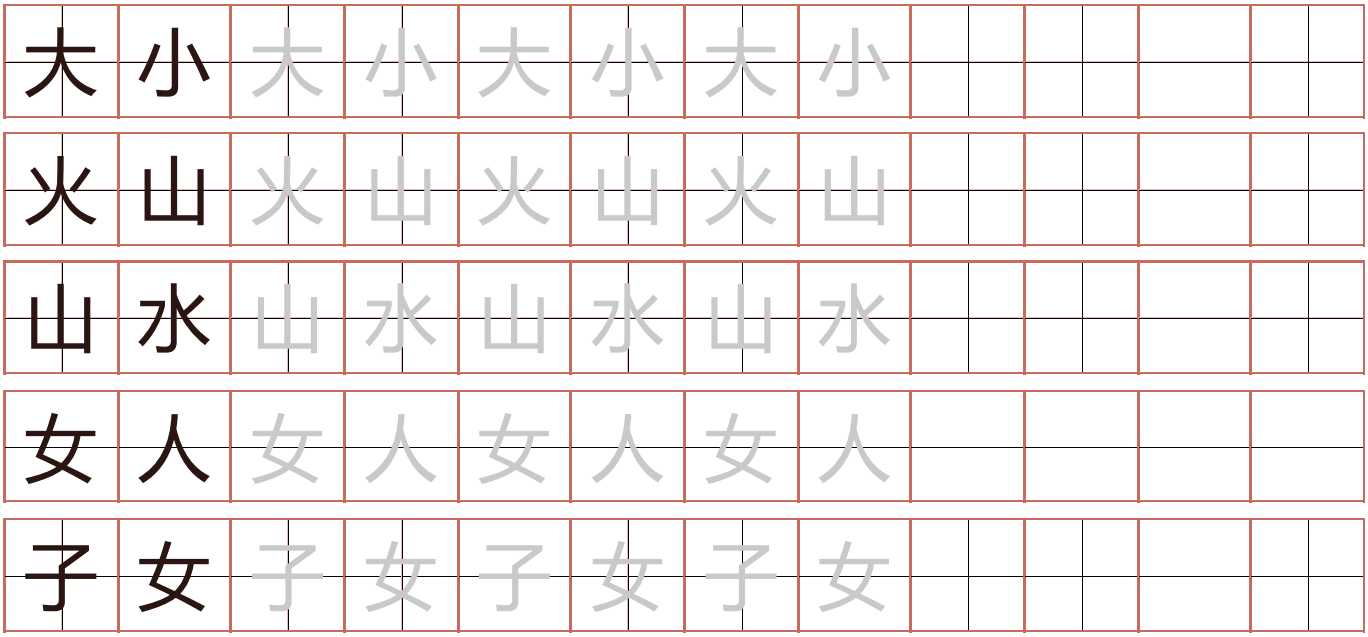
女 + 子 makes 好 hǎo (good). One old explanation: a woman with her child is a good thing.

Watch the first stroke: 小 and 水 start in the middle.



Keep both characters the same size, each in its own square.

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Read the characters and words aloud.

小 中 山 水

火 木 女 子

大小 火山 山水

女人 子女 中国

Quick quiz

QUIZ

27. Listen. Which character is it? (listen in the web app: 水)

- ○ A) 火
- ○ B) 水
- ○ C) 山
- ○ D) 木

28. What is the first stroke of 小?

- ○ A) The left dot
- ○ B) The right dot
- ○ C) A horizontal
- ○ D) The middle hook

29. What is the last stroke of 中?

- ○ A) The bottom line
- ○ B) The left side
- ○ C) The top line
- ○ D) The long middle vertical

30. 火山 means...

- ○ A) campfire
- ○ B) volcano
- ○ C) mountain water
- ○ D) big fire

31. Which character means "woman"?

- ○ A) 子
- ○ B) 大
- ○ C) 女
- ○ D) 人

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32. How many strokes does 山 have?

- ○ A) 3
- ○ B) 4
- ○ C) 2
- ○ D) 5

33. Which two characters make 好 (good)?

- ○ A) 人 + 木
- ○ B) 日 + 月
- ○ C) 女 + 子
- ○ D) 小 + 大

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UNIT 2 · LESSON 6 · 15 MINUTES

Common Radicals

The meaning parts that unlock thousands of characters

- Recognise ten common radicals
- Guess the meaning area of a new character
- Write the radicals in the correct stroke order

A **radical** (部首 bùshǒu) is the part of a character that hints at its meaning. Dictionaries are organised by radicals, and once you know the common ones, new characters stop looking like random strokes.

Ten radicals to know

Radical	Name	Meaning area	Examples
氵	sāndiǎnshuǐ · "three drops of water"	water, liquids	河 hé river, 海 hǎi sea, 洗 xǐ to wash
亻	dānrénpáng · "person side"	people	你 nǐ you, 他 tā he, 休 xiū rest
口	kǒuzìpáng · "mouth side"	mouth, speaking, eating	吃 chī eat, 喝 hē drink, 叫 jiào call
女	nǚzìpáng · "woman side"	women, family	妈 mā mum, 姐 jiě big sister, 她 tā she
木	mùzìpáng · "tree side"	trees, wood	树 shù tree, 林 lín woods, 桌 zhuō table
心 / 忄	xīnzìdǐ / shùxīnpáng · "heart"	feelings, thinking	想 xiǎng think, 忙 máng busy, 快 kuài fast
讠	yánzìpáng · "speech side"	speech, words	说 shuō speak, 话 huà words, 请 qǐng please
扌	tíshǒupáng · "hand side"	hand actions	打 dǎ hit, 找 zhǎo look for, 拉 lā pull
艹	cǎozìtóu · "grass top"	plants	花 huā flower, 茶 chá tea, 草 cǎo grass
宀	bǎogàitóu · "roof top"	houses, shelter	家 jiā home, 字 zì character, 安 ān peace

MEMORY TRICK

氵 is three drops of water sliding down a window. 亻 is a person standing sideways. 扌 is a hand with fingers spread. 艹 is two little sprouts. 宀 is a roof with a chimney.



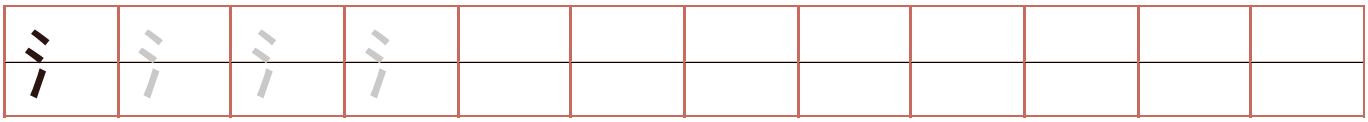
water radical

1. Stroke 1: 点, a dot at the top.
2. Stroke 2: 点, a second dot below it.
3. Stroke 3: 提, a rising stroke flicking up to the right.

★ Three drops: drip, drip, splash!

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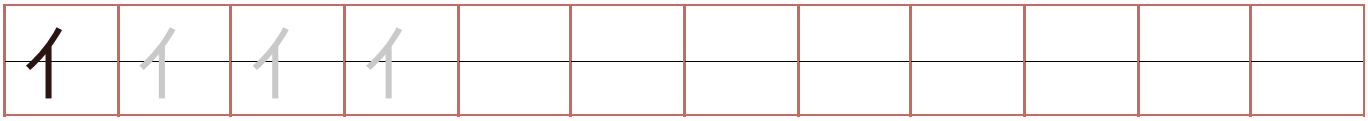
亻

person radical

1. Stroke 1: 撇, a short stroke down to the left.
2. Stroke 2: 竖, a vertical line hanging from the middle of the 撇.

★ A person standing sideways to make room for a friend.





讠

speech radical

1. Stroke 1: 点, a dot.
2. Stroke 2: 横折提, a short horizontal, down, then flick up to the right, all in one stroke.

★ A mouth (the dot) and the words coming out.





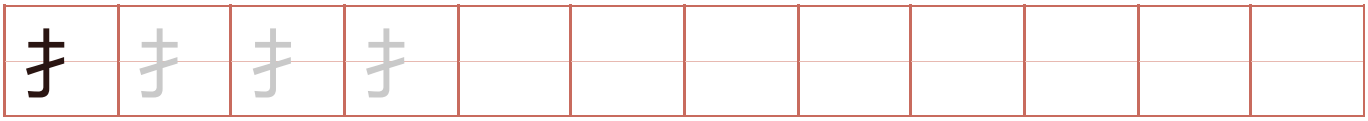
扌

hand radical

1. Stroke 1: 横, a short horizontal.
2. Stroke 2: 竖钩, a vertical line with a hook to the left.
3. Stroke 3: 提, a rising stroke crossing the 竖 from lower left to upper right.

★ A hand ready to grab something.





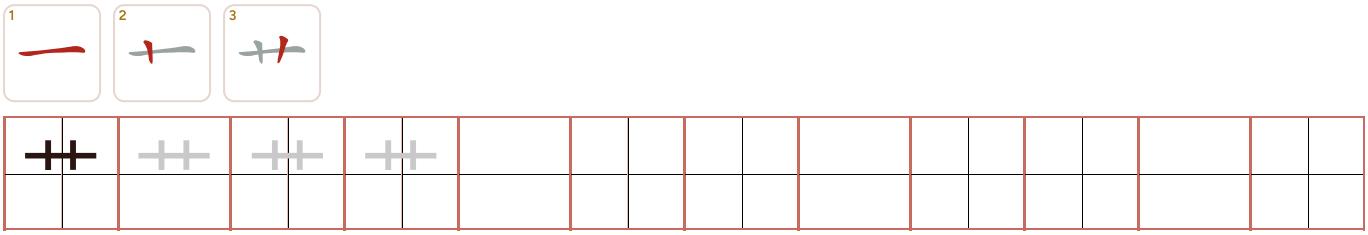
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grass radical

1. Stroke 1: 横, a horizontal.
2. Stroke 2: 竖, a short vertical on the left.
3. Stroke 3: 竖, a short vertical on the right.

★ Two blades of grass poking through the ground. In mainland China it is written with 3 strokes.

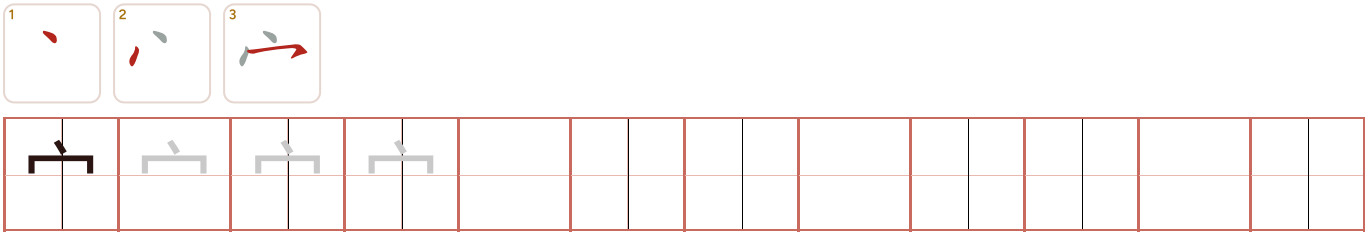




roof radical

1. Stroke 1: 点, a dot on top (the chimney).
2. Stroke 2: 点, a short dot on the left.
3. Stroke 3: 横钩, a horizontal across with a hook down at the right.

★ A roof with a chimney: 宀 + 子 = 字, a child under a roof learning characters.

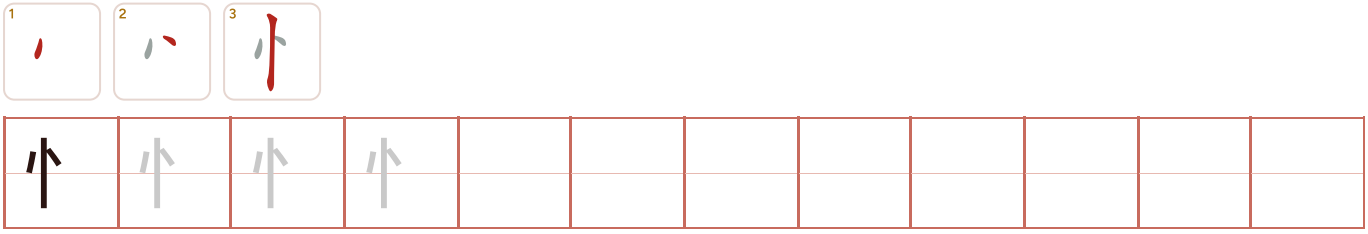




heart radical (side form)

1. Stroke 1: 点, a short dot on the left.
2. Stroke 2: 点, a short dot on the right.
3. Stroke 3: 竖, a long vertical line down the middle.

★ 心 stands up straight when it sits on the side: a heart beating with feelings.



Words grouped by radical

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
河	hé	river ;
洗	xǐ	to wash ;

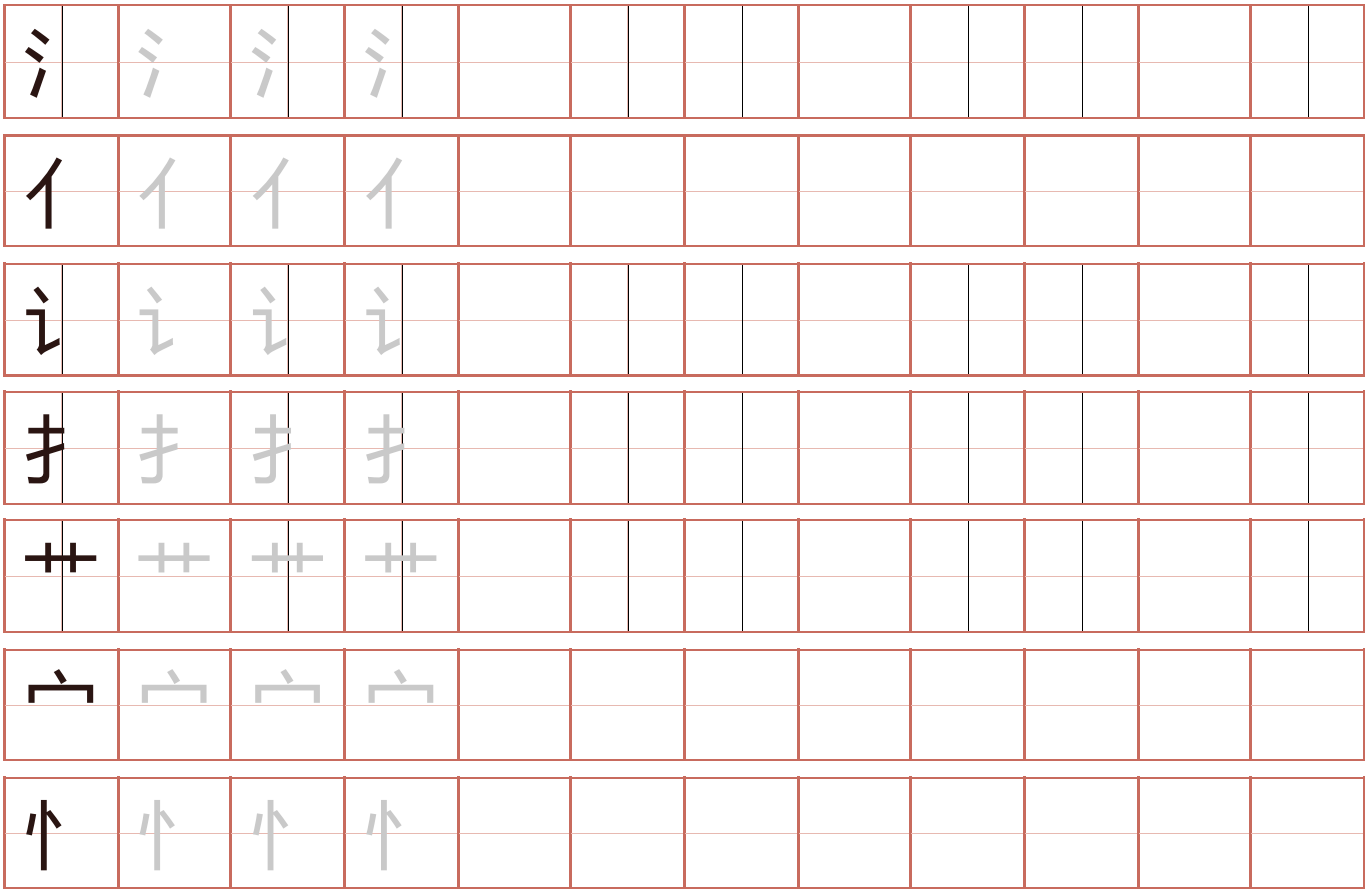
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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
你	nǐ	you 亻
吃	chī	to eat 口
妈	mā	mum 女
树	shù	tree 木
想	xiǎng	to think; to want 心
说	shuō	to speak 讠
打	dǎ	to hit; to play (ball) 扌
花	huā	flower ⺾
家	jiā	home, family 宀

TIP

A radical gives the **area** of meaning, not the exact meaning. 忙 (busy) has the heart radical: being busy is a state of mind!

Radicals are usually written narrow or flat, because they share a square with another part.



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Read each group. Say the radical they share.

河 海 洗

你 他 休

吃 喝 叫

妈 姐 她

说 话 请

花 茶 草

家 字 安

Quick quiz

QUIZ

34. A character with 氵 probably has to do with...

- ○ A) water
- ○ B) people
- ○ C) plants
- ○ D) speech

35. Which radical is in 说, 话 and 请?

- ○ A) 氵
- ○ B) 扌
- ○ C) 亻
- ○ D) 讠

36. 花 (flower) has which radical?

- ○ A) 宀
- ○ B) 艹
- ○ C) 木
- ○ D) 口

37. Which character has the "person" radical?

- ○ A) 她
- ○ B) 他
- ○ C) 吃
- ○ D) 河

38. The radical 宀 shows...

- ○ A) a hand
- ○ B) a heart
- ○ C) a mouth
- ○ D) a roof

39. 打 (to hit) has the hand radical. What does a radical tell you?

- ○ A) The general area of meaning
- ○ B) The exact pronunciation
- ○ C) The tone
- ○ D) The stroke count

40. Which radical is a form of 心 (heart)?

- ○ A) 亻
- ○ B) 讠
- ○ C) 忄
- ○ D) 扌

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好

UNIT 2 · LESSON 7 · 15 MINUTES

Building Characters from Parts

Shapes, idea combinations and sound families

- Recognise left-right, top-bottom and enclosed shapes
- Read idea combinations like 休 and 明
- Use sound parts to guess pronunciation

Most characters are built like Lego: two or three parts snapped together in a square. Learn the parts and the ways they fit, and every new character becomes a little puzzle you can solve.

How parts fit together

Shape	How the parts fit	Examples
left + right	two parts side by side	你 好 林 妈
top + bottom	one part above another	字 花 想 家
left + middle + right	three parts side by side	树 谢
full enclosure	a box around the inside	国 回 四
half enclosure	a frame on two or three sides	这 同 医

TIP

Every character fits in an imaginary square, no matter how many strokes it has. A part on the left gets thin; a part on top gets flat.

Idea combinations

Put meanings together and a new meaning appears.

休
xiū
to rest
亻 person + 木 tree: resting against a tree

明
míng
bright
日 sun + 月 moon: the brightest things in the sky

好
hǎo
good
女 woman + 子 child

林
lín
woods
木 + 木: two trees

森
sēn
forest
木 + 木 + 木: many trees

从
cóng
from; to follow
人 + 人: one person following another

众
zhòng
crowd
人 + 人 + 人: lots of people

尖
jiān
pointed, sharp
小 small on top + 大 big below

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男
nán
man, male
田 field + 力 strength: working in the fields

安
ān
peace, safe
宀 roof + 女 woman

MEMORY TRICK
尖 is the easiest one ever: small on top of big makes a point, like the tip of a pencil.

Sound families

Characters that share a sound part often sound similar. The meaning part on the side tells them apart.

How to say it: Same sound part 马, different radicals: 女 woman, 口 mouth, 石 stone…

马 mǎ · horse
妈 mā · mum
吗 ma · question word
骂 mà · to scold
码 mǎ · code, number

The 青 family

Character	Pinyin	Meaning part	Meaning
青	qīng	(the sound part)	blue-green; young
清	qīng	氵 water	clear (like water)
晴	qíng	日 sun	sunny
请	qǐng	讠 speech	please; to invite
情	qíng	忄 heart	feeling
睛	jīng	目 eye	eyeball

WATCH OUT
Sound parts give a hint, not a guarantee. Tones often differ, and sometimes the sound has changed a lot over the centuries: 睛 is jīng, not qīng.

The 包 family

Character	Pinyin	Meaning part	Meaning
包	bāo	(the sound part)	bag; to wrap
饱	bǎo	饣 food	full (after eating)
跑	pǎo	足 foot (squeezed on the left)	to run
抱	bào	扌 hand	to hug
泡	pào	氵 water	to soak; bubble

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Read each family. Notice how similar they sound.

马 妈 吗 骂

青 清 晴 请 情

包 饱 跑 抱 泡

休 明 林 森 尖

Quick quiz

QUIZ

41. What does 明 (sun + moon) mean?

- ○ A) bright
- ○ B) night
- ○ C) month
- ○ D) sky

42. 晴 has 日 on the left. It probably means...

- ○ A) clear water
- ○ B) feeling
- ○ C) sunny
- ○ D) please

43. In 请 (please), what does 青 give?

- ○ A) The meaning
- ○ B) The sound
- ○ C) The tone
- ○ D) Nothing

44. 尖 means "pointed" because...

- ○ A) it has a sharp hook
- ○ B) it looks like a knife
- ○ C) it is a pictograph of a pen
- ○ D) small sits on top of big

45. Which shape is 国?

- ○ A) left + right
- ○ B) top + bottom
- ○ C) half enclosure
- ○ D) full enclosure

46. Which character is about running (with a foot radical)?

- ○ A) 抱
- ○ B) 跑
- ○ C) 饱
- ○ D) 泡

47. 众 (three people) means...

- ○ A) family
- ○ B) to follow
- ○ C) crowd
- ○ D) one person

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UNIT 2 · LESSON 8 · 8 MINUTES

Simplified and Traditional Characters

Two ways of writing the same language

- Know where each system is used
- Recognise a few common pairs
- Understand how characters were simplified

There are two standard sets of Chinese characters. This course teaches **Simplified** characters, used in mainland China. It is useful to know that **Traditional** characters exist too.

Two systems

Feature	Simplified 简体字	Traditional 繁體字
Used in	mainland China, Singapore, Malaysia	Taiwan, Hong Kong, Macau, many overseas communities
Since	officially from the 1950s–60s	the older standard forms
Strokes	fewer	more

Common pairs

Simplified	Traditional	Pinyin	Meaning
马	馬	mǎ	horse
门	門	mén	door
车	車	chē	vehicle
说	說	shuō	to speak
国	國	guó	country
学	學	xué	to study
书	書	shū	book
龙	龍	lóng	dragon

How characters were simplified

1

Shorter components

说

shuō

to speak

A common part gets a short form: 言 → 讠, 馬 → 马, 門 → 门.

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2 **Handwriting shapes**

书

shū

book

Flowing handwritten forms became standard: 書 → 书, 東 → 东.

3 **Keeping just a part**

声

shēng

sound

Only part of the old character remains: 聲 → 声.

4 **A simpler sound part**

远

yuǎn

far

A sound part with fewer strokes replaced the old one: 遠 → 远.

DID YOU KNOW?

The dragon 龙 has 5 strokes in Simplified, but 龍 has 16 in Traditional!

CULTURE NOTE

A popular joke: Traditional 愛 (love) has a heart 心 inside, but Simplified 爱 lost it and gained 友 (friend) instead. Love without a heart, but with a friend!

TIP

Good news: all 17 characters you learned in this unit (一 二 三 十 人 口 日 月 大 小 中 山 水 火 木 女 子) are the same in both systems. Pinyin and the spoken language are also the same.

Read the simplified characters aloud.

马 门 车

说 国 学

书 龙 爱

Quick quiz

QUIZ

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48. Which character set does mainland China use?

- ○ A) Simplified
- ○ B) Traditional
- ○ C) Both equally
- ○ D) Neither

49. Where are Traditional characters used?

- ○ A) Beijing and Shanghai
- ○ B) Singapore
- ○ C) Taiwan and Hong Kong
- ○ D) Only in old books

50. What is the Simplified form of 門?

- ○ A) 门
- ○ B) 问
- ○ C) 们
- ○ D) 间

51. Which pair matches?

- ○ A) 学 / 書
- ○ B) 马 / 龍
- ○ C) 说 / 車
- ○ D) 国 / 國

52. Simplified characters usually have...

- ○ A) more strokes
- ○ B) fewer strokes
- ○ C) different sounds
- ○ D) no radicals

53. Are 人 and 山 different in Traditional?

- ○ A) Yes, both changed
- ○ B) No, they are the same
- ○ C) Only 人 changed
- ○ D) Only 山 changed

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UNIT 2 · LESSON 9 · 15 MINUTES

Copywork and Dictation

Write, listen, and check yourself

- Copy characters neatly in the correct order
- Write characters from dictation
- Check your progress

Practice makes characters stick. In this lesson you copy, then write from memory, then check yourself. A few minutes every day works much better than one long session.

A five-step routine

1 Look
Study the character. Find its parts and count its strokes.

2 Trace
Trace it in the grid, saying each stroke name.

3 Copy
Write it by yourself, looking at the model.

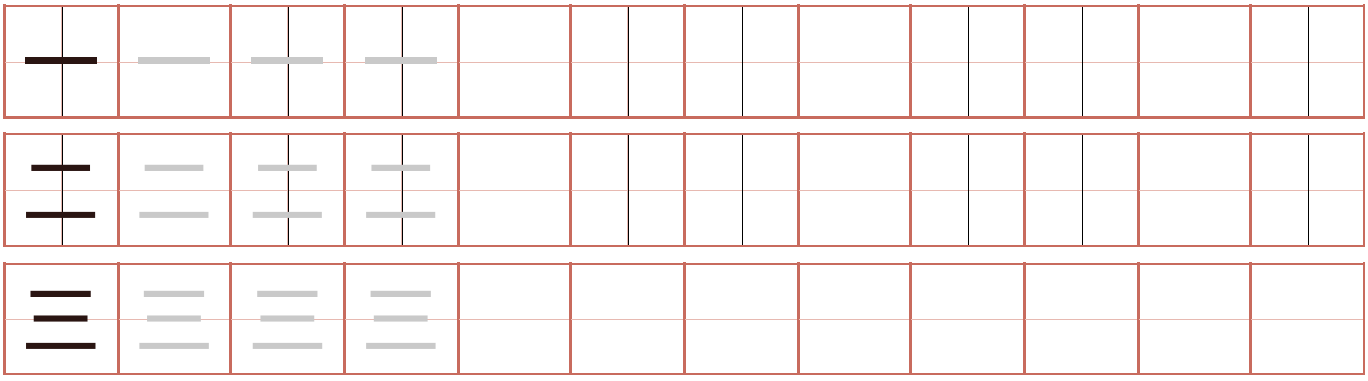
4 Recall
Cover the model and write it from memory.

5 Use
Write a word with it, and say it aloud with the right tone.

TIP

Keep each character in its own square, centred and balanced. Write strokes firmly; do not go back over them.

Copywork: all 17 characters from this unit.



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十 十 十 十

人 人 人 人

口 口 口 口

日 日 日 日

月 月 月 月

大 大 大 大

小 小 小 小

中 中 中 中

山 山 山 山

水 水 水 水

火 火 火 火

木 木 木 木

女 女 女 女

子 子 子 子

Copy each word. Say it aloud as you write.

大 人 大 人 大 人 大 人

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人	口	人	口	人	口	人	口								
日	子	日	子	日	子	日	子								
大	小	大	小	大	小	大	小								
火	山	火	山	火	山	火	山								
山	水	山	水	山	水	山	水								
女	人	女	人	女	人	女	人								
子	女	子	女	子	女	子	女								
一	月	一	月	一	月	一	月								

十二月 十二月 十二月

Write each line in one go. 三月十一日 means "11 March".

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三月十一日

三月十一日

二月二十日

二月二十日

大山小山

大山小山

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日月山水

日月山水

MEMORY TRICK

Before writing from memory, close your eyes and "see" the character with its memory picture: the campfire 火, the three peaks 山, the arrow through the target 中.

Dictation: listen and write the characters

A teacher or friend reads each item aloud, or press "Listen" in the web app. Write what you hear; answers are at the end of the unit.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____

Check yourself

- ☐ I can name the eight basic strokes.
- ☐ I know the seven stroke-order rules.
- ☐ I can write all 17 characters from memory in the correct order.
- ☐ I can recognise the ten common radicals.
- ☐ I can explain how 妈 gets its meaning and its sound.
- ☐ I know the difference between Simplified and Traditional characters.

Give your work today some stars ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆

Quick quiz

QUIZ

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54. Listen. Which character is it? (listen in the web app: 火)

- ○ A) 水
- ○ B) 大
- ○ C) 人
- ○ D) 火

55. Listen. Which word is it? (listen in the web app: 山水)

- ○ A) 山水
- ○ B) 火山
- ○ C) 大小
- ○ D) 日子

56. Which character has 4 strokes?

- ○ A) 口
- ○ B) 人
- ○ C) 木
- ○ D) 山

57. Which character has only 2 strokes?

- ○ A) 人
- ○ B) 大
- ○ C) 女
- ○ D) 子

58. 日子 means...

- ○ A) Sunday
- ○ B) son
- ○ C) day; life
- ○ D) sunshine

59. What is the best way to learn characters?

- ○ A) One long session a month
- ○ B) A little practice every day
- ○ C) Only reading pinyin
- ○ D) Guessing the strokes

60. 三月十一日 is the date...

- ○ A) 3 November
- ○ B) 31 January
- ○ C) 13 March
- ○ D) 11 March

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UNIT 2

Answer key

Dictation

1. 山 (shān)
2. 水 (shuǐ)
3. 火 (huǒ)
4. 人 (rén)
5. 中 (zhōng)
6. 大小 (dàxiǎo)
7. 火山 (huǒshān)
8. 三月 (sānyuè)

Quiz

1. C) one syllable with a meaning
2. A) 山
3. D) sun + moon
4. B) 马
5. B) a meaning part + a sound part
6. D) a person by a tree
7. A) Left to right
8. C) 撇 piě
9. A) 提 tí
10. C) One
11. B) One pen movement before lifting
12. D) 撇 then 捺
13. D) The horizontal
14. B) 撇 (down-left)
15. C) Last
16. A) The middle hook
17. C) Left to right
18. A) Faster, better-balanced, readable writing
19. D) 6
20. B) 日
21. B) 大
22. D) 3
23. A) The middle line
24. C) March
25. A) The middle one
26. C) twenty
27. B) 水
28. D) The middle hook
29. D) The long middle vertical
30. B) volcano
31. C) 女
32. A) 3
33. C) 女 + 子
34. A) water
35. D) 讠
36. B) 艹
37. B) 他
38. D) a roof
39. A) The general area of meaning
40. C) 忄
41. A) bright
42. C) sunny
43. B) The sound
44. D) small sits on top of big
45. D) full enclosure
46. B) 跑
47. C) crowd
48. A) Simplified
49. C) Taiwan and Hong Kong
50. A) 门
51. D) 国 / 國
52. B) fewer strokes
53. B) No, they are the same
54. D) 火
55. A) 山水
56. C) 木
57. A) 人
58. C) day; life

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59. B) A little practice every day

60. D) 11 March

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UNIT 3

First Words & Phrases

Greetings, numbers, money, time, family, food and getting around

1. Greetings & Politeness
2. Introducing Yourself
3. Numbers 0–10 & Hand Signs
4. Numbers to 100 & Money
5. Dates & Time
6. Family
7. Food & Drink
8. Colours
9. Places & Transport
10. Everyday Objects

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你好

UNIT 3 · LESSON 1 · 12 MINUTES

Greetings & Politeness

Hello, goodbye, thank you and sorry

- Greet people politely
- Say thank you and sorry
- Answer 'How are you?'
- Say goodbye

Time for your first real Chinese words! Greetings in Mandarin are short, friendly and easy to say. Tap any word to hear it, then copy the voice out loud.

Hello and goodbye

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
你好	nǐ hǎo	hello 亻 person 你好！我是安娜。(Nǐ hǎo! Wǒ shì Ānnà.) — Hello! I'm Anna.
您好	nín hǎo	hello (polite) 心 heart 老师，您好！(Lǎoshī, nín hǎo!) — Hello, teacher!
你们好	nǐmen hǎo	hello, everyone 亻 person
早上好	zǎoshang hǎo	good morning 日 sun
晚上好	wǎnshang hǎo	good evening 日 sun
晚安	wǎn'ān	good night (before bed) 宀 roof
再见	zàijiàn	goodbye 见 see
明天见	míngtiān jiàn	see you tomorrow 见 see

MEMORY TRICK

再见 is literally 'again see'. You can swap in a time: 明天见 = 'tomorrow see' = see you tomorrow!

TIP

Two third tones together: the first one rises. So 你好 sounds like 'ní hǎo'. The pinyin still writes nǐ hǎo, so just let your voice do it.

CULTURE NOTE

Use 您 instead of 你 for teachers, older people and customers. It shows respect. With friends and classmates, 你 is perfect.

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你好吗?

你	好	吗
you	good, well	(turns it into a question)

Nǐ hǎo ma?

How are you?

Use it with people you already know. With a stranger, a simple 你好！ is enough.

Answering 'How are you?'

我很好。	还可以。	不太好。	你呢?
Wǒ hěn hǎo.	Hái kěyǐ.	Bú tài hǎo.	Nǐ ne?
I'm fine.	Not bad. / OK.	Not so good.	And you?

Magic words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
谢谢	xièxie	thank you 讠 speech 谢谢你！ (Xièxie nǐ!) — Thank you!
不客气	bú kèqi	you're welcome 宀 roof
不用谢	búyòng xiè	no need to thank me 讠 speech
对不起	duìbuqǐ	sorry 寸 inch
没关系	méi guānxi	it's OK, never mind 氵 water
请	qǐng	please (inviting, asking politely) 讠 speech 请坐！ (Qǐng zuò!) — Please sit down!
请问	qǐngwèn	excuse me, may I ask... 讠 speech

TIP

不 is normally bù, but before a fourth tone it changes to bú: 不客气 = bú kèqi. In this course we always write the tone you actually say.

CULTURE NOTE

Close friends and family say 谢谢 less than English speakers say 'thanks'. Too many thank-yous can sound a little distant. With shop staff, teachers and strangers, always say it!

DID YOU KNOW?

Older neighbours sometimes greet each other with 你吃了吗? (Have you eaten?). It is just a friendly 'hi', not a dinner invitation!

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At school

Xiaoming 王老师，您好！
Wáng lǎoshī, nín hǎo!
Hello, Teacher Wang!

Teacher Wang 你好，小明！你好吗？
Nǐ hǎo, Xiǎomíng! Nǐ hǎo ma?
Hi, Xiaoming! How are you?

Xiaoming 我很好，谢谢。您呢？
Wǒ hěn hǎo, xièxie. Nín ne?
I'm fine, thanks. And you?

Teacher Wang 我也很好。
Wǒ yě hěn hǎo.
I'm fine too.

Xiaoming 老师，再见！
Lǎoshī, zàijiàn!
Goodbye, teacher!

Teacher Wang 明天见！
Míngtiān jiàn!
See you tomorrow!

Read each line aloud. Tap a word if you need to hear it again.

你好！

您好！

你好吗？

我很好，谢谢。你呢？

对不起！　没关系。

谢谢！　不客气。

再见！　明天见！

Quick quiz

QUIZ

1. Listen. What does it mean? (listen in the web app: 谢谢)
   - ○ A) Thank you
   - ○ B) Hello
   - ○ C) Sorry
   - ○ D) Goodbye
2. Someone says 谢谢 to you. What do you answer?
   - ○ A) 没关系
   - ○ B) 不客气
   - ○ C) 早上好
   - ○ D) 再见

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3. Which hello is more polite, for an older person?

- ○ A) 你好
- ○ B) 你们好
- ○ C) 晚安
- ○ D) 您好

4. 对不起 means...

- ○ A) Please
- ○ B) Sorry
- ○ C) Good night
- ○ D) Thank you

5. Listen. When do you say this? (listen in the web app: 晚安)

- ○ A) At bedtime
- ○ B) When you're sorry
- ○ C) In the morning
- ○ D) At lunchtime

6. How do you say 'See you tomorrow'?

- ○ A) 早上好
- ○ B) 晚上好
- ○ C) 再见了
- ○ D) 明天见

7. What does 你呢？ mean?

- ○ A) Where are you?
- ○ B) Are you OK?
- ○ C) And you?
- ○ D) Who are you?

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我

UNIT 3 · LESSON 2 · 14 MINUTES

Introducing Yourself

Your name, your country, nice to meet you

- Say your name with 我叫…
- Ask someone's name
- Say where you are from
- Say 'nice to meet you'

Let's introduce ourselves! With just three short patterns you can tell people your name, where you are from and that you are happy to meet them.

我叫李明。

我	叫	李明
I	am called	Li Ming (a name)

Wǒ jiào Lǐ Míng.

My name is Li Ming.

叫 means 'to be called'. Put your own name at the end.

你叫什么名字?

你	叫	什么	名字
you	are called	what	name

Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?

What's your name?

Word for word: 'You are called what name?'

MEMORY TRICK

Chinese questions don't flip the word order. The question word sits exactly where the answer goes: 你叫什么名字? → 我叫李明。

Words for meeting people

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
名字	míngzi	name 口 mouth
叫	jiào	to be called; to call 口 mouth 我叫安娜。(Wǒ jiào Ānnà.) — My name is Anna.
姓	xìng	surname; to be surnamed 女 woman 我姓王。(Wǒ xìng Wáng.) — My surname is Wang.

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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
是	shì	to be (am, is, are) 日 sun
人	rén	person, people 人 person
学生	xuésheng	student 子 child
老师	lǎoshī	teacher 巾 cloth
朋友	péngyou	friend 月 moon
认识	rènshi	to know (a person), to meet 讠 speech
高兴	gāoxìng	happy, glad 八 eight

很高兴认识你。

很 very | 高兴 glad | 认识 to meet, to know | 你 you

Hěn gāoxìng rènshi nǐ.

Nice to meet you.

Reply with 我也很高兴认识你 (I'm glad to meet you too).

CULTURE NOTE

Chinese names put the **family name first**. In 王丽 (Wáng Lì), Wang is the surname and Li is the given name. The most common surnames are 王, 李, 张, 刘 and 陈.

The polite way

您贵姓?

Nín guì xìng?

May I ask your surname? (polite)

我姓王，叫王丽。

Wǒ xìng Wáng, jiào Wáng Lì.

My surname is Wang; my full name is Wang Li.

Countries

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
中国	Zhōngguó	China 口 enclosure
美国	Měiguó	the USA 口 enclosure
英国	Yīngguó	the UK 口 enclosure

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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
加拿大	Jiānádà	Canada
澳大利亚	Àodàlìyà	Australia
法国	Fǎguó	France 囗 enclosure
德国	Déguó	Germany 囗 enclosure
日本	Rìběn	Japan 日 sun
印度	Yìndù	India

你是哪国人?

你	是	哪	国	人
you	are	which	country	person

Nǐ shì nǎ guó rén?

Which country are you from?

Literally 'You are which-country person?'

Country + 人 = nationality

Add 人 (person) after a country and you get the nationality.

中国人	美国人	英国人
Zhōngguó rén	Měiguó rén	Yīngguó rén

我是美国人。
Wǒ shì Měiguó rén.
I'm American.

她是中国人。
Tā shì Zhōngguó rén.
She is Chinese.

我是学生。
Wǒ shì xuésheng.
I'm a student.

First meeting

Anna 你好！我叫安娜。你叫什么名字?
Nǐ hǎo! Wǒ jiào Ānnà. Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?
Hi! I'm Anna. What's your name?

Li Ming 我叫李明。很高兴认识你!
Wǒ jiào Lǐ Míng. Hěn gāoxìng rènshi nǐ!
I'm Li Ming. Nice to meet you!

Anna 我也很高兴认识你。
Wǒ yě hěn gāoxìng rènshi nǐ.
Nice to meet you too.

Li Ming 你是哪国人?
Nǐ shì nǎ guó rén?
Where are you from?

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Anna 我是英国人。你是中国人吗?
Wǒ shì Yīngguó rén. Nǐ shì Zhōngguó rén ma?
I'm British. Are you Chinese?

Li Ming 对，我是中国人。我是学生。
Duì, wǒ shì Zhōngguó rén. Wǒ shì xuésheng.
Yes, I'm Chinese. I'm a student.

Your introduction in 4 steps

1 **Say hello**
你好!
Nǐ hǎo!
Hello!

2 **Give your name**
我叫……
Wǒ jiào ...
My name is ...

3 **Say where you are from**
我是……人。
Wǒ shì ... rén.
I'm from ...

4 **Be friendly**
很高兴认识你!
Hěn gāoxìng rènshi nǐ!
Nice to meet you!

Read these aloud, then say them again with your own name and country.

我叫李明。

你叫什么名字?

我姓王。

我是美国人。

你是哪国人?

很高兴认识你!

Quick quiz

QUIZ

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8. How do you ask 'What's your name?'

- ○ A) 你是哪国人?
- ○ B) 你是学生吗?
- ○ C) 你叫什么名字?
- ○ D) 你好吗?

9. 我是英国人 means...

- ○ A) I'm a teacher.
- ○ B) I'm Chinese.
- ○ C) I live in England.
- ○ D) I'm British.

10. In the name 张伟 (Zhāng Wěi), which part is the surname?

- ○ A) Neither
- ○ B) Both
- ○ C) 张
- ○ D) 伟

11. Listen. What did you hear? (listen in the web app: 很高兴认识你)

- ○ A) Where are you from?
- ○ B) What's your name?
- ○ C) Nice to meet you.
- ○ D) See you tomorrow.

12. Which word means 'friend'?

- ○ A) 名字
- ○ B) 学生
- ○ C) 朋友
- ○ D) 老师

13. How do you say 'Japanese person'?

- ○ A) 人日本
- ○ B) 是日本
- ○ C) 日本人
- ○ D) 日本国

14. Listen. Which word means 'to be called'? (listen in the web app: 叫)

- ○ A) 叫
- ○ B) 姓
- ○ C) 人
- ○ D) 是

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八

UNIT 3 · LESSON 3 · 12 MINUTES

Numbers 0–10 & Hand Signs

Count to ten with your voice and one hand

- Count from 0 to 10
- Use Chinese hand signs for 6–10
- Know when 一 changes its tone
- Know the lucky and unlucky numbers

Chinese numbers are short, clear and very logical. Learn these eleven and you can already count to 99 in the next lesson!

Zero to ten

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
零	líng	0, zero 雨 rain
一	yī	1, one 一 one
二	èr	2, two 二 two
三	sān	3, three
四	sì	4, four 口 enclosure
五	wǔ	5, five
六	liù	6, six 八 eight
七	qī	7, seven
八	bā	8, eight 八 eight
九	jiǔ	9, nine
十	shí	10, ten 十 ten
两	liǎng	two (before a measure word) 两个人 (liǎng gè rén) — two people

MEMORY TRICK

One, two and three are just lines: 一 二 三. 十 is a cross, like a plus sign. 八 looks like two lines spreading apart.

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WATCH OUT

Listen carefully: 四 (sì, 4) and 十 (shí, 10) sound close. Sì is a short falling 'ss'; shí rises and has the 'sh' sound.

Count on one hand

Number	Chinese	Pinyin	Hand sign
1	一	yī	Index finger up
2	二	èr	Index and middle finger up
3	三	sān	Middle, ring and little finger up
4	四	sì	Four fingers up, thumb folded in
5	五	wǔ	Open hand
6	六	liù	Thumb and little finger out
7	七	qī	Fingertips of thumb, index and middle finger pinched together
8	八	bā	Thumb and index finger out, like an L
9	九	jiǔ	Index finger bent into a hook
10	十	shí	A fist, or two index fingers crossed like 十

CULTURE NOTE

Chinese people count to ten on **one hand**. You will see these signs at markets and in noisy places. Some regions use small variations, but these are the most common.

The tone of 一 changes

When counting, in dates and at the end of a number, 一 is yī. Before a fourth tone it becomes yí. Before tones 1, 2 and 3 it becomes yì.

一个 yí gè　一天 yì tiān　一年 yì nián　一百 yìbǎi　十一 shíyī

TIP

When people read out phone numbers or room numbers, they often say yāo for 1, so it is not confused with 七 (qī). Room 101 = 'yāo líng yāo'.

DID YOU KNOW?

八 (bā) is the luckiest number because it sounds like 发 (fā, to get rich). The Beijing Olympics opened on 8/8/2008 at 8:08 p.m.! 四 (sì) is unlucky because it sounds like 死 (sǐ, to die), so some buildings skip the 4th floor.

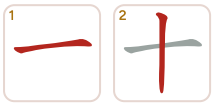
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十

shí — ten

1. Draw a horizontal line from left to right.
2. Draw a vertical line from top to bottom, crossing the middle.

★ Horizontal before vertical is one of the basic stroke-order rules.



Copy each number. Say it out loud as you write.

一 一 一 一

二 二 二 二

三 三 三 三

十 十 十 十

八 八 八 八

六 六 六 六

Count out loud. Then count backwards!

一 二 三 四 五

六 七 八 九 十

十 九 八 七 六

五 四 三 二 一 零

Quick quiz

QUIZ

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15. Listen. Which number? (listen in the web app: 七)

- ○ A) 7
- ○ B) 1
- ○ C) 10
- ○ D) 4

16. Listen. Which number? (listen in the web app: 四)

- ○ A) 10
- ○ B) 5
- ○ C) 9
- ○ D) 4

17. Thumb and little finger out means...

- ○ A) 8
- ○ B) 3
- ○ C) 10
- ○ D) 6

18. Which number is lucky in China?

- ○ A) 8
- ○ B) 7
- ○ C) 4
- ○ D) 1

19. 零 is...

- ○ A) 2
- ○ B) 0
- ○ C) 6
- ○ D) 10

20. Which is the correct pinyin for 一个?

- ○ A) yǐ gè
- ○ B) yī gè
- ○ C) yì gè
- ○ D) yí gè

21. Listen. Which number? (listen in the web app: 九)

- ○ A) 5
- ○ B) 2
- ○ C) 6
- ○ D) 9

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UNIT 3 · LESSON 4 · 15 MINUTES

Numbers to 100 & Money

Count to a hundred and go shopping

- Say any number up to 100
- Use 块, 毛 and 元 for prices
- Ask 'How much is it?'
- Bargain politely at a market

If you know 1 to 10, you already know 11 to 99. Chinese numbers are built like Lego. Then we'll use them to go shopping!

Building numbers

Number	Chinese	Pinyin	How it works
11	十一	shíyī	ten + one
12	十二	shí'èr	ten + two
20	二十	èrshí	two tens
21	二十一	èrshíyī	two tens + one
35	三十五	sānshíwǔ	three tens + five
99	九十九	jiǔshíjiǔ	nine tens + nine
100	一百	yìbǎi	one hundred

Tens + 十 + units

Say the tens digit, then 十, then the units digit. Nothing else to learn!

十五 shíwǔ　四十 sìshí　六十八 liùshíbā　七十七 qīshíqī

WATCH OUT

Order matters! 十四 (shísì) is 14 but 四十 (sìshí) is 40.

Money words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
钱	qián	money 钅 metal
块	kuài	yuan (spoken) 土 earth 五块 (wǔ kuài) — five yuan

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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
元	yuán	yuan (written, on price tags)
毛	máo	0.1 yuan (spoken) 毛 fur
角	jiǎo	0.1 yuan (written)
分	fēn	0.01 yuan; minute 刀 knife
人民币	rénmínbì	RMB, Chinese money 巾 cloth
多少	duōshao	how much, how many
贵	guì	expensive 贝 shell
便宜	piányi	cheap 亻 person
买	mǎi	to buy
卖	mài	to sell 十 ten

MEMORY TRICK

买 (mǎi, buy) and 卖 (mài, sell) look alike. Selling has an extra 十 on top: you need **more** (+) to sell!

MEMORY TRICK

The radical 贝 is an old picture of a shell. Long ago shells were money, so 贵 (expensive) has a shell inside.

Reading prices

Price	Written (tag)	Spoken
¥5	五元	五块
¥0.50	五角	五毛
¥3.50	三元五角	三块五
¥2	二元	两块
¥12.80	十二元八角	十二块八

TIP

In speech you can drop the last unit: 三块五 = 3.50. And before 块 or 毛 on its own, 2 is 两: 两块, not 二块. But 12 is still 十二块.

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这个多少钱?

这个	多少	钱
this one	how much	money

Zhège duōshao qián?

How much is this?

Shopping phrases

太贵了!

Tài guì le!

Too expensive!

便宜一点儿吧。

Piányi yìdiǎnr ba.

A bit cheaper, please.

我买两个。

Wǒ mǎi liǎng gè.

I'll buy two.

一共多少钱?

Yígòng duōshao qián?

How much altogether?

At the fruit market

Customer 老板，苹果多少钱一斤?
Lǎobǎn, píngguǒ duōshao qián yì jīn?
Excuse me, how much are apples per jin?

Seller 八块一斤。
Bā kuài yì jīn.
Eight kuai a jin.

Customer 太贵了！六块吧。
Tài guì le! Liù kuài ba.
Too expensive! How about six?

Seller 七块，好吗?
Qī kuài, hǎo ma?
Seven, OK?

Customer 好，我买两斤。
Hǎo, wǒ mǎi liǎng jīn.
OK, I'll take two jin.

Seller 一共十四块。
Yígòng shísì kuài.
That's fourteen kuai altogether.

CULTURE NOTE

Fruit and vegetables are sold by the 斤 (jīn), which is 500 grams. Shop owners are often called 老板 (boss). Today most people pay by scanning a QR code with their phone, but cash still works.

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Read the numbers and prices aloud.

十一　二十　三十五　九十九　一百

五块

三块五

两块

这个多少钱?

太贵了!

Quick quiz

QUIZ

22. Listen. Which number? (listen in the web app: 四十)

- ○ A) 14
- ○ B) 4
- ○ C) 44
- ○ D) 40

23. How do you say 99?

- ○ A) 九九十
- ○ B) 十九九
- ○ C) 九十九
- ○ D) 九百九

24. How do you SAY ¥2.50 in a shop?

- ○ A) 二块五
- ○ B) 两毛五
- ○ C) 两块五
- ○ D) 二十五块

25. 多少钱? means...

- ○ A) Is it cheap?
- ○ B) How many people?
- ○ C) Where is the money?
- ○ D) How much is it?

26. Listen. What does the shopper say? (listen in the web app: 太贵了)

- ○ A) How much?
- ○ B) That's very cheap!
- ○ C) Too expensive!
- ○ D) I'll buy two of them.

27. 1 块 = how many 毛?

- ○ A) 10
- ○ B) 2
- ○ C) 5
- ○ D) 100

28. Which word means 'cheap'?

- ○ A) 卖
- ○ B) 贵
- ○ C) 钱
- ○ D) 便宜

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UNIT 3 · LESSON 5 · 15 MINUTES

Dates & Time

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Days, months, dates and telling the time

- Name the days of the week
- Say a date in Chinese order
- Ask and tell the time
- Talk about birthdays

Good news: Chinese dates and times use the numbers you already know. Monday is 'week-one', May is 'five-month'. Easy!

Days and dates

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
今天	jīntiān	today 人 person
明天	míngtiān	tomorrow 日 sun
昨天	zuótiān	yesterday 日 sun
星期	xīngqī	week 日 sun
周末	zhōumò	weekend
年	nián	year
月	yuè	month; moon 月 moon
号	hào	day of the month (spoken) 口 mouth
日	rì	day of the month (written); sun 日 sun
生日	shēngrì	birthday 日 sun

Days of the week

English	Chinese	Pinyin
Monday	星期一	xīngqīyī
Tuesday	星期二	xīngqī'èr
Wednesday	星期三	xīngqīsān
Thursday	星期四	xīngqīsì

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English	Chinese	Pinyin
Friday	星期五	xīngqīwǔ
Saturday	星期六	xīngqīliù
Sunday	星期天 / 星期日	xīngqītiān / xīngqīrì

MEMORY TRICK

Monday to Saturday are 'week + 1' to 'week + 6'. Sunday is the odd one: 'week + day' (天) or 'week + sun' (日). On signs you will also see 周一 for Monday.

Months: number + 月

一月 yīyuè January	五月 wǔyuè May	十月 shíyuè October	十二月 shí'èryuè December

Big to small

Chinese dates go from the biggest unit to the smallest: year → month → day → weekday. Years are read digit by digit.

二〇二六年 一月一日 二〇二六年一月一日，星期四

èr líng èr liù nián　yīyuè yī rì　èr líng èr liù nián yīyuè yī rì, xīngqīsì

今天几月几号?

今天	几	月	几	号
today	which (number)	month	which (number)	day

Jīntiān jǐ yuè jǐ hào?

What's the date today?

今天星期几?

今天	星期	几
today	week	which number

Jīntiān xīngqī jǐ?

What day is it today?

No 是 is needed in date sentences: 今天星期五 = Today is Friday.

Telling the time

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
现在	xiànzài	now

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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
点	diǎn	o'clock 灬 fire
分	fēn	minute 刀 knife
半	bàn	half
刻	kè	quarter of an hour 刂 knife
差	chà	to (before the hour); short of
早上	zǎoshang	early morning 日 sun
上午	shàngwǔ	morning (before noon)
中午	zhōngwǔ	noon
下午	xiàwǔ	afternoon
晚上	wǎnshang	evening, night 日 sun

现在几点?

现在 now | 几 how many | 点 o'clock

Xiànzài jǐ diǎn?

What time is it now?

What time is it?

八点
bā diǎn
8:00

两点
liǎng diǎn
2:00
Use 两, not 二, for two o'clock.

三点半
sān diǎn bàn
3:30

七点一刻
qī diǎn yí kè
7:15

十点十分
shí diǎn shí fēn
10:10

差五分九点
chà wǔ fēn jiǔ diǎn
8:55 (five to nine)

下午四点
xiàwǔ sì diǎn
4 p.m.

TIP

Part of the day goes **before** the time: 晚上八点 = 8 p.m. ('evening eight o'clock'). Timetables and tickets use the 24-hour clock.

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Birthdays

Lin 你的生日是几月几号?
Nǐ de shēngrì shì jǐ yuè jǐ hào?
When is your birthday?

Sam 五月八号。你呢?
Wǔyuè bā hào. Nǐ ne?
May 8th. And yours?

Lin 我的生日是明天!
Wǒ de shēngrì shì míngtiān!
My birthday is tomorrow!

Sam 真的吗?生日快乐!
Zhēn de ma? Shēngrì kuàilè!
Really? Happy birthday!

Lin 谢谢!明天晚上七点,我们一起吃饭吧。
Xièxie! Míngtiān wǎnshang qī diǎn, wǒmen yìqǐ chī fàn ba.
Thanks! Let's have dinner together tomorrow at 7 p.m.

Sam 好啊!
Hǎo a!
Great!

CULTURE NOTE

The Spring Festival (Chinese New Year) follows the lunar calendar, so its date moves every year, somewhere between late January and mid-February.

Say these dates and times aloud.

星期一

星期天

十月一号

现在几点?

三点半

晚上八点

Quick quiz

QUIZ

29. How do you say 'Wednesday'?

- ○ A) 星期二
- ○ B) 星期四
- ○ C) 星期三
- ○ D) 星期天

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30. Listen. What time is it? (listen in the web app: 三点半)

- ○ A) 3:15
- ○ B) 3:03
- ○ C) 13:00
- ○ D) 3:30

31. Which is NOT a way to say Sunday?

- ○ A) 星期日
- ○ B) 星期七
- ○ C) 星期天

32. Which date is in the correct Chinese order?

- ○ A) 8日5月2026年
- ○ B) 2026年5月8日
- ○ C) 5月8日2026年

33. 昨天 means...

- ○ A) the day after
- ○ B) today
- ○ C) tomorrow
- ○ D) yesterday

34. Listen. What time is it? (listen in the web app: 差五分九点)

- ○ A) 9:55
- ○ B) 9:05
- ○ C) 8:55
- ○ D) 5:09

35. What time is 两点?

- ○ A) 12:00
- ○ B) 2:30
- ○ C) 10:00
- ○ D) 2:00

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家

UNIT 3 · LESSON 6 · 13 MINUTES

Family

Parents, brothers, sisters and grandparents

- Name family members
- Tell older and younger siblings apart
- Say how many people are in your family
- Use 有 and 没有

Family is at the heart of Chinese culture, and the words are very precise. There is no single word for 'brother': you must say if he is older or younger!

Family words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
家	jiā	family; home 宀 roof
爸爸	bàba	dad 父 father
妈妈	māma	mum 女 woman
哥哥	gēge	older brother 口 mouth
姐姐	jiějie	older sister 女 woman
弟弟	dìdi	younger brother
妹妹	mèimei	younger sister 女 woman
爷爷	yéye	grandpa (dad's father) 父 father
奶奶	nǎinai	grandma (dad's mother) 女 woman
外公	wàigōng	grandpa (mum's father)
外婆	wàipó	grandma (mum's mother) 女 woman
儿子	érzi	son 子 child
女儿	nǚ'ér	daughter 女 woman
孩子	háizi	child, children 子 child
丈夫	zhàngfu	husband

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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
妻子	qīzi	wife 女 woman

MEMORY TRICK

Spot the radical 女 (woman) in 妈, 姐, 妹, 奶, 婆 and 妻. And 父 (father) sits on top of 爸 and 爷.

Older or younger?

	Older	Younger
Brother	哥哥 gēge	弟弟 dìdi
Sister	姐姐 jiějie	妹妹 mèimei

CULTURE NOTE

Grandparents on your dad's side (爷爷, 奶奶) have different names from those on your mum's side (外公, 外婆). 外 means 'outside'. Children also call adult friends of the family 叔叔 (shūshu, uncle) and 阿姨 (āyí, auntie).

Useful words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
有	yǒu	to have; there is 月 moon 我有一个妹妹。 (Wǒ yǒu yí gè mèimei.) — I have a younger sister.
没有	méiyǒu	not have 氵 water 我没有哥哥。 (Wǒ méiyǒu gēge.) — I don't have an older brother.
岁	suì	years old 山 mountain 他十二岁。 (Tā shí'èr suì.) — He is twelve.
口	kǒu	measure word for family members 口 mouth

你家有几口人?

你	家	有	几	口	人
your	family	has	how many	(measure word: 'mouths')	people

Nǐ jiā yǒu jǐ kǒu rén?

How many people are in your family?

Family members are counted in 'mouths' (口), people to feed!

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我家有四口人。
Wǒ jiā yǒu sì kǒu rén.
There are four people in my family.

我有一个哥哥。
Wǒ yǒu yí gè gēge.
I have an older brother.

我没有姐姐。
Wǒ méiyǒu jiějie.
I don't have an older sister. The opposite of 有 is always 没有, never 不有.

这是我妈妈。
Zhè shì wǒ māma.
This is my mum.

Looking at a photo

Tom 这是你的家人吗?
Zhè shì nǐ de jiārén ma?
Is this your family?

Xiaoyu 对。这是我爸爸，这是我妈妈。
Duì. Zhè shì wǒ bàba, zhè shì wǒ māma.
Yes. This is my dad, and this is my mum.

Tom 他是你哥哥吗?
Tā shì nǐ gēge ma?
Is he your older brother?

Xiaoyu 不是，他是我弟弟。他十二岁。
Bú shì, tā shì wǒ dìdi. Tā shí'èr suì.
No, he's my younger brother. He's twelve.

Tom 你有姐姐吗?
Nǐ yǒu jiějie ma?
Do you have an older sister?

Xiaoyu 没有。我家有四口人。
Méiyǒu. Wǒ jiā yǒu sì kǒu rén.
No. There are four of us in my family.

Read aloud, then describe your own family.

爸爸 妈妈 哥哥 姐姐 弟弟 妹妹

你家有几口人?

我家有三口人。

我有一个弟弟。

我没有妹妹。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

36. 姐姐 is your...

- ○ A) older sister
- ○ B) younger sister
- ○ C) older brother
- ○ D) mum

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37. Listen. Who is it? (listen in the web app: 弟弟)

- ○ A) son
- ○ B) older brother
- ○ C) grandpa
- ○ D) younger brother

38. Your mum's mother is your...

- ○ A) 奶奶
- ○ B) 外婆
- ○ C) 妈妈
- ○ D) 妹妹

39. How do you say 'I don't have a younger sister'?

- ○ A) 我有不妹妹。
- ○ B) 我没有妹妹。
- ○ C) 我不有妹妹。
- ○ D) 我没妹妹有。

40. Which radical appears in 妈, 姐 and 妹?

- ○ A) 女
- ○ B) 父
- ○ C) 子
- ○ D) 口

41. Listen. What is the question? (listen in the web app: 你家有几口人)

- ○ A) How many people are in your family?
- ○ B) Is this your mum?
- ○ C) Do you have a brother?
- ○ D) How old are you?

42. Which word means 'daughter'?

- ○ A) 孩子
- ○ B) 女儿
- ○ C) 妻子
- ○ D) 儿子

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吃

UNIT 3 · LESSON 7 · 15 MINUTES

Food & Drink

Order a meal and talk about what you like

- Name common foods and drinks
- Order in a restaurant
- Use 碗, 杯, 瓶 and 盘
- Say if something tastes good

Food is one of the best reasons to learn Chinese! In this lesson you'll learn the dishes and drinks you'll see everywhere, and how to order them.

Food

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
米饭	mǐfàn	(cooked) rice 饣 food
面条	miàntiáo	noodles 木 wood
饺子	jiǎozi	dumplings 饣 food
包子	bāozi	steamed buns 子 child
鸡蛋	jīdàn	egg 虫 insect
鸡肉	jīròu	chicken (meat)
牛肉	niúròu	beef 牛 cow
猪肉	zhūròu	pork 犭 animal
鱼	yú	fish 鱼 fish
菜	cài	vegetables; a dish ⺾ grass
水果	shuǐguǒ	fruit 木 tree
苹果	píngguǒ	apple ⺾ grass
香蕉	xiāngjiāo	banana ⺾ grass

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Drinks

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
水	shuǐ	water 水 water
茶	chá	tea ⺾ grass
咖啡	kāfēi	coffee 口 mouth
牛奶	niúnǎi	milk 女 woman
果汁	guǒzhī	juice 氵 water
啤酒	píjiǔ	beer 氵 water

Eating and drinking

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
吃	chī	to eat 口 mouth 我吃饺子。 (Wǒ chī jiǎozi.) — I eat dumplings.
喝	hē	to drink 口 mouth 你喝茶吗？ (Nǐ hē chá ma?) — Do you drink tea?
饿	è	hungry 饣 food
渴	kě	thirsty 氵 water
好吃	hǎochī	delicious (food)
好喝	hǎohē	tasty (drinks)
辣	là	spicy

MEMORY TRICK

Radicals give clues: 饣 (food) in 饭, 饺, 饿; 口 (mouth) in 吃, 喝; 氵 (water) in 汁, 酒, 渴; ⺾ (grass, plants) in 菜, 茶, 苹.

我要一碗米饭。

我	要	一	碗	米饭
I	want	one	bowl (measure word)	rice

Wǒ yào yì wǎn mǐfàn.

I'd like a bowl of rice.

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Cups, bottles, bowls and plates

一杯茶
yì bēi chá
a cup of tea

一瓶水
yì píng shuǐ
a bottle of water

一碗面条
yì wǎn miàntiáo
a bowl of noodles

一盘饺子
yì pán jiǎozi
a plate of dumplings

In a restaurant

服务员！
Fúwùyuán!
Excuse me! (to call the waiter)

请给我菜单。
Qǐng gěi wǒ càidān.
The menu, please.

不要辣的。
Bú yào là de.
Not spicy, please.

很好吃！
Hěn hǎochī!
It's delicious!

买单！
Mǎidān!
The bill, please!

Ordering dinner

Waiter 你好！你们吃什么？
Nǐ hǎo! Nǐmen chī shénme?
Hello! What would you like to eat?

Mia 我要一盘饺子和一碗米饭。
Wǒ yào yì pán jiǎozi hé yì wǎn mǐfàn.
A plate of dumplings and a bowl of rice, please.

Waiter 喝什么？
Hē shénme?
Anything to drink?

Mia 一杯绿茶，谢谢。
Yì bēi lǜchá, xièxie.
A cup of green tea, thanks.

Mia 服务员，买单！
Fúwùyuán, mǎidān!
Excuse me, the bill please!

Waiter 一共四十五块。
Yígòng sìshíwǔ kuài.
That's forty-five kuai altogether.

CULTURE NOTE

Dishes are usually shared in the middle of the table. Never stand your chopsticks upright in a bowl of rice: it looks like the incense sticks used for the dead. When people raise a glass they say 干杯! (gānbēi, cheers!).

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Read aloud as if you were ordering.

我饿了。

我要一碗面条。

我要一杯咖啡。

不要辣的。

很好吃！

买单！

Quick quiz

QUIZ

43. Listen. What is it? (listen in the web app: 饺子)

- ○ A) noodles
- ○ B) rice
- ○ C) dumplings
- ○ D) eggs

44. How do you say 'a cup of tea'?

- ○ A) 一盘茶
- ○ B) 一杯茶
- ○ C) 一瓶茶
- ○ D) 一碗茶

45. Which radical means food?

- ○ A) 艹
- ○ B) 氵
- ○ C) 口
- ○ D) 饣

46. 好吃 means...

- ○ A) hard to eat
- ○ B) tasty
- ○ C) thirsty
- ○ D) very hungry

47. How do you ask for the bill?

- ○ A) 好喝！
- ○ B) 干杯！
- ○ C) 买单！
- ○ D) 菜单！

48. Listen. What does the customer want? (listen in the web app: 我要一瓶水)

- ○ A) a plate of rice
- ○ B) a bottle of water
- ○ C) a bowl of noodles
- ○ D) a cup of coffee

49. Which is a drink?

- ○ A) 猪肉
- ○ B) 包子
- ○ C) 鸡蛋
- ○ D) 果汁

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UNIT 3 · LESSON 8 · 11 MINUTES

Colours

Red for luck, and every colour in between

- Name the main colours
- Use a colour before a noun
- Say which colour you like
- Know what colours mean in China

Colours in Chinese are easy: most are one character + 色 (sè, colour). Some also carry strong cultural meanings.

Colours

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
颜色	yánsè	colour 页 page
红色	hóngsè	red 纟 silk
黄色	huángsè	yellow
蓝色	lánsè	blue 艹 grass
绿色	lǜsè	green 纟 silk
白色	báisè	white 白 white
黑色	hēisè	black 灬 fire
橙色	chéngsè	orange 木 tree
紫色	zǐsè	purple 纟 silk
粉色	fěnsè	pink 米 rice
灰色	huīsè	grey 火 fire
棕色	zōngsè	brown 木 tree
金色	jīnsè	gold 金 metal

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MEMORY TRICK

Long ago, cloth was dyed, so many colour characters have the silk radical 纟: 红, 绿, 紫 (at the bottom, as 糸).

Colour + noun

A one-character colour goes straight before the noun, no 色 needed.

红苹果 hóng píngguǒ　白猫 bái māo　黑车 hēi chē

DID YOU KNOW?

Black tea is called 红茶 (hóngchá), 'red tea', because of the colour of the drink. Green tea is 绿茶 (lǜchá).

你喜欢什么颜色?

你	喜欢	什么	颜色
you	like	what	colour

Nǐ xǐhuan shénme yánsè?

What colour do you like?

我喜欢蓝色。
Wǒ xǐhuan lánsè.
I like blue.

我的车是白色的。
Wǒ de chē shì báisè de.
My car is white.

这件衣服是红色的。
Zhè jiàn yīfu shì hóngsè de.
This piece of clothing is red.

我要黑的。
Wǒ yào hēi de.
I want the black one.
Colour + 的 = 'the … one'.

CULTURE NOTE

Red means luck and joy: weddings, Spring Festival and the red envelopes of money called 红包 (hóngbāo). **White** is traditionally the colour of mourning. Never give a man a green hat: 戴绿帽子 means his partner is cheating!

DID YOU KNOW?

On Chinese stock market screens, **red** means prices are going up and **green** means down, the opposite of many Western screens.

Copy each colour and say it aloud.

红	色	红	色	红	色	红	色							
白	色	白	色	白	色	白	色							

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黑 色 黑 色 黑 色 黑 色

绿 色 绿 色 绿 色 绿 色

Say each colour, then point at something of that colour around you.

红色 黄色 蓝色 绿色

白色 黑色 灰色 粉色

你喜欢什么颜色?

我喜欢绿色。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

50. Listen. Which colour? (listen in the web app: 红色)

- ○ A) green
- ○ B) red
- ○ C) yellow
- ○ D) blue

51. How do you say 'black'?

- ○ A) 黑色
- ○ B) 蓝色
- ○ C) 白色
- ○ D) 灰色

52. 红茶 is...

- ○ A) black tea
- ○ B) red wine
- ○ C) rose juice
- ○ D) green tea

53. Which colour is lucky at weddings and Spring Festival?

- ○ A) 红色
- ○ B) 黑色
- ○ C) 绿色
- ○ D) 白色

54. Listen. What does the speaker like? (listen in the web app: 我喜欢紫色)

- ○ A) pink
- ○ B) orange
- ○ C) purple
- ○ D) brown

55. Which phrase means 'white cat'?

- ○ A) 猫的白
- ○ B) 猫白
- ○ C) 白色是猫
- ○ D) 白猫

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车

UNIT 3 · LESSON 9 · 15 MINUTES

Places & Transport

Where are you going and how will you get there?

- Name places around town
- Ask where something is
- Use 坐, 骑 and 开 with transport
- Take a taxi

Let's get around town! You'll learn the places you need, how to ask where they are, and how to talk about buses, trains and bikes.

Places

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
学校	xuéxiào	school 木 tree
医院	yīyuàn	hospital 阝 mound
银行	yínháng	bank 钅 metal
商店	shāngdiàn	shop 广 shelter
超市	chāoshì	supermarket
饭馆	fànguǎn	restaurant 饣 food
公园	gōngyuán	park 口 enclosure
酒店	jiǔdiàn	hotel 广 shelter
机场	jīchǎng	airport 土 earth
火车站	huǒchēzhàn	train station 火 fire
洗手间	xǐshǒujiān	restroom, toilet 氵 water
公司	gōngsī	company, office

Transport

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
车	chē	vehicle, car 车 vehicle

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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
公交车	gōngjiāochē	city bus 车 vehicle
地铁	dìtiě	subway, metro 钅 metal
出租车	chūzūchē	taxi 车 vehicle
火车	huǒchē	train 火 fire
高铁	gāotiě	high-speed train 钅 metal
飞机	fēijī	plane 木 wood
自行车	zìxíngchē	bicycle 车 vehicle

Verbs for getting around

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
去	qù	to go 我去银行。 (Wǒ qù yínháng.) — I'm going to the bank.
来	lái	to come
坐	zuò	to sit; to take (bus, train, plane) 土 earth
骑	qí	to ride (bike, horse) 马 horse
开车	kāichē	to drive 车 vehicle
走路	zǒulù	to walk 足 foot
在	zài	to be at, to be in 土 earth
哪儿	nǎr	where 口 mouth

坐, 骑 or 开?

You 坐 (sit in) buses, subways, taxis, trains and planes. You 骑 (sit astride) bikes, motorbikes and horses. You 开 (drive) a car yourself.

坐地铁 zuò dìtiě　坐飞机 zuò fēijī　骑自行车 qí zìxíngchē　开车 kāichē

MEMORY TRICK

骑 has the horse radical 马: you ride a bike the way you ride a horse.

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你去哪儿?

你	去	哪儿
you	go	where

Nǐ qù nǎr?

Where are you going?

我坐地铁去学校。

我	坐	地铁	去	学校
I	take (sit on)	subway	go to	school

Wǒ zuò dìtiě qù xuéxiào.

I take the subway to school.

'How' comes before 'where': first the subway, then the school.

Useful sentences

请问，洗手间在哪儿?
Qǐngwèn, xǐshǒujiān zài nǎr?
Excuse me, where is the restroom?

银行在那儿。
Yínháng zài nàr.
The bank is over there.

我去超市买水果。
Wǒ qù chāoshì mǎi shuǐguǒ.
I'm going to the supermarket to buy fruit.

我走路去公园。
Wǒ zǒulù qù gōngyuán.
I walk to the park.

TIP

哪儿 (nǎr) is common in the north, 哪里 (nǎlǐ) in the south. Both mean 'where'. Likewise 这儿 = here, 那儿 = there.

CULTURE NOTE

Taxi and ride-hailing drivers are politely called 师傅 (shīfu, master). China also has the world's largest high-speed rail network, so 高铁 is a great way to travel between cities.

In a taxi

Driver 你好，去哪儿?
Nǐ hǎo, qù nǎr?
Hello, where to?

Ben 师傅，去火车站。远吗?
Shīfu, qù huǒchēzhàn. Yuǎn ma?
To the train station, please. Is it far?

Driver 不太远，二十分钟。
Bú tài yuǎn, èrshí fēnzhōng.
Not too far, twenty minutes.

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Ben 好的，谢谢。
Hǎo de, xièxie.
OK, thanks.

Driver 到了。三十二块。
Dào le. Sānshí'èr kuài.
Here we are. Thirty-two kuai.

Ben 给您。再见！
Gěi nín. Zàijiàn!
Here you are. Goodbye!

Read aloud. Then say how YOU get to school or work.

你去哪儿?

我去机场。

我坐公交车去公司。

我骑自行车去学校。

洗手间在哪儿?

Quick quiz

QUIZ

56. Listen. Where is the speaker going? (listen in the web app: 我去机场)

- ○ A) the park
- ○ B) the hospital
- ○ C) the bank
- ○ D) the airport

57. Which verb goes with 自行车 (bicycle)?

- ○ A) 开
- ○ B) 骑
- ○ C) 坐
- ○ D) 走

58. How do you say 'Where is the restroom?'

- ○ A) 洗手间去哪儿?
- ○ B) 哪儿是洗手间吗?
- ○ C) 你去洗手间?
- ○ D) 洗手间在哪儿?

59. 地铁 is...

- ○ A) a plane
- ○ B) a taxi
- ○ C) the bus
- ○ D) the subway

60. Choose the correct order: 'I take the bus to school.'

- ○ A) 我坐公交车去学校。
- ○ B) 我去学校坐公交车。
- ○ C) 我学校去坐公交车。
- ○ D) 坐公交车我学校去。

61. Listen. What place is it? (listen in the web app: 银行)

- ○ A) bank
- ○ B) shop
- ○ C) hotel
- ○ D) school

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62. What do you call a taxi driver politely?

- ○ A) 师傅
- ○ B) 老板
- ○ C) 老师
- ○ D) 服务员

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本

UNIT 3 · LESSON 10 · 14 MINUTES

Everyday Objects

Things around you, counted the Chinese way

- Name everyday objects
- Ask 'What is this?'
- Count things with measure words
- Use 这 and 那

In Chinese you can't say 'one book' directly. You say 'one **volume** book': 一本书. These little counting words are called **measure words**. Let's meet them with the objects around you.

Things around you

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
书	shū	book 一本书 (yì běn shū) — a book
笔	bǐ	pen 𥫱 bamboo 一支笔 (yì zhī bǐ) — a pen
纸	zhǐ	paper 纟 silk 一张纸 (yì zhāng zhǐ) — a sheet of paper
手机	shǒujī	mobile phone 木 wood 一个手机 (yí gè shǒujī) — a mobile phone
电脑	diànnǎo	computer 月 body 一台电脑 (yì tái diànnǎo) — a computer
桌子	zhuōzi	table, desk 木 wood 一张桌子 (yì zhāng zhuōzi) — a table
椅子	yǐzi	chair 木 wood 一把椅子 (yì bǎ yǐzi) — a chair
杯子	bēizi	cup, glass 木 wood 一个杯子 (yí gè bēizi) — a cup
包	bāo	bag 一个包 (yí gè bāo) — a bag
钥匙	yàoshi	key 钅 metal 一把钥匙 (yì bǎ yàoshi) — a key
雨伞	yǔsǎn	umbrella 雨 rain 一把雨伞 (yì bǎ yǔsǎn) — an umbrella
衣服	yīfu	clothes 衣 clothing 一件衣服 (yí jiàn yīfu) — a piece of clothing

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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
钱包	qiánbāo	wallet, purse 钅 metal 一个钱包 (yí gè qiánbāo) — a wallet
票	piào	ticket 示 show 两张票 (liǎng zhāng piào) — two tickets

Number + measure word + noun

Between a number and a noun you always need a measure word.

一本书 yì běn shū　两张纸 liǎng zhāng zhǐ　三把椅子 sān bǎ yǐzi

Common measure words

Measure word	Pinyin	Used for	Example
个	gè	people and many things (the all-rounder)	一个杯子
本	běn	books, notebooks	一本书
张	zhāng	flat things: paper, tables, tickets, beds	两张票
把	bǎ	things with a handle: chairs, keys, umbrellas	一把钥匙
支	zhī	pens and pencils	三支笔
件	jiàn	clothes (tops, coats)	一件衣服
台	tái	machines: computers, TVs	一台电脑
辆	liàng	vehicles	一辆车

TIP

Not sure which measure word to use? 个 is the safe default. People will understand you, and you'll pick up the others little by little.

MEMORY TRICK

张 means 'to stretch out': anything flat and spread out. 把 means 'to hold': anything you grab by a handle.

这是什么?

这 this　是 is　什么 what

Zhè shì shénme?

What's this?

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那是我的手机。

那	是	我的	手机
that	is	my	phone

Nà shì wǒ de shǒujī.

That is my phone.

这 / 那 + measure word + noun

'This' and 'that' also need a measure word before a noun.

这本书 (zhè běn shū) 那把雨伞 (nà bǎ yǔsǎn) 这件衣服 (zhè jiàn yīfu)

这本书是中文书。

Zhè běn shū shì Zhōngwén shū.

This book is a Chinese book.

我有两支笔。

Wǒ yǒu liǎng zhī bǐ.

I have two pens.

这件衣服很漂亮。

Zhè jiàn yīfu hěn piàoliang.

This piece of clothing is very pretty.

Ready for school?

Mum 你的钥匙呢?
Nǐ de yàoshi ne?
Where are your keys?

Xiaodong 在包里。
Zài bāo li.
In my bag.

Mum 手机呢?
Shǒujī ne?
And your phone?

Xiaodong 手机在桌子上。
Shǒujī zài zhuōzi shang.
My phone is on the table.

Mum 雨伞呢?今天会下雨。
Yǔsǎn ne? Jīntiān huì xià yǔ.
What about an umbrella? It's going to rain today.

Xiaodong 啊,我没有雨伞!
À, wǒ méiyǒu yǔsǎn!
Oh, I don't have an umbrella!

Mum 给你,这把是我的。
Gěi nǐ, zhè bǎ shì wǒ de.
Here you go, this one is mine.

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Point at things around you and name them with a number.

这是什么?

一本书

两支笔

三张纸

一把椅子

一台电脑

Unit check

Check yourself

☐ I can greet people politely and say goodbye.

☐ I can introduce myself and ask someone's name.

☐ I can count to 100 and ask for a price.

☐ I can say the date and the time.

☐ I can name family, food, colours, places and objects.

☐ I can use 个, 本, 张 and 把.

Give your work today some stars ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆

Quick quiz

QUIZ

63. Which measure word goes with 书?

- ○ A) 把
- ○ B) 张
- ○ C) 辆
- ○ D) 本

64. Listen. What is it? (listen in the web app: 一把雨伞)

- ○ A) a wallet
- ○ B) a key
- ○ C) a chair
- ○ D) an umbrella

65. 一张票 means...

- ○ A) a book
- ○ B) a ticket
- ○ C) a key
- ○ D) a phone

66. How do you say 'two pens'?

- ○ A) 两笔
- ○ B) 两支笔
- ○ C) 二笔支
- ○ D) 二支笔

67. 这是什么？ means...

- ○ A) Where is it?
- ○ B) Who is this?
- ○ C) Is this yours?
- ○ D) What's this?

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68. Which measure word is the safe all-rounder?

- ○ A) 支
- ○ B) 件
- ○ C) 台
- ○ D) 个

69. Listen. Which object? (listen in the web app: 电脑)

- ○ A) table
- ○ B) clothes
- ○ C) computer
- ○ D) mobile phone

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UNIT 3

Answer key

1. A) Thank you

2. B) 不客气
不客气 = you're welcome. 没关系 answers 'sorry'.

3. D) 您好
您 is the respectful 'you'.

4. B) Sorry

5. A) At bedtime

6. D) 明天见

7. C) And you?

8. C) 你叫什么名字?

9. D) I'm British.

10. C) 张
Chinese surnames come first.

11. C) Nice to meet you.

12. C) 朋友

13. C) 日本人

14. A) 叫

15. A) 7

16. D) 4

17. D) 6

18. A) 8
八 bā sounds like 发 fā, to get rich.

19. B) 0

20. D) yí gè
个 is a fourth tone, so 一 becomes yí.

21. D) 9

22. D) 40

23. C) 九十九

24. C) 两块五

25. D) How much is it?

26. C) Too expensive!

27. A) 10

28. D) 便宜

29. C) 星期三

30. D) 3:30

31. B) 星期七
There is no 'week-seven'. Sunday is 星期天 or 星期日.

32. B) 2026年5月8日

33. D) yesterday

34. C) 8:55

35. D) 2:00

36. A) older sister

37. D) younger brother

38. B) 外婆

39. B) 我没有妹妹。

40. A) 女

41. A) How many people are in your family?

42. B) 女儿

43. C) dumplings

44. B) 一杯茶

45. D) ㄅ

46. B) tasty

47. C) 买单!

48. B) a bottle of water

49. D) 果汁

50. B) red

51. A) 黑色

52. A) black tea
It's called 'red tea' because of the drink's colour.

53. A) 红色

54. C) purple

55. D) 白猫

56. D) the airport

57. B) 骑

58. D) 洗手间在哪儿?

59. D) the subway

60. A) 我坐公交车去学校。

61. A) bank

62. A) 师傅

63. D) 本

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64. D) an umbrella

65. B) a ticket

66. B) 两支笔

67. D) What's this?

68. D) 个

69. C) computer

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UNIT 4

Grammar Made Easy

Build real sentences step by step: word order, questions, negatives and time

1. Word Order: Subject–Verb–Object
2. 是: To Be
3. Adjectives with 很
4. Yes/No Questions with 吗
5. Question Words
6. Saying No: 不 vs 没
7. Measure Words
8. 的: Possession & Description
9. 在: Where & What's Happening
10. 了: Completed Actions
11. Want, Can, May: 想 要 会 能 可以
12. Comparisons with 比
13. Where Do Time Words Go?
14. 过: Have You Ever...?

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UNIT 4 · LESSON 1 · 12 MINUTES

Word Order: Subject–Verb–Object

The good news: it's a lot like English

- Build simple subject–verb–object sentences
- Use the personal pronouns
- See that verbs never change
- Know that there are no articles or plural -s

Here's some great news: the basic word order of Chinese is the same as English. **Who** does **what** to **what**: subject, verb, object.

我爱你。

我	爱	你
I	love	you

Wǒ ài nǐ.

I love you.

她学中文。

她	学	中文
she	studies	Chinese

Tā xué Zhōngwén.

She studies Chinese.

Pronouns

Chinese	Pinyin	Meaning
我	wǒ	I, me
你	nǐ	you
您	nín	you (polite)
他	tā	he, him
她	tā	she, her
它	tā	it
我们	wǒmen	we, us
你们	nǐmen	you (more than one)
他们	tāmen	they, them

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MEMORY TRICK

'I' and 'me' are the same word, 我. Swap the places and the meaning swaps: 我爱你 (I love you) → 你爱我 (you love me).

DID YOU KNOW?

他, 她 and 它 all sound exactly the same: tā. Only the written character shows he, she or it.

Verbs never change

No -s, no -ed, no am/is/are. The verb stays the same for every person and every time.

我吃 wǒ chī　他吃 tā chī　我们吃 wǒmen chī

TIP

There is no 'a', 'an' or 'the', and nouns have no plural -s. 书 can mean a book, the book or books. Only people can take 们: 老师们 (teachers), but never 书们.

Subject + verb + object

我喝茶。 Wǒ hē chá. I drink tea.	他看书。 Tā kàn shū. He reads books.	我们学中文。 Wǒmen xué Zhōngwén. We study Chinese.	妈妈做饭。 Māma zuò fàn. Mum cooks.

One small difference

我吃苹果。

Same as English

I eat apples. Subject, verb, object.

我在家吃苹果。

Place moves forward

I eat apples at home. The place comes BEFORE the verb (more on this later).

Read aloud and notice the order: who → does → what.

我爱你。

你爱我。

他喝咖啡。

我们学中文。

她们看书。

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Quick quiz

QUIZ

1. Choose the correct sentence for 'He drinks tea.'
   - ○ A) 茶他喝。
   - ○ B) 喝他茶。
   - ○ C) 他茶喝。
   - ○ D) 他喝茶。
2. How do you say 'they'?
   - ○ A) 我们
   - ○ B) 他
   - ○ C) 他们
   - ○ D) 你们
3. How do you change 我爱你 into 'You love me'?
   - ○ A) 我爱你们
   - ○ B) 爱你我
   - ○ C) 你爱你
   - ○ D) 你爱我
4. Listen. Who is studying Chinese? (listen in the web app: 我们学中文)
   - ○ A) she
   - ○ B) they
   - ○ C) we
   - ○ D) I
5. What is the plural of 书 (book)?
   - ○ A) 书
   - ○ B) 书子
   - ○ C) 书书
   - ○ D) 书们
6. Which pronoun means 'it'?
   - ○ A) 你
   - ○ B) 他
   - ○ C) 它
   - ○ D) 她
7. Listen. What does it mean? (listen in the web app: 妈妈做饭)
   - ○ A) Mum reads.
   - ○ B) Mum cooks.
   - ○ C) Mum eats.
   - ○ D) Mum drinks tea.

☐ Lesson done Date: _____

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是

UNIT 4 · LESSON 2 · 11 MINUTES

是: To Be

Saying who and what someone is

- Use 是 to link two nouns
- Make 是 negative with 不是
- Know when NOT to use 是

是 (shì) works like 'am, is, are'. It links two nouns: 'I am a student', 'This is my book'. And it never changes!

我是学生。

我	是	学生
I	am	student

Wǒ shì xuésheng.

I am a student.

A 是 B

Use 是 to say what or who something is. B is a noun.

我是美国人。
Wǒ shì Měiguó rén.

这是我的书。
Zhè shì wǒ de shū.

她是医生。
Tā shì yīshēng.

他不是老师。

他	不	是	老师
he	not	is	teacher

Tā bú shì lǎoshī.

He is not a teacher.

不 is said bú here, because 是 is a fourth tone.

Negative: 不是

Put 不 right before 是.

我不是老师。
Wǒ bú shì lǎoshī.

这不是我的。
Zhè bú shì wǒ de.

WATCH OUT

Don't use 是 with adjectives like busy, tall or happy. 'I am busy' is 我很忙, not 我是忙. You'll see why in the next lesson.

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TIP

Ages, dates and prices often skip 是: 我二十岁。 (I'm twenty.) 今天星期五。 (Today is Friday.) 这个十块。 (This one is ten kuai.)

Useful words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
医生	yīshēng	doctor 匚 box
司机	sījī	driver 木 wood
这	zhè	this 辶 walk
那	nà	that 阝 city
谁	shéi	who 讠 speech
也	yě	also, too

MEMORY TRICK

也 (also) goes before the verb, never at the end like 'too': 我也是学生。 = I'm a student too.

这是什么?
Zhè shì shénme?
What is this?

那是我朋友。
Nà shì wǒ péngyou.
That's my friend.

他是谁?
Tā shì shéi?
Who is he?

他是我哥哥。
Tā shì wǒ gēge.
He's my older brother.

Leo 你是老师吗?
Nǐ shì lǎoshī ma?
Are you a teacher?

Fang 不是，我是学生。你呢?
Bú shì, wǒ shì xuésheng. Nǐ ne?
No, I'm a student. And you?

Leo 我是医生。
Wǒ shì yīshēng.
I'm a doctor.

Fang 他也是医生吗?
Tā yě shì yīshēng ma?
Is he a doctor too?

Leo 不是，他是司机。他是我弟弟。
Bú shì, tā shì sījī. Tā shì wǒ dìdi.
No, he's a driver. He's my younger brother.

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Read aloud, then say what you and your friends are.

我是学生。

我不是老师。

这是我的书。

那不是我的。

我也是美国人。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

8. How do you say 'I am not a doctor'?
   - ○ A) 我没是医生。
   - ○ B) 不我是医生。
   - ○ C) 我不是医生。
   - ○ D) 我是不医生。

9. Which sentence is WRONG?
   - ○ A) 他是老师。
   - ○ B) 我是忙。
   - ○ C) 我是学生。
   - ○ D) 我很忙。

10. Listen. What does it mean? (listen in the web app: 他是谁)
   - ○ A) Where is he?
   - ○ B) Is he a teacher?
   - ○ C) Who is he?
   - ○ D) What's this?

11. Where does 也 go in 'I'm a student too'?
   - ○ A) 我也是学生。
   - ○ B) 我是也学生。
   - ○ C) 也我是学生。
   - ○ D) 我是学生也。

12. How is 不是 pronounced?
   - ○ A) bú shì
   - ○ B) bǔ shì
   - ○ C) bū shì
   - ○ D) bù shì

13. Which sentence can drop 是?
   - ○ A) 他老师。
   - ○ B) 这我的书。
   - ○ C) 我二十岁。
   - ○ D) 我学生。

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很

UNIT 4 · LESSON 3 · 12 MINUTES

Adjectives with 很

Busy, tired, cold, beautiful

- Describe things with 很 + adjective
- Avoid the 是 + adjective mistake
- Say how much: 有点儿, 非常, 太…了
- Make adjectives negative with 不

In Chinese, adjectives behave like verbs. 'I am busy' is simply 'I busy'. But a lonely adjective sounds odd, so we add a little word in front: 很.

我很忙。

我	很	忙
I	(very)	busy

Wǒ hěn máng.

I'm busy.

Here 很 is mostly a link word. It doesn't always mean 'very'.

Subject + 很 + adjective

No 是! Use 很 (or another degree word) before the adjective.

今天很冷。 Jīntiān hěn lěng.

中文很有意思。 Zhōngwén hěn yǒu yìsi.

她很高。 Tā hěn gāo.

WATCH OUT

✗ 我是累。 ✓ 我很累。 (I'm tired.) English speakers make this mistake a lot, so watch out for it!

Common adjectives

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
好	hǎo	good 女 woman
忙	máng	busy 忄 heart
累	lèi	tired 糸 silk
冷	lěng	cold 冫 ice
热	rè	hot 灬 fire

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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
高	gāo	tall, high
大	dà	big; old (age)
小	xiǎo	small; young
漂亮	piàoliang	beautiful, pretty 氵 water
难	nán	difficult
容易	róngyì	easy 宀 roof
有意思	yǒu yìsi	interesting 心 heart

MEMORY TRICK

冷 has two drops of ice 冫, and 热 sits on four little flames 灬.

How much?

Word	Pinyin	Meaning	Example
不	bù	not	我不忙。
有点儿	yǒudiǎnr	a bit (usually negative)	今天有点儿冷。
很	hěn	(link) / very	他很高。
非常	fēicháng	extremely	非常好！
太…了	tài … le	too… / so…!	太贵了！

TIP

太…了 can be a complaint (太贵了, too expensive) or praise (太好了！, great!). Listen to the tone of voice.

MEMORY TRICK

Without 很, an adjective sounds like a comparison: 他高，我矮。 = He's the tall one, I'm the short one.

我不累。
Wǒ bú lèi.
I'm not tired.

这个菜有点儿辣。
Zhège cài yǒudiǎnr là.
This dish is a bit spicy.

北京非常大。
Běijīng fēicháng dà.
Beijing is extremely big.

太好了！
Tài hǎo le!
Great!

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Jia 你今天忙吗?
Nǐ jīntiān máng ma?
Are you busy today?

Max 很忙，我有点儿累。
Hěn máng, wǒ yǒudiǎnr lèi.
Very busy. I'm a bit tired.

Jia 中文难吗?
Zhōngwén nán ma?
Is Chinese difficult?

Max 不太难，非常有意思!
Bú tài nán, fēicháng yǒu yìsi!
Not too hard, and really interesting!

Describe the weather and how you feel today.

今天很热。

今天有点儿冷。

我很好。

我不累。

中文很有意思!

Quick quiz

QUIZ

14. How do you say 'I'm tired'?

- ○ A) 我是累。
- ○ B) 我很累。
- ○ C) 我累是。
- ○ D) 很我累。

15. Listen. What's the weather like? (listen in the web app: 今天有点儿冷)

- ○ A) not cold
- ○ B) too hot
- ○ C) a bit cold
- ○ D) very hot

16. 太贵了！ means...

- ○ A) Very cheap!
- ○ B) So pretty!
- ○ C) Not bad!
- ○ D) Too expensive!

17. Which radical in 冷 means ice?

- ○ A) 灬
- ○ B) 氵
- ○ C) 忄
- ○ D) 冫

18. How do you say 'not busy'?

- ○ A) 很不
- ○ B) 是忙
- ○ C) 没忙
- ○ D) 不忙

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19. Listen. How is Chinese? (listen in the web app: 中文很有意思)

- ○ A) easy
- ○ B) boring
- ○ C) interesting
- ○ D) difficult

20. 非常好 means...

- ○ A) a bit good
- ○ B) too good to be true
- ○ C) not good
- ○ D) extremely good

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吗

UNIT 4 · LESSON 4 · 12 MINUTES

Yes/No Questions with 吗

Turn any sentence into a question

- Make yes/no questions with 吗
- Answer without 'yes' or 'no'
- Ask A-not-A questions
- Bounce a question back with 呢

This is one of the easiest things in Chinese: to ask a yes/no question, take a normal sentence and add 吗 (ma) at the end. Nothing moves!

Sentence + 吗?

Keep the word order. Just add 吗 and raise your eyebrows.

你是老师吗?
Nǐ shì lǎoshī ma?

你忙吗?
Nǐ máng ma?

你喜欢茶吗?
Nǐ xǐhuan chá ma?

你喝咖啡吗?

你	喝	咖啡	吗
you	drink	coffee	(question)

Nǐ hē kāfēi ma?

Do you drink coffee?

English adds 'do' and moves words around. Chinese just adds 吗.

MEMORY TRICK

Chinese has no single word for 'yes' or 'no'. Answer with the verb: yes = repeat it, no = 不 + verb.

Answer with the verb

Question	Yes	No
你是中国人吗?	是。	不是。
你忙吗?	忙。	不忙。
你喜欢猫吗?	喜欢。	不喜欢。
你有哥哥吗?	有。	没有。

TIP

对 (duì) means 'right, correct' and 好 (hǎo) means 'OK'. They're handy for agreeing, but repeating the verb is the most natural answer.

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A-not-A questions

Another way to ask: say the verb, then 不 + the verb. No 吗 needed!

你忙不忙?
Nǐ máng bu máng?

你是不是老师?
Nǐ shì bu shì lǎoshī?

你去不去?
Nǐ qù bu qù?

WATCH OUT

Never use both: X 你忙不忙吗? Choose 你忙吗? or 你忙不忙?

Bounce it back with 呢

我很好，你呢?
Wǒ hěn hǎo, nǐ ne?
I'm fine, and you?

我是学生，他呢?
Wǒ shì xuésheng, tā ne?
I'm a student. What about him?

我的手机呢?
Wǒ de shǒujī ne?
Where's my phone?
On its own, noun + 呢 asks 'where is...?'

Nora 你喜欢中国菜吗?
Nǐ xǐhuan Zhōngguó cài ma?
Do you like Chinese food?

Kai 喜欢！你呢?
Xǐhuan! Nǐ ne?
Yes! And you?

Nora 我也喜欢。你吃不吃辣?
Wǒ yě xǐhuan. Nǐ chī bu chī là?
Me too. Do you eat spicy food?

Kai 不吃，我怕辣。
Bù chī, wǒ pà là.
No, I'm afraid of spicy food.

Nora 那我们吃饺子，好吗?
Nà wǒmen chī jiǎozi, hǎo ma?
Then let's have dumplings, OK?

Kai 好!
Hǎo!
OK!

Ask these questions aloud, then answer them about yourself.

你忙吗?

你是学生吗?

你喜欢茶吗?

你有妹妹吗?

你去不去?

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Quick quiz

QUIZ

21. Turn 你是学生 into a question.

- ○ A) 是你学生吗?
- ○ B) 你是学生吗?
- ○ C) 你吗是学生?
- ○ D) 吗你是学生?

22. Someone asks 你忙吗? You're not busy. You say...

- ○ A) 没忙。
- ○ B) 不忙。
- ○ C) 忙吗。
- ○ D) 不是。

23. Listen. What is the question? (listen in the web app: 你喜欢猫吗)

- ○ A) Do you like cats?
- ○ B) Where is the cat?
- ○ C) Do you have a cat?
- ○ D) Is this your cat?

24. Which question is WRONG?

- ○ A) 你是不是老师?
- ○ B) 你去不去?
- ○ C) 你去吗?
- ○ D) 你去不去吗?

25. 你呢? means...

- ○ A) Is it you?
- ○ B) Are you OK?
- ○ C) And you?
- ○ D) Who are you?

26. 你有哥哥吗? The answer is no. You say...

- ○ A) 不有。
- ○ B) 没有。
- ○ C) 没是。
- ○ D) 不是。

27. Someone asks 你喜欢茶吗? Listen to the answer. What does it mean? (listen in the web app: 喜欢)

- ○ A) Yes, I like it.
- ○ B) I don't know.
- ○ C) Maybe.
- ○ D) No, I don't.

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谁

UNIT 4 · LESSON 5 · 15 MINUTES

Question Words

What, who, where, how many, how

- Use 什么, 谁, 哪儿, 几, 多少, 怎么
- Keep the question word in the answer's place
- Choose between 几 and 多少
- Ask how to say something in Chinese

English moves question words to the front: 'Where are you going?' Chinese doesn't! Put the question word exactly where the answer will go. That's the whole secret.

The question words

Word	Pinyin	Meaning	Example
什么	shénme	what	这是什么?
谁	shéi	who	他是谁?
哪儿 / 哪里	nǎr / nǎlǐ	where	你去哪儿?
几	jǐ	how many (small numbers)	你有几个孩子?
多少	duōshao	how many, how much	多少钱?
怎么	zěnme	how	你怎么去?
什么时候	shénme shíhou	when	你什么时候来?
为什么	wèishénme	why	你为什么学中文?

Stay in place

Write the answer sentence, then swap the answer for a question word. No change of order, and no 吗.

你去哪儿? Nǐ qù nǎr?

他是谁? Tā shì shéi?

你吃什么? Nǐ chī shénme?

Questions and answers line up

我去北京。
Wǒ qù Běijīng.
I'm going to Beijing.
Answers 你去哪儿? — 北京 takes the place of 哪儿.

他是我哥哥。
Tā shì wǒ gēge.
He's my older brother.
Answers 他是谁?

我吃面条。
Wǒ chī miàntiáo.
I'm eating noodles.
Answers 你吃什么?

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你什么时候去中国?

你	什么时候	去	中国
you	when	go	China

Nǐ shénme shíhou qù Zhōngguó?

When are you going to China?

Answer: 我明天去中国 — 'tomorrow' sits right where 'when' was.

WATCH OUT

Question words already make a question, so don't add 吗: ✗ 你去哪儿吗?

TIP

谁 is usually said shéi in everyday speech; you may also hear shuí.

几 or 多少?

Use 几 when you expect a small number (about 1–10) and add a measure word. Use 多少 for any number; the measure word is optional.

你家有几口人?
Nǐ jiā yǒu jǐ kǒu rén?

你们学校有多少学生?
Nǐmen xuéxiào yǒu duōshao xuésheng?

现在几点?
Xiànzài jǐ diǎn?

CULTURE NOTE

To ask a child's age, say 你几岁? To ask an adult, say 你多大? (Nǐ duō dà?). For an older person, 您多大年纪? (Nín duō dà niánjì?) is most polite.

怎么 and friends

这个用中文怎么说?
Zhège yòng Zhōngwén zěnme shuō?
How do you say this in Chinese?

去火车站怎么走?
Qù huǒchēzhàn zěnme zǒu?
How do I get to the train station?

这个菜怎么样?
Zhège cài zěnmeyàng?
How is this dish?

你为什么学中文?
Nǐ wèishénme xué Zhōngwén?
Why are you learning Chinese?

MEMORY TRICK

怎么 + verb = 'how to do it': 怎么说 (how to say), 怎么走 (how to get there), 怎么写 (how to write).

Lily 你叫什么名字?
Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?
What's your name?

Sam 我叫山姆。你是哪里人?
Wǒ jiào Shānmǔ. Nǐ shì nǎlǐ rén?
I'm Sam. Where are you from?

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Lily 我是上海人。你为什么学中文?
Wǒ shì Shànghǎi rén. Nǐ wèishénme xué Zhōngwén?
I'm from Shanghai. Why are you learning Chinese?

Sam 因为我喜欢中国菜!
Yīnwèi wǒ xǐhuan Zhōngguó cài!
Because I love Chinese food!

Lily 哈哈!你什么时候来上海?
Hāha! Nǐ shénme shíhou lái Shànghǎi?
Haha! When are you coming to Shanghai?

Sam 我八月去。
Wǒ bāyuè qù.
I'm going in August.

Ask these questions aloud, then answer each one.

你叫什么名字?

他是谁?

你去哪儿?

现在几点?

这个多少钱?

你怎么去学校?

Quick quiz

QUIZ

28. 谁 means...

- ○ A) what
- ○ B) when
- ○ C) who
- ○ D) where

29. Answer 你去哪儿? with 'the bank':

- ○ A) 我去银行。
- ○ B) 去银行吗。
- ○ C) 我去哪儿银行。
- ○ D) 银行我去。

30. Listen. What is the question? (listen in the web app: 多少钱)

- ○ A) What time is it?
- ○ B) Where is it?
- ○ C) Who is it?
- ○ D) How much is it?

31. Which question is WRONG?

- ○ A) 你吃什么吗?
- ○ B) 他是谁?
- ○ C) 你去哪儿?
- ○ D) 你吃什么?

32. How do you ask a child's age?

- ○ A) 你哪儿岁?
- ○ B) 你几岁?
- ○ C) 你什么岁?
- ○ D) 你多少岁吗?

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33. Listen. What is the speaker asking? (listen in the web app: 这个用中文怎么说)

- ○ A) how to say something
- ○ B) why you study
- ○ C) when you arrive
- ○ D) where to go

34. 为什么 means...

- ○ A) when
- ○ B) why
- ○ C) which
- ○ D) how

35. To ask how many students a big school has, use...

- ○ A) 怎么
- ○ B) 几
- ○ C) 哪
- ○ D) 多少

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不

UNIT 4 · LESSON 6 · 13 MINUTES

Saying No: 不 vs 没

Two little words for 'not'

- Use 不 for habits, wishes, the future and adjectives
- Use 没 for things that didn't happen
- Always say 没有, never 不有
- Hear the tone change of 不

Chinese has two words for 'not': 不 (bù) and 没 (méi). Choosing the right one is easier than it looks: ask yourself 'Did it happen?' and 'Is it 有?'

Two kinds of 'not'

不

bù — don't, won't, am not

Habits, wishes, the future, adjectives and 是.

没

méi — didn't, haven't

Things that did not happen, and 没有 (don't have).

不 + verb / adjective

For what you normally do, want to do, will do, or what something is like.

我不吃肉。
Wǒ bù chī ròu.

明天我不去。
Míngtiān wǒ bú qù.

今天不冷。
Jīntiān bù lěng.

他不是老师。
Tā bú shì lǎoshī.

没 + verb

For something that did not happen (yet).

我没吃早饭。
Wǒ méi chī zǎofàn.

他昨天没来。
Tā zuótiān méi lái.

我还没去过。
Wǒ hái méi qù guo.

我今天没喝咖啡。

我	今天	没	喝	咖啡
I	today	didn't	drink	coffee

Wǒ jīntiān méi hē kāfēi.

I didn't drink coffee today.

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Feel the difference

我不喝咖啡。
Wǒ bù hē kāfēi.
I don't drink coffee.
A habit: I never drink it.

我没喝咖啡。
Wǒ méi hē kāfēi.
I didn't drink coffee.
A fact: it didn't happen.

WATCH OUT
有 (to have) is always made negative with 没: 我没有钱。 (I have no money.) *X* 我不有钱。

TIP
Remember: 不 becomes bú before a fourth tone: 不去 bú qù, 不是 bú shì, 不要 bú yào. Before other tones it stays bù: 不吃 bù chī.

MEMORY TRICK
Think of 没 as 'no event'. If you could have taken a photo of it happening and you can't, use 没.

Short answers

你吃饭了吗?
Nǐ chī fàn le ma?
Have you eaten?

还没吃。
Hái méi chī.
Not yet.

你明天来吗?
Nǐ míngtiān lái ma?
Are you coming tomorrow?

不来。
Bù lái.
No, I'm not.

Read each pair aloud and think about the difference.

我不吃肉。

我没吃肉。

他不来。

他没来。

我没有钱。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

36. 'I don't eat meat' (I'm vegetarian):

- ○ A) 我没吃肉。
- ○ B) 我不有肉。
- ○ C) 我没有吃。
- ○ D) 我不吃肉。

37. 'He didn't come yesterday':

- ○ A) 他昨天没来。
- ○ B) 他昨天不有来。
- ○ C) 他昨天不来。
- ○ D) 他没昨天来。

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38. Which is correct for 'I don't have a car'?

- ○ A) 我不车有。
- ○ B) 我不有车。
- ○ C) 我没有车。
- ○ D) 我没是车。

39. Listen. What does it mean? (listen in the web app: 我没吃早饭)

- ○ A) I don't eat breakfast.
- ○ B) I want breakfast.
- ○ C) I didn't eat breakfast.
- ○ D) I'll eat breakfast.

40. How is 不去 pronounced?

- ○ A) bù qù
- ○ B) bú qù
- ○ C) bǔ qù
- ○ D) bū qù

41. 'It isn't cold today':

- ○ A) 今天不冷。
- ○ B) 今天不有冷。
- ○ C) 今天没冷。
- ○ D) 今天冷不。

42. Listen. Is the speaker coming? (listen in the web app: 我明天不来)

- ○ A) Yes, coming
- ○ B) Came yesterday
- ○ C) Didn't come
- ○ D) No, not coming

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UNIT 4 · LESSON 7 · 14 MINUTES

Measure Words

个, 本, 杯, 张, 只, 件 and friends

- Use number + measure word + noun
- Choose the right measure word
- Use 这/那/哪 with measure words
- Use 两, not 二, before measure words

You met measure words in Unit 3. Now let's master them. Every time you count something, or say 'this one' or 'that one', a measure word slips in between.

Number / 这 / 那 / 哪 + measure word + noun

The measure word always sits right before the noun.

三个人 这本书 那杯咖啡 哪件衣服?

sān gè rén　zhè běn shū　nà bēi kāfēi　nǎ jiàn yīfu?

The most useful measure words

Measure word	Pinyin	Used for	Examples
个	gè	people and general things	一个人, 两个苹果
本	běn	books, magazines, notebooks	三本书
杯	bēi	cups and glasses of a drink	一杯水, 两杯茶
张	zhāng	flat things: paper, tickets, photos, beds, tables	一张床
只	zhī	most animals; one of a pair	一只猫, 一只手
件	jiàn	clothes for the top half; matters	一件衬衫, 一件事
条	tiáo	long, bendy things: fish, roads, trousers	一条鱼, 一条裤子
辆	liàng	vehicles	一辆车
位	wèi	people (polite)	三位老师

MEMORY TRICK

Picture them: 张 = a flat sheet, 条 = a ribbon, 只 = a single little animal, 本 = a book with a spine, 杯 = a cup (木: cups were once wooden).

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2 = 两 before a measure word

Counting things, use 两 (liǎng). Use 二 (èr) in counting, phone numbers and in 12, 20, 22...

两个人 liǎng gè rén　两本书 liǎng běn shū　十二个人 shí'èr gè rén

我买两本书。

我	买	两	本	书
I	buy	two	(measure word for books)	books

Wǒ mǎi liǎng běn shū.

I'm buying two books.

这只猫很可爱。

这	只	猫	很	可爱
this	(measure word for animals)	cat	very	cute

Zhè zhī māo hěn kě'ài.

This cat is very cute.

TIP

In fast speech 个 is often said with a light, neutral tone: 'ge'. And if you forget a measure word, 个 will usually still be understood.

WATCH OUT

只 (zhī) and 支 (zhī, for pens) sound the same. 一只狗 = a dog, 一支笔 = a pen. You may also hear 一条狗 for a dog.

我要一杯咖啡。

Wǒ yào yì bēi kāfēi.

I'd like a coffee.

这张照片很漂亮。

Zhè zhāng zhàopiàn hěn piàoliang.

This photo is beautiful.

我有一件事。

Wǒ yǒu yí jiàn shì.

There's something I need to tell you.

这条路很长。

Zhè tiáo lù hěn cháng.

This road is very long.

你要哪个?

Nǐ yào nǎge?

Which one do you want?

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Count the things around you with the right measure word.

一个人

两本书

三杯水

四张纸

五只猫

一件衣服

一条鱼

Quick quiz

QUIZ

43. Fill the gap: 一 ___ 书

- A) 只
- B) 件
- C) 张
- D) 本

44. Fill the gap: 一 ___ 猫

- A) 只
- B) 本
- C) 杯
- D) 张

45. Fill the gap: 两 ___ 衣服

- A) 辆
- B) 本
- C) 件
- D) 张

46. Choose the correct way to say 'two people'.

- A) 二人们
- B) 两人个
- C) 两个人
- D) 二个人

47. Fill the gap: 三 ___ 咖啡

- A) 张
- B) 本
- C) 杯
- D) 只

48. Listen. What is it? (listen in the web app: 一辆车)

- A) a book
- B) a car
- C) a cat
- D) a fish

49. Which measure word is for long, bendy things like fish and trousers?

- A) 杯
- B) 张
- C) 位
- D) 条

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50. Listen. How many tickets? (listen in the web app: 两张票)

- ○ A) 3
- ○ B) 10
- ○ C) 2
- ○ D) 4

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的

UNIT 4 · LESSON 8 · 12 MINUTES

的: Possession & Description

My, your, the teacher's... and 'the red one'

- Show possession with 的
- Know when to drop 的
- Use adjective + 的 + noun
- Ask 'Whose is it?'

的 (de) is the most common character in Chinese. Its main job is just like English **'s**: 老师的书 = the teacher's book.

A 的 B = A's B

The owner comes first, then 的, then the thing.

我的书	老师的电脑	妈妈的车	中国的茶
wǒ de shū	lǎoshī de diànnǎo	māma de chē	Zhōngguó de chá

这是我朋友的手机。

这	是	我	朋友	的	手机
this	is	my	friend	's	phone

Zhè shì wǒ péngyou de shǒujī.

This is my friend's phone.

My, your, his...

Chinese	Pinyin	Meaning
我的	wǒ de	my, mine
你的	nǐ de	your, yours
他的 / 她的	tā de	his / her, hers
我们的	wǒmen de	our, ours
你们的	nǐmen de	your, yours (plural)
他们的	tāmen de	their, theirs

MEMORY TRICK

Pronoun + 的 gives both 'my' AND 'mine': 我的书 (my book), 这是我的。 (This is mine.)

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Drop 的 for close people and groups

With family, close friends, and groups you belong to, 的 is usually left out.

我妈妈 wǒ māma　我朋友 wǒ péngyou　我们学校 wǒmen xuéxiào　我家 wǒ jiā

Adjective + 的 + noun

Longer adjectives, or adjectives with 很, take 的 before the noun. Short one-character adjectives usually don't.

很好的朋友 hěn hǎo de péngyou　漂亮的衣服 piàoliang de yīfu　好朋友 hǎo péngyou　新手机 xīn shǒujī

TIP

Leave out the noun and 的 means 'the … one': 红的 = the red one, 我的 = mine, 贵的 = the expensive one.

这本书是谁的?
Zhè běn shū shì shéi de?
Whose book is this?

是我的。
Shì wǒ de.
It's mine.

我要红的。
Wǒ yào hóng de.
I want the red one.

她是我最好的朋友。
Tā shì wǒ zuì hǎo de péngyou.
She's my best friend.

Lost property

Teacher 这是谁的杯子?
Zhè shì shéi de bēizi?
Whose cup is this?

Amy 不是我的。我的杯子是红的。
Bú shì wǒ de. Wǒ de bēizi shì hóng de.
It's not mine. My cup is the red one.

Ben 是我的！谢谢老师。
Shì wǒ de! Xièxie lǎoshī.
It's mine! Thank you, teacher.

Teacher 那这本书呢?
Nà zhè běn shū ne?
And this book?

Amy 那是我哥哥的。
Nà shì wǒ gēge de.
That's my brother's.

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Point at things and say whose they are.

我的手机

你的书

老师的电脑

我妈妈

这是谁的?

是我的。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

51. How do you say 'the teacher's car'?

- ○ A) 的老师车
- ○ B) 老师车的
- ○ C) 车的老师
- ○ D) 老师的车

52. Listen. What is the question? (listen in the web app: 这是谁的)

- ○ A) Where is this?
- ○ B) Who is this?
- ○ C) What is this?
- ○ D) Whose is this?

53. Which is most natural for 'my mum'?

- ○ A) 妈妈我的
- ○ B) 我妈妈
- ○ C) 妈妈的我
- ○ D) 我的的妈妈

54. 红的 means...

- ○ A) the red one
- ○ B) red tea
- ○ C) very red
- ○ D) not red

55. Which one needs 的?

- ○ A) 我___妈妈
- ○ B) 新___手机
- ○ C) 好___朋友
- ○ D) 很好___朋友

56. 这是我的。 means...

- ○ A) I am here.
- ○ B) It's my turn.
- ○ C) This is mine.
- ○ D) This is me.

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UNIT 4 · LESSON 9 · 14 MINUTES

在: Where & What's Happening

Location, place of action, and actions in progress

- Say where someone or something is
- Use place words like 上, 里, 旁边
- Say where you do something
- Talk about actions in progress

在 (zài) is a hard-working little word with three jobs: 'to be at', 'at/in (a place)' and '-ing' (doing right now). Let's take them one at a time.

Job 1: X 在 place

在 is the verb 'to be at / in'.

我在家。
Wǒ zài jiā.

书在桌子上。
Shū zài zhuōzi shang.

我妈妈在上海。
Wǒ māma zài Shànghǎi.

Place words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
上	shàng	on, above — one
下	xià	under, below — one
里	lǐ	inside 里 village
外	wài	outside 夕 evening
旁边	pángbiān	next to 方 square
前面	qiánmiàn	in front 刂 knife
后面	hòumiàn	behind 口 mouth
这儿	zhèr	here 辶 walk
那儿	nàr	there 阝 city

WATCH OUT

The place word comes AFTER the thing: 桌子上 = 'table-on' = on the table; 包里 = 'bag-inside' = in the bag. English does it the other way round.

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Job 2: 在 + place + verb

To say WHERE you do something, put 在 + place before the verb.

我在银行工作。
Wǒ zài yínháng gōngzuò.

他在家看电视。
Tā zài jiā kàn diànshì.

我在学校吃午饭。

我	在	学校	吃	午饭
I	at	school	eat	lunch

Wǒ zài xuéxiào chī wǔfàn.

I have lunch at school.

English: I eat lunch AT SCHOOL. Chinese: I AT SCHOOL eat lunch.

Job 3: 在 + verb = doing now

Put 在 (or 正在) right before the verb for an action in progress. 呢 at the end makes it sound natural.

我在吃饭。
Wǒ zài chī fàn.

他在看电视。
Tā zài kàn diànshì.

她正在睡觉呢。
Tā zhèngzài shuìjiào ne.

你在做什么?

你	在	做	什么
you	(doing now)	do	what

Nǐ zài zuò shénme?

What are you doing?

TIP

Negatives: 不在 = not at a place (他不在家。 He's not home). 没在 = not doing it right now (我没在看电视。 I'm not watching TV).

On the phone

Xiaoli 喂，你在哪儿?
Wéi, nǐ zài nǎr?
Hello, where are you?

Dan 我在家。
Wǒ zài jiā.
I'm at home.

Xiaoli 你在做什么?
Nǐ zài zuò shénme?
What are you doing?

Dan 我在做饭。你呢?
Wǒ zài zuò fàn. Nǐ ne?
I'm cooking. And you?

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Xiaoli 我在超市买东西。
Wǒ zài chāoshì mǎi dōngxi.
I'm shopping at the supermarket.

Dan 那你买一点儿水果吧!
Nà nǐ mǎi yìdiǎnr shuǐguǒ ba!
Then buy some fruit!

CULTURE NOTE

On the phone, Chinese people answer with 喂? (wéi), a 'hello' used only for calls.

Say where you are and what you're doing right now.

我在家。

我在学中文。

手机在桌子上。

钥匙在包里。

你在做什么?

Quick quiz

QUIZ

57. How do you say 'The book is on the table'?

- ○ A) 书在桌子上。
- ○ B) 在桌子上书。
- ○ C) 书上在桌子。
- ○ D) 书在上桌子。

58. Listen. What is he doing? (listen in the web app: 他在看电视)

- ○ A) sleeping
- ○ B) watching TV
- ○ C) working
- ○ D) eating

59. Choose the correct order: 'I work at a bank.'

- ○ A) 我银行在工作。
- ○ B) 在我银行工作。
- ○ C) 我在银行工作。
- ○ D) 我工作在银行。

60. 你在做什么? means...

- ○ A) What do you want?
- ○ B) What do you do?
- ○ C) What are you doing?
- ○ D) Where are you?

61. 里 means...

- ○ A) inside
- ○ B) behind
- ○ C) outside
- ○ D) on

62. Listen. Where is the speaker? (listen in the web app: 我在家)

- ○ A) at the shop
- ○ B) at work
- ○ C) at school
- ○ D) at home

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63. 'He's not at home' is...

- ○ A) 他不在家。
- ○ B) 他没是家。
- ○ C) 他不有家。
- ○ D) 他在不家。

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了

UNIT 4 · LESSON 10 · 14 MINUTES

了: Completed Actions

Done, finished, and things that have changed

- Use verb + 了 for completed actions
- Ask 'Have you...?' with 了吗
- Make negatives with 没 (no 了)
- Use 了 at the end for a change

Chinese verbs have no past tense. Instead, a tiny word 了 (le) tells you an action is **done**. It's not exactly 'past', it's 'completed'.

Verb + 了

了 after a verb shows the action is complete. It is very common with a number or amount.

我吃了。
Wǒ chī le.

我买了三本书。
Wǒ mǎi le sān běn shū.

他喝了两杯咖啡。
Tā hē le liǎng bēi kāfēi.

我昨天看了一个电影。

我	昨天	看	了	一	个	电影
I	yesterday	watch	(done)	one	(measure word)	film

Wǒ zuótiān kàn le yí gè diànyǐng.

I watched a film yesterday.

Questions and negatives

Ask with 了吗? or 了没有? Answer yes with verb + 了. For no, use 没 + verb, and drop 了!

你吃饭了吗?
Nǐ chī fàn le ma?

吃了。
Chī le.

我没吃。
Wǒ méi chī.

还没吃。
Hái méi chī.

WATCH OUT

✗ 我没吃了。 ✓ 我没吃。 没 and 了 don't go together.

MEMORY TRICK

Think of 了 as a tick ✓ on your to-do list: 我买了 = 'buy ✓'.

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了 at the end: something changed

At the end of a sentence, 了 shows a new situation: 'now...'.

我饿了。 Wǒ è le.

下雨了！ Xià yǔ le!

我二十岁了。 Wǒ èrshí suì le.

他是老师了。 Tā shì lǎoshī le.

TIP

Not every past sentence needs 了. Descriptions and habits in the past don't take it: 昨天很冷。(It was cold yesterday.) 我以前是老师。(I used to be a teacher.)

Words for this lesson

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
电影	diànyǐng	film, movie 彡 hair
早饭	zǎofàn	breakfast 饣 food
午饭	wǔfàn	lunch 饣 food
晚饭	wǎnfàn	dinner 饣 food
下雨	xià yǔ	to rain 雨 rain
还没	hái méi	not yet

Morning at home

Mum 你吃早饭了吗?
Nǐ chī zǎofàn le ma?
Have you had breakfast?

Leo 吃了。我吃了两个包子。
Chī le. Wǒ chī le liǎng gè bāozi.
Yes. I had two steamed buns.

Mum 你做作业了吗?
Nǐ zuò zuòyè le ma?
Have you done your homework?

Leo 还没做.....
Hái méi zuò...
Not yet...

Mum 快做吧！八点了！
Kuài zuò ba! Bā diǎn le!
Do it quickly! It's eight o'clock already!

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Read aloud. Then say three things you did today.

我吃了。

我买了一本书。

你吃饭了吗?

还没吃。

下雨了!

我饿了。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

64. How do you say 'I bought three books'?

- ○ A) 我买三了本书。
- ○ B) 我了买三本书。
- ○ C) 我买了三本书。
- ○ D) 我买三本书了了。

65. Which sentence is WRONG?

- ○ A) 我没吃。
- ○ B) 我吃了。
- ○ C) 我还没吃。
- ○ D) 我没吃了。

66. Listen. What happened? (listen in the web app: 下雨了)

- ○ A) It's sunny.
- ○ B) It stopped raining.
- ○ C) It will rain.
- ○ D) It started raining.

67. Someone asks 你吃饭了吗? You haven't eaten yet. You say...

- ○ A) 吃了没。
- ○ B) 没吃了。
- ○ C) 不吃了。
- ○ D) 还没吃。

68. 我饿了 means...

- ○ A) I was hungry.
- ○ B) I ate.
- ○ C) I'm not hungry.
- ○ D) I'm hungry (now).

69. Listen. What did the speaker do? (listen in the web app: 我看了一个电影)

- ○ A) ate breakfast
- ○ B) watched a film
- ○ C) bought a book
- ○ D) drank coffee

70. Which sentence does NOT need 了?

- ○ A) 我吃___两个包子。
- ○ B) 下雨___!
- ○ C) 我买___三本书。
- ○ D) 昨天很冷___。

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想

UNIT 4 · LESSON 11 · 16 MINUTES

Want, Can, May: 想 要 会 能 可以

Wishes, skills, abilities and permission

- Say what you want with 想 and 要
- Say what you can do with 会 and 能
- Ask permission with 可以
- Choose the right negative

These five little verbs go right before another verb, like 'want to', 'can' and 'may' in English. English has one 'can'; Chinese has three! Let's sort them out.

The five helpers

Word	Pinyin	Meaning	Example	Negative
想	xiǎng	would like to, want to	我想喝水。	不想
要	yào	want to (firmly); will; need to	我要去北京。	不想 / 不用
会	huì	can (learned skill); will probably	我会说中文。	不会
能	néng	can (able, possible)	你能来吗?	不能
可以	kěyǐ	may, can (allowed)	我可以坐这儿吗?	不可以

想: would like to

Soft and polite. It also means 'to miss' and 'to think'.

我想去中国。
Wǒ xiǎng qù Zhōngguó.

你想吃什么?
Nǐ xiǎng chī shénme?

我想你。
Wǒ xiǎng nǐ.

要: want / going to / need to

Stronger than 想. With a noun it means 'I'll have...'.

我要一杯咖啡。
Wǒ yào yì bēi kāfēi.

明天我要考试。
Míngtiān wǒ yào kǎoshì.

你要多喝水。
Nǐ yào duō hē shuǐ.

WATCH OUT

不要 doesn't mean 'don't want'. It means **Don't!** 不要说话! = Don't talk! For 'don't want to' say 不想; for 'no need' say 不用.

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你会说中文吗?

你	会	说	中文	吗
you	can (know how to)	speak	Chinese	(question)

Nǐ huì shuō Zhōngwén ma?

Can you speak Chinese?

Perfect reply for now: 会一点儿 (Huì yìdiǎnr, a little).

会, 能 or 可以?

我会游泳。

会: a skill you learned

I can swim (I know how).

我今天能游泳。

能: able / possible now

I can swim today (I'm well, the pool is open).

这儿可以游泳。

可以: allowed

You may swim here (it's permitted).

你会开车吗?

Nǐ huì kāichē ma?

Can you drive?

明天会下雨。

Míngtiān huì xià yǔ.

It will probably rain tomorrow.

你能帮我吗?

Nǐ néng bāng wǒ ma?

Can you help me?

我感冒了，不能去。

Wǒ gǎnmào le, bù néng qù.

I've got a cold, so I can't go.

我可以进来吗?

Wǒ kěyǐ jìnlái ma?

May I come in?

这儿不可以抽烟。

Zhèr bù kěyǐ chōuyān.

Smoking is not allowed here.

MEMORY TRICK

会: you went to class and learned it. 能: your body or the situation lets you. 可以: someone says it's OK.

TIP

To answer, just use the helper word: 你会游泳吗? → 会。 / 不会。

At the swimming pool

Coach 你会游泳吗?
Nǐ huì yóuyǒng ma?
Can you swim?

Yan 会，可是今天不能游。
Huì, kěshì jīntiān bù néng yóu.
Yes, but I can't swim today.

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Coach 为什么?
Wèishénme?
Why?

Yan 我感冒了。我可以明天来吗?
Wǒ gǎnmào le. Wǒ kěyǐ míngtiān lái ma?
I've got a cold. Can I come tomorrow?

Coach 可以。你要多喝水，多休息!
Kěyǐ. Nǐ yào duō hē shuǐ, duō xiūxi!
Sure. You need to drink lots of water and rest!

Say what you want, can and may do.

我想去中国。

我要一杯茶。

我会说一点儿中文。

你能帮我吗?

我可以坐这儿吗?

Quick quiz

QUIZ

71. 'I can speak Chinese' (I learned it):

- A) 我可以说中文。
- B) 我要说中文。
- C) 我会说中文。
- D) 我说会中文。

72. 'May I come in?'

- A) 我想进来吗?
- B) 我可以进来吗?
- C) 我进来可以吗了?
- D) 我会进来吗?

73. Listen. What does it mean? (listen in the web app: 不要说话)

- A) Don't talk!
- B) Can't talk now.
- C) I don't want to talk.
- D) No need to talk.

74. 'I don't want to go' is...

- A) 我不要去。
- B) 我没想去。
- C) 我不会去。
- D) 我不想去。

75. Listen. What is the speaker asking? (listen in the web app: 你能帮我吗)

- A) Can I help you?
- B) Do you want help?
- C) Do you know him?
- D) Can you help me?

76. Which helper means 'allowed'?

- A) 要
- B) 会
- C) 可以
- D) 想

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77. 我想你 means...

- ○ A) I think so.
- ○ B) I want you to go.
- ○ C) I miss you.
- ○ D) I know you.

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UNIT 4 · LESSON 12 · 13 MINUTES

Comparisons with 比

Taller, cheaper, colder… and the same

- Compare with A 比 B + adjective
- Say how much more
- Say 'not as … as' with 没有
- Say 'the same' with 一样

Comparing things in Chinese uses one magic word: 比 (bǐ, compared with). No '-er' endings, no 'more'. Just A 比 B + adjective.

A 比 B + adjective

Read it as 'A, compared with B, is …'.

我比我哥哥高。
Wǒ bǐ wǒ gēge gāo.

今天比昨天冷。
Jīntiān bǐ zuótiān lěng.

茶比咖啡便宜。
Chá bǐ kāfēi piányi.

冬天，北京比上海冷。

冬天	北京	比	上海	冷
winter	Beijing	compared with	Shanghai	cold

Dōngtiān, Běijīng bǐ Shànghǎi lěng.

In winter, Beijing is colder than Shanghai.

WATCH OUT

No 很 in a 比 sentence! ✗ 我比他很高。 ✓ 我比他高。

How much more?

Add the amount AFTER the adjective: 一点儿 (a bit), 得多 or 多了 (much).

我比他高一点儿。
Wǒ bǐ tā gāo yìdiǎnr.

这个比那个贵得多。
Zhège bǐ nàge guì de duō.

地铁比公交车快多了。
Dìtiě bǐ gōngjiāochē kuài duō le.

TIP

To say 'even more', put 更 (gèng) or 还 (hái) before the adjective: 她比我更忙。 (She's even busier than me.)

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A 没有 B + adjective

'A is not as … as B'.

我没有他高。
Wǒ méiyǒu tā gāo.

今天没有昨天热。
Jīntiān méiyǒu zuótiān rè.

A 跟 B 一样 (+ adjective)

'A is the same (as B)'.

我跟你一样大。
Wǒ gēn nǐ yíyàng dà.

这两个一样。
Zhè liǎng gè yíyàng.

MEMORY TRICK

比 looks like two people standing side by side, being compared. Who's taller?

Adjectives for comparing

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
快	kuài	fast 忄 heart
慢	màn	slow 忄 heart
长	cháng	long
短	duǎn	short (length) 矢 arrow
矮	ǎi	short (height) 矢 arrow
新	xīn	new 斤 axe
旧	jiù	old (things) 日 sun
一样	yíyàng	the same

Clothes shopping

Shopper 这件多少钱?
Zhè jiàn duōshao qián?
How much is this one?

Seller 两百块。
Liǎng bǎi kuài.
Two hundred kuai.

Shopper 那件呢?
Nà jiàn ne?
And that one?

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Seller 那件比这件便宜，一百五。
Nà jiàn bǐ zhè jiàn piányi, yìbǎi wǔ.
That one is cheaper: a hundred and fifty.

Shopper 可是这件比那件漂亮多了。
Kěshì zhè jiàn bǐ nà jiàn piàoliang duō le.
But this one is much prettier than that one.

Seller 对！一分钱一分货。
Duì! Yì fēn qián yì fēn huò.
Right! You get what you pay for.

Compare yourself with someone in your family.

我比我妹妹高。

我没有我爸爸高。

我跟我哥哥一样大。

今天比昨天热。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

78. 'I am taller than him':

- ○ A) 我高比他。
- ○ B) 我比他高。
- ○ C) 我比他很高。
- ○ D) 他比我高。

79. Which sentence is WRONG?

- ○ A) 今天没有昨天冷。
- ○ B) 今天比昨天很冷。
- ○ C) 今天比昨天冷一点儿。
- ○ D) 今天比昨天冷。

80. Listen. What does it mean? (listen in the web app: 我没有他高)

- ○ A) I'm not as tall as him.
- ○ B) We're the same height.
- ○ C) He's not tall.
- ○ D) I'm taller than him.

81. 我跟你一样大 means...

- ○ A) We're both tall.
- ○ B) I'm older than you.
- ○ C) You're bigger than me.
- ○ D) We're the same age.

82. 'The subway is much faster than the bus':

- ○ A) 地铁比公交车快多了。
- ○ B) 公交车比地铁快多了。
- ○ C) 地铁比公交车多快了。
- ○ D) 地铁多了比公交车快。

83. Listen. Which is cheaper? (listen in the web app: 茶比咖啡便宜)

- ○ A) the same
- ○ B) neither
- ○ C) tea
- ○ D) coffee

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时

UNIT 4 · LESSON 13 · 12 MINUTES

Where Do Time Words Go?

When comes early in a Chinese sentence

- Put time words before the verb
- Order time, place and action
- Go from big to small in time phrases
- Put 'how long' after the verb

In English, we often put the time at the end: 'I'm going to Beijing **tomorrow**.' Chinese puts it early, before the verb: 'I **tomorrow** go to Beijing.'

Subject + time + place + verb

Time comes first, then place, then the action.

我明天去北京。
Wǒ míngtiān qù Běijīng.

我每天早上七点起床。
Wǒ měitiān zǎoshang qī diǎn qǐchuáng.

他下午在图书馆看书。
Tā xiàwǔ zài túshūguǎn kàn shū.

Or time at the very front

You can also start the sentence with the time. Both are correct.

明天我去北京。
Míngtiān wǒ qù Běijīng.

周末我们去公园。
Zhōumò wǒmen qù gōngyuán.

WATCH OUT

✗ 我去北京明天。 Time never goes at the end like in English.

MEMORY TRICK

When → Where → What. First set the time, then the place, then the action, like setting a scene in a film.

我晚上八点在家吃饭。

我	晚上	八点	在	家	吃饭
I	evening	eight o'clock	at	home	eat (a meal)

Wǒ wǎnshang bā diǎn zài jiā chī fàn.

I have dinner at home at 8 p.m.

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Big to small

Time phrases start with the biggest unit, like dates do.

明天上午十点　下个星期五晚上　二〇二五年八月

míngtiān shàngwǔ shí diǎn　xià gè xīngqīwǔ wǎnshang　èr líng èr wǔ nián bāyuè

Time words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
每天	měitiān	every day
以前	yǐqián	before, in the past
以后	yǐhòu	after, later, in future
去年	qùnián	last year
明年	míngnián	next year 日 sun
上个星期	shàng gè xīngqī	last week
下个月	xià gè yuè	next month
刚才	gāngcái	just now 刂 knife
起床	qǐchuáng	to get up 广 shelter
图书馆	túshūguǎn	library

TIP

How long you do something is different: it goes AFTER the verb. 我学了两年中文。(I studied Chinese for two years.) 我每天学习一个小时。(I study for an hour every day.)

我去年去了中国。

Wǒ qùnián qù le Zhōngguó.

I went to China last year.

你明天几点来?

Nǐ míngtiān jǐ diǎn lái?

What time are you coming tomorrow?

我们下个月在上海见。

Wǒmen xià gè yuè zài Shànghǎi jiàn.

We'll meet in Shanghai next month.

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Describe your day in order: when → where → what.

我每天七点起床。

我八点在学校学习。

我中午在饭馆吃饭。

我晚上在家看书。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

84. 'I'm going to Beijing tomorrow':

- ○ A) 去北京我明天。
- ○ B) 我去明天北京。
- ○ C) 我去北京明天。
- ○ D) 我明天去北京。

85. Put it in order: 'I eat at home at 7 p.m.'

- ○ A) 我吃饭在家晚上七点。
- ○ B) 我晚上七点在家吃饭。
- ○ C) 晚上七点吃饭我在家。
- ○ D) 我在家吃饭晚上七点。

86. Listen. When is the speaker going? (listen in the web app: 我下个月去上海)

- ○ A) next week
- ○ B) tomorrow
- ○ C) last month
- ○ D) next month

87. Which time phrase is in the right order?

- ○ A) 明天上午十点
- ○ B) 十点明天上午
- ○ C) 上午明天十点
- ○ D) 十点上午明天

88. 'I studied Chinese for two years': where does 'two years' go?

- ○ A) After the verb
- ○ B) Before the subject
- ○ C) At the very start
- ○ D) Before the verb

89. 刚才 means...

- ○ A) last year
- ○ B) every day
- ○ C) just now
- ○ D) later on

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UNIT 4 · LESSON 14 · 12 MINUTES

过: Have You Ever...?

Talking about experiences

- Say what you have done before with 过
- Ask 'Have you ever...?'
- Make negatives with 没...过
- Tell 了 and 过 apart

Have you ever eaten Peking duck? Been to Shanghai? To talk about experiences, put 过 (guo) right after the verb.

Verb + 过 = have done (before)

过 says you have had this experience at least once.

我去过中国。
Wǒ qù guo Zhōngguó.

我吃过北京烤鸭。
Wǒ chī guo Běijīng kǎoyā.

他看过这个电影。
Tā kàn guo zhège diànyǐng.

你去过上海吗?

你	去	过	上海	吗
you	go	(have ever)	Shanghai	(question)

Nǐ qù guo Shànghǎi ma?

Have you ever been to Shanghai?

Answering 你吃过饺子吗?

吃过。
Chī guo.
Yes, I have (eaten it).

没吃过。
Méi chī guo.
No, I've never eaten it.

没 + verb + 过

For 'have never', use 没 and KEEP 过. Add 从来 (cónglái) for 'never ever'.

我没去过日本。
Wǒ méi qù guo Rìběn.

我从来没吃过榴莲。
Wǒ cónglái méi chī guo liúlián.

WATCH OUT

The negative of 了 drops 了 (我没吃), but the negative of 过 keeps 过 (我没吃过).

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了 or 过?

我去了北京。

了: it happened

I went to Beijing (maybe I'm still there).

我去过北京。

过: an experience

I've been to Beijing before (and came back).

MEMORY TRICK

过 also means 'to pass, to cross'. An experience is something you have 'passed through'.

Words for this lesson

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
北京烤鸭	Běijīng kǎoyā	Peking duck 火 fire
榴莲	liúlián	durian (a very smelly fruit) 木 tree
从来	cónglái	ever, always (从来没 = never)
次	cì	time(s), occasion 我去过两次。 (Wǒ qù guo liǎng cì.) — I've been twice.
爬	pá	to climb 爪 claw
长城	Chángchéng	the Great Wall 土 earth

Travel stories

Hong 你来过中国吗?
Nǐ lái guo Zhōngguó ma?
Have you been to China?

Eva 来过一次。我去过北京。
Lái guo yí cì. Wǒ qù guo Běijīng.
Once. I've been to Beijing.

Hong 你爬过长城吗?
Nǐ pá guo Chángchéng ma?
Have you climbed the Great Wall?

Eva 爬过！也吃过北京烤鸭。
Pá guo! Yě chī guo Běijīng kǎoyā.
Yes! And I've eaten Peking duck too.

Hong 你吃过榴莲吗?
Nǐ chī guo liúlián ma?
Have you ever eaten durian?

Eva 没吃过，我不敢!
Méi chī guo, wǒ bù gǎn!
Never. I don't dare!

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Say three things you have done and one you have never done.

我去过……

我吃过饺子。

我看过中国电影。

我没去过中国。

我从来没吃过榴莲。

Unit check

Check yourself

☐ I can build subject–verb–object sentences.

☐ I use 很 (not 是) with adjectives.

☐ I can ask questions with 吗 and question words.

☐ I know when to use 不 and when to use 没.

☐ I can use measure words, 的 and 在.

☐ I can talk about the past with 了 and 过.

☐ I can compare with 比 and put time words in the right place.

Give your work today some stars ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆

Quick quiz

QUIZ

90. 'I have been to China':

- ○ A) 我去中国过。
- ○ B) 我过去中国。
- ○ C) 我去过中国。
- ○ D) 过我去中国。

91. 'I have never eaten durian':

- ○ A) 我没吃榴莲了。
- ○ B) 我不吃过榴莲。
- ○ C) 我没吃过榴莲。
- ○ D) 我吃没过榴莲。

92. Listen. What is the question? (listen in the web app: 你去过上海吗)

- ○ A) Do you live in Shanghai?
- ○ B) Where is Shanghai?
- ○ C) Are you going to Shanghai?
- ○ D) Have you been to Shanghai?

93. Which sentence talks about an EXPERIENCE?

- ○ A) 我要看电影。
- ○ B) 我在看电影。
- ○ C) 我看过这个电影。
- ○ D) 我想看电影。

94. Listen. How many times? (listen in the web app: 我去过两次)

- ○ A) three times
- ○ B) once
- ○ C) twice
- ○ D) never

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95. 从来没 means...

- ○ A) already
- ○ B) never ever
- ○ C) sometimes
- ○ D) always

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UNIT 4

Answer key

1. D) 他喝茶。

2. C) 他们

3. D) 你爱我

4. C) we

5. A) 书
Nouns don't change. 书 = book or books.

6. C) 它

7. B) Mum cooks.

8. C) 我不是医生。

9. B) 我是忙。
Adjectives don't take 是. Say 我很忙.

10. C) Who is he?

11. A) 我也是学生。

12. A) bú shì
不 becomes bú before a fourth tone.

13. C) 我二十岁。

14. B) 我很累。

15. C) a bit cold

16. D) Too expensive!

17. D) ㄋ

18. D) 不忙

19. C) interesting

20. D) extremely good

21. B) 你是学生吗?

22. B) 不忙。

23. A) Do you like cats?

24. D) 你去不去吗?

25. C) And you?

26. B) 没有。

27. A) Yes, I like it.

28. C) who

29. A) 我去银行。

30. D) How much is it?

31. A) 你吃什么吗?
Question words don't take 吗.

32. B) 你几岁?

33. A) how to say something

34. B) why

35. D) 多少

36. D) 我不吃肉。

37. A) 他昨天没来。

38. C) 我没有车。

39. C) I didn't eat breakfast.

40. B) bú qù

41. A) 今天不冷。

42. D) No, not coming

43. D) 本

44. A) 只

45. C) 件

46. C) 两个人

47. C) 杯

48. B) a car

49. D) 条

50. C) 2

51. D) 老师的车

52. D) Whose is this?

53. B) 我妈妈
With close family 的 is usually dropped.

54. A) the red one

55. D) 很好___朋友

56. C) This is mine.

57. A) 书在桌子上。

58. B) watching TV

59. C) 我在银行工作。

60. C) What are you doing?

61. A) inside

62. D) at home

63. A) 他不在家。

64. C) 我买了三本书。

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65. D) 我没吃了。

66. D) It started raining.

67. D) 还没吃。

68. D) I'm hungry (now).

69. B) watched a film

70. D) 昨天很冷___。

71. C) 我会说中文。

72. B) 我可以进来吗?

73. A) Don't talk!

74. D) 我不想去。
不要去 sounds like 'Don't go!'

75. D) Can you help me?

76. C) 可以

77. C) I miss you.

78. B) 我比他高。

79. B) 今天比昨天很冷。

80. A) I'm not as tall as him.

81. D) We're the same age.

82. A) 地铁比公交车快多了。

83. C) tea

84. D) 我明天去北京。

85. B) 我晚上七点在家吃饭。

86. D) next month

87. A) 明天上午十点

88. A) After the verb

89. C) just now

90. C) 我去过中国。

91. C) 我没吃过榴莲。

92. D) Have you been to Shanghai?

93. C) 我看过这个电影。

94. C) twice

95. B) never ever

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UNIT 5

Everyday Conversations

Real-life Mandarin for restaurants, shops, travel, phones, plans, the doctor and work.

1. Ordering at a Restaurant
2. Shopping & Bargaining
3. Asking for Directions
4. Taxi & Subway
5. At the Hotel
6. Phone Calls & Messaging
7. Making Plans
8. At the Doctor
9. Small Talk & the Weather
10. At School & Work

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饭

UNIT 5 · LESSON 1 · 15 MINUTES

Ordering at a Restaurant

Get a table, order dishes, ask about spice and pay the bill.

- Answer “How many people?” and ask for the menu
- Order dishes with 来 and 要
- Ask if a dish is spicy
- Ask for the bill and take leftovers away

Eating out is one of the best parts of life in China. Food is cheap, tasty and shared by the whole table. In this lesson you will get a table, order, ask about spice and pay.

Key words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
服务员	fúwùyuán	waiter, waitress 服务员，菜单！ (Fúwùyuán, càidān!) — Excuse me, the menu please!
菜单	càidān	menu
点菜	diǎn cài	to order (dishes) 我们点菜吧。 (Wǒmen diǎn cài ba.) — Let's order.
米饭	mǐfàn	(cooked) rice
饺子	jiǎozi	dumplings
碗	wǎn	bowl (also a measure word) 一碗面 (yì wǎn miàn) — a bowl of noodles
辣	là	spicy, hot
好吃	hǎochī	tasty, delicious
买单	mǎidān	to pay the bill; “The bill, please!”
打包	dǎbāo	to pack (leftovers) to take away

At a Sichuan restaurant

Waiter 您好！几位?
Nín hǎo! Jǐ wèi?
Hello! How many people?

Anna 两位。
Liǎng wèi.
Two.

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Waiter 这边请。这是菜单。
Zhèbiān qǐng. Zhè shì càidān.
This way, please. Here is the menu.

Anna 你们这儿有什么好吃的?
Nǐmen zhèr yǒu shénme hǎochī de?
What's good here?

Waiter 我们的宫保鸡丁很有名。
Wǒmen de gōngbǎo jīdīng hěn yǒumíng.
Our kung pao chicken is famous.

Anna 辣不辣?
Là bu là?
Is it spicy?

Waiter 有一点儿辣。
Yǒu yìdiǎnr là.
A little spicy.

Anna 好，来一个宫保鸡丁，两碗米饭，一壶茶。
Hǎo, lái yí ge gōngbǎo jīdīng, liǎng wǎn mǐfàn, yì hú chá.
OK, one kung pao chicken, two bowls of rice and a pot of tea.

Waiter 好的，请稍等。
Hǎo de, qǐng shāo děng.
Sure, one moment please.

Anna 服务员，买单!
Fúwùyuán, mǎidān!
Excuse me, the bill please!

TIP

To order, say 来 (lái, 'bring') or 要 (yào, 'want') + number + measure word + dish: 来一盘饺子 = 'a plate of dumplings, please'.

我要一碗牛肉面。

我	要	一	碗	牛肉	面
I	want	one	bowl (measure word)	beef	noodles

Wǒ yào yì wǎn niúròu miàn.

I'd like a bowl of beef noodles.

请不要放辣椒。

请	不要	放	辣椒
please	don't	put in	chilli pepper

Qǐng bú yào fàng làjiāo.

Please don't add chilli.

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可以用手机付钱吗?

可以	用	手机	付钱	吗
can	use	mobile phone	pay	(question word)

Kěyǐ yòng shǒujī fù qián ma?

Can I pay with my phone?

CULTURE NOTE

Dishes are shared. Everyone orders together, the plates go in the middle and each person has a small bowl of rice. Tipping is not expected in mainland China.

CULTURE NOTE

Calling 服务员! across the room is normal and not rude. Many restaurants also have a QR code on the table: you scan it to order and pay on your phone.

Role-play: dinner for two

1 **Get a table**

两位。

Liǎng wèi.

Two people.

Answer the question 几位? (How many people?).

2 **Ask for the menu**

请给我菜单。

Qǐng gěi wǒ càidān.

Please give me the menu.

3 **Ask what's good**

有什么推荐的?

Yǒu shénme tuījiàn de?

What do you recommend?

4 **Order**

来一盘饺子，两碗米饭。

Lái yì pán jiǎozi, liǎng wǎn mǐfàn.

A plate of dumplings and two bowls of rice.

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5

Pay

买单!

Mǎidān!

The bill, please!

Then try 打包 if there is food left.

Say it aloud

Read each line aloud. Tap any word to hear it.

服务员，菜单!

我要一碗米饭。

辣不辣?

不要太辣。

太好吃了!

买单!

Quick quiz

QUIZ

1. What does 买单 mean?
   - ○ A) The menu, please!
   - ○ B) One more bowl!
   - ○ C) The bill, please!
   - ○ D) Not spicy, please!
2. Listen. What is being asked? (listen in the web app: 辣不辣？)
   - ○ A) Is it tasty?
   - ○ B) Is it expensive?
   - ○ C) Is the soup hot enough?
   - ○ D) Is it spicy?
3. The waiter greets you at the door. Which question means “How many people?”
   - ○ A) 几位?
   - ○ B) 多少钱?
   - ○ C) 几点?
   - ○ D) 哪里?
4. Which word means “menu”?
   - ○ A) 米饭
   - ○ B) 菜单
   - ○ C) 服务员
   - ○ D) 打包
5. You want to take the leftovers home. Which word do you need?
   - ○ A) 买单
   - ○ B) 点菜
   - ○ C) 好吃
   - ○ D) 打包
6. Is tipping expected in most restaurants in mainland China?
   - ○ A) Yes, about 10%
   - ○ B) Yes, always 20 percent
   - ○ C) No, not usually
   - ○ D) Only for big groups at dinner

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UNIT 5 · LESSON 2 · 15 MINUTES

买 Shopping & Bargaining

Ask prices, try things on and bargain with a smile.

- Ask “How much?” and understand prices
- Say “too expensive” and ask for a lower price
- Ask to try something on
- Know where bargaining is normal

Shopping in China ranges from huge malls to busy street markets. In this lesson you will ask prices, try things on and practise friendly bargaining.

Key words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
多少钱	duōshao qián	how much (money)? 这个多少钱？ (Zhège duōshao qián?) — How much is this?
块	kuài	yuan (spoken word for money)
贵	guì	expensive
便宜	piányi	cheap
一点儿	yìdiǎnr	a little, a bit 便宜一点儿吧。 (Piányi yìdiǎnr ba.) — Make it a bit cheaper.
试	shì	to try (on)
件	jiàn	measure word for tops and jackets 一件衣服 (yí jiàn yīfu) — a piece of clothing
衣服	yīfu	clothes
颜色	yánsè	colour
买	mǎi	to buy
卖	mài	to sell

Talking about money

Spoken	Written / on price tags	Value
块 kuài	元 yuán	1 yuan
毛 máo	角 jiǎo	0.1 yuan

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Spoken	Written / on price tags	Value
两块五 liǎng kuài wǔ	2.5元	2.50 yuan

At a clothes market

Ben 老板，这件衣服多少钱?
Lǎobǎn, zhè jiàn yīfu duōshao qián?
Excuse me (boss), how much is this top?

Seller 两百块。
Liǎngbǎi kuài.
200 yuan.

Ben 我可以试一下吗?
Wǒ kěyǐ shì yíxià ma?
Can I try it on?

Seller 可以，那边可以试。
Kěyǐ, nàbiān kěyǐ shì.
Sure, you can try it over there.

Ben 有点儿贵，便宜一点儿吧。
Yǒudiǎnr guì, piányi yìdiǎnr ba.
It's a bit expensive. Make it a little cheaper.

Seller 一百八，怎么样?
Yìbǎi bā, zěnmeyàng?
180, how about that?

Ben 一百块，可以吗?
Yìbǎi kuài, kěyǐ ma?
100 yuan, OK?

Seller 不行不行，一百五，最低了。
Bù xíng bù xíng, yìbǎi wǔ, zuì dī le.
No way. 150 is my lowest.

Ben 一百二吧，不行我就走了。
Yìbǎi èr ba, bù xíng wǒ jiù zǒu le.
Say 120. If not, I'll go.

Seller 好吧好吧，一百二，给你。
Hǎo ba hǎo ba, yìbǎi èr, gěi nǐ.
Fine, fine. 120, it's yours.

MEMORY TRICK

Short prices drop the last unit: 一百八 = 180 (not 108!) and 两块五 = 2.50 yuan.

这个多少钱?

这个	多少	钱
this	how much	money

Zhège duōshao qián?

How much is this?

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有没有大一点儿的?

有没有	大	一点儿	的
do you have	big	a bit	one (thing)

Yǒu méiyǒu dà yìdiǎnr de?

Do you have a bigger one?

我只是看看。

我	只是	看看
I	just	have a look

Wǒ zhǐshì kànkan.

I'm just looking.

CULTURE NOTE

Bargaining is normal at street markets and small stalls, and in tourist markets the first price can be far too high. In malls, supermarkets and chain stores prices are fixed, so don't bargain there.

TIP

Stay friendly and smile. Walking away politely is the strongest move: the seller may call you back with a better price.

Role-play: bargain for a souvenir

1 **Ask the price**

这个多少钱?

Zhège duōshao qián?

How much is this?

2 **React**

太贵了!

Tài guì le!

Too expensive!

3 **Make an offer**

五十块，可以吗?

Wǔshí kuài, kěyǐ ma?

50 yuan, OK?

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4 **Meet in the middle**

六十吧。

Liùshí ba.

Let's say 60.

5 **Close the deal**

好，我买了。

Hǎo, wǒ mǎi le.

OK, I'll take it.

Say it aloud

Read each line aloud, like a real shopper.

多少钱?

太贵了!

便宜一点儿吧。

我可以试一下吗?

有没有小一点儿的?

好，我买了。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

7. Listen. What does the speaker think? (listen in the web app: 太贵了！)

- ○ A) It's very cheap
- ○ B) It's too expensive
- ○ C) It's too small
- ○ D) It's the wrong colour for me

8. In everyday speech, the word for “yuan” is…

- ○ A) 块 (kuài)
- ○ B) 件 (jiàn)
- ○ C) 毛 (máo)
- ○ D) 个 (gè)

9. Where is bargaining normal?

- ○ A) At a street market
- ○ B) In a supermarket
- ○ C) At a big chain store
- ○ D) In a shopping mall shop

10. 便宜 means…

- ○ A) expensive
- ○ B) pretty
- ○ C) cheap
- ○ D) new

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11. How do you say “I'm just looking”?

- ○ A) 我可以试一下吗?
- ○ B) 我只是看看。
- ○ C) 我买了。
- ○ D) 太贵了!

12. The seller says 一百二. What is the price?

- ○ A) 102 yuan
- ○ B) 112 yuan
- ○ C) 1,200 yuan
- ○ D) 120 yuan

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路

UNIT 5 · LESSON 3 · 15 MINUTES

Asking for Directions

Find your way with left, right, straight on and landmarks.

- Ask where a place is and how to get there
- Understand left, right, straight and turn
- Describe where things are with position words

Even with a map app, it helps to ask a real person. Learn to ask where something is, follow simple directions and check that you understood.

Key words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
在哪儿	zài nǎr	where is...? 地铁站在哪儿？ (Dìtiězhàn zài nǎr?) — Where is the subway station?
怎么走	zěnme zǒu	how do I get there?
一直走	yìzhí zǒu	go straight on
往左拐	wǎng zuǒ guǎi	turn left
往右拐	wǎng yòu guǎi	turn right
路口	lùkǒu	intersection, crossing
红绿灯	hónglǜdēng	traffic lights
远	yuǎn	far
近	jìn	near, close
旁边	pángbiān	next to, beside
对面	duìmiàn	opposite

Looking for the subway

Lily 请问，地铁站在哪儿？
Qǐngwèn, dìtiězhàn zài nǎr?
Excuse me, where is the subway station?

Mr Li 地铁站？离这儿不远。
Dìtiězhàn? Lí zhèr bù yuǎn.
The subway station? It's not far from here.

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Lily 怎么走?
Zěnme zǒu?
How do I get there?

Mr Li 你一直往前走，到第二个路口往右拐。
Nǐ yìzhí wǎng qián zǒu, dào dì-èr ge lùkǒu wǎng yòu guǎi.
Go straight ahead and turn right at the second intersection.

Lily 第二个路口往右拐，对吗?
Dì-èr ge lùkǒu wǎng yòu guǎi, duì ma?
Turn right at the second intersection, right?

Mr Li 对。地铁站就在银行旁边。
Duì. Dìtiězhàn jiù zài yínháng pángbiān.
Yes. The station is right next to the bank.

Lily 走路要多长时间?
Zǒulù yào duō cháng shíjiān?
How long does it take on foot?

Mr Li 大概五分钟。
Dàgài wǔ fēnzhōng.
About five minutes.

Lily 太好了，谢谢您!
Tài hǎo le, xièxie nín!
Great, thank you!

Mr Li 不客气。
Bú kèqi.
You're welcome.

Saying where something is

Thing + 在 + landmark + position word.

How to say it: The position word comes AFTER the landmark, the opposite of English: 'the bank's opposite', not 'opposite the bank'.

学校在公园旁边。
Xuéxiào zài gōngyuán pángbiān.

书在桌子上。
Shū zài zhuōzi shang.

咖啡店在银行对面。
Kāfēidiàn zài yínháng duìmiàn.

请问，洗手间在哪儿?

请问	洗手间	在	哪儿
excuse me (may I ask)	restroom	is at	where

Qǐngwèn, xǐshǒujiān zài nǎr?

Excuse me, where is the restroom?

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银行在超市对面。

银行	在	超市	对面
bank	is at	supermarket	opposite

Yínháng zài chāoshì duìmiàn.

The bank is opposite the supermarket.

到红绿灯往左拐。

到	红绿灯	往	左	拐
when you reach	traffic lights	towards	left	turn

Dào hónglǜdēng wǎng zuǒ guǎi.

Turn left at the traffic lights.

CULTURE NOTE

In Beijing and other northern cities, people often give directions with compass points: 往东走 (wǎng dōng zǒu, go east) or 往北走 (wǎng běi zǒu, go north). Further south, left and right are more common.

CULTURE NOTE

Start with 请问 ('may I ask') to stop someone politely. To older strangers you can say 阿姨 (āyí, auntie) or 叔叔 (shūshu, uncle). It sounds warm and friendly.

Role-play: find the train station

1 **Get attention**

不好意思，请问一下。

Bù hǎoyìsi, qǐngwèn yíxià.

Sorry, may I ask something?

2 **Ask where**

火车站在哪儿?

Huǒchēzhàn zài nǎr?

Where is the train station?

3 **Ask how**

怎么走?

Zěnme zǒu?

How do I get there?

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4 **Check you understood**

往左拐，对吗?

Wǎng zuǒ guǎi, duì ma?

Turn left, right?

Repeating the key words is a great way to check.

5 **Ask the distance**

远不远?

Yuǎn bu yuǎn?

Is it far?

6 **Thank them**

谢谢您!

Xièxie nín!

Thank you!

Say it aloud

Read each direction aloud. Point the way with your hand as you say it!

一直往前走。

往左拐。

往右拐。

在银行旁边。

离这儿不远。

远不远?

Quick quiz

QUIZ

13. 往右拐 means...

- ○ A) turn left
- ○ B) go straight
- ○ C) turn right
- ○ D) go back

14. Listen. What should you do? (listen in the web app: 一直往前走。)

- ○ A) Turn at the lights
- ○ B) Go straight ahead
- ○ C) It's next to the bank
- ○ D) It's very far from here

15. Which sentence means “The bank is opposite the supermarket”?

- ○ A) 银行对面在超市。
- ○ B) 在超市银行对面。
- ○ C) 超市在银行旁边。
- ○ D) 银行在超市对面。

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16. Which word means “near”?

- ○ A) 近
- ○ B) 远
- ○ C) 左
- ○ D) 右

17. What is a 路口?

- ○ A) an intersection
- ○ B) a traffic light
- ○ C) a subway station
- ○ D) a restroom

18. In Beijing someone says 往北走. Which way do you go?

- ○ A) South
- ○ B) North
- ○ C) East
- ○ D) West

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车

UNIT 5 · LESSON 4 · 15 MINUTES

Taxi & Subway

Tell a driver where to go and find your way on the metro.

- Give a taxi driver a destination
- Ask which subway line to take and where to change
- Pay and get off politely

Chinese cities have huge subway systems and plenty of taxis. Learn the words you need to ride, change lines and pay.

Key words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
出租车	chūzūchē	taxi
打车	dǎchē	to take a taxi
师傅	shīfu	driver (polite word for skilled workers)
地铁	dìtiě	subway, metro
号线	hào xiàn	(subway) line 二号线 (èr hào xiàn) — Line 2
站	zhàn	station, stop
换乘	huànchéng	to change lines, transfer
上车	shàng chē	to get on
下车	xià chē	to get off
堵车	dǔchē	traffic jam
票	piào	ticket

In a taxi

Tom 师傅，去北京站。
Shīfu, qù Běijīng Zhàn.
Driver, to Beijing Railway Station, please.

Driver 好的。您赶时间吗？
Hǎo de. Nín gǎn shíjiān ma?
OK. Are you in a hurry?

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Tom 有点儿急。大概要多长时间?
Yǒudiǎnr jí. Dàgài yào duō cháng shíjiān?
A bit. About how long will it take?

Driver 不堵车的话，二十分钟。
Bù dǔchē dehuà, èrshí fēnzhōng.
If there's no traffic, twenty minutes.

Tom 师傅，前面停一下就行。
Shīfu, qiánmiàn tíng yíxià jiù xíng.
Driver, just stop up ahead, that's fine.

Driver 好，到了。一共三十五块。
Hǎo, dào le. Yígòng sānshíwǔ kuài.
OK, we're here. 35 yuan in total.

Tom 我用手机付。
Wǒ yòng shǒujī fù.
I'll pay with my phone.

Driver 行，扫这个码。
Xíng, sǎo zhège mǎ.
Sure, scan this code.

Tom 好了。谢谢师傅!
Hǎo le. Xièxie shīfu!
Done. Thank you!

去天安门坐几号线?

去	天安门	坐	几	号线
go to	Tiananmen	take (ride)	which number	line

Qù Tiān'ānmén zuò jǐ hào xiàn?

Which line goes to Tiananmen?

在下一站换乘二号线。

在	下一站	换乘	二号线
at	the next stop	change to	Line 2

Zài xià yí zhàn huànchéng èr hào xiàn.

Change to Line 2 at the next stop.

我在这儿下车。

我	在	这儿	下车
I	at	here	get off

Wǒ zài zhèr xià chē.

I'll get off here.

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CULTURE NOTE

Taxi drivers are usually called 师傅 (shīfu, 'master'), a respectful word for people with a skill. Most people now book rides with an app and pay by phone.

CULTURE NOTE

Subways in big Chinese cities are fast and cheap, and stops are announced in Chinese and English. At most entrances your bag goes through a security scanner, just like at an airport.

Role-play: ride the subway to the airport

1 **Ask which line**

去机场坐几号线?

Qù jīchǎng zuò jǐ hào xiàn?

Which line goes to the airport?

2 **Buy a ticket**

我要一张去西单的票。

Wǒ yào yì zhāng qù Xīdān de piào.

I'd like a ticket to Xidan.

3 **Ask where to change**

在哪儿换乘?

Zài nǎr huànchéng?

Where do I change?

4 **Ask how many stops**

还有几站?

Hái yǒu jǐ zhàn?

How many more stops?

5 **Get off**

不好意思，我下车。

Bù hǎoyìsi, wǒ xià chē.

Excuse me, I'm getting off.

Say this to people near the door.

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Say it aloud

Read each line aloud.

师傅，去机场。

前面停一下。

一共多少钱?

坐几号线?

在哪儿换乘?

我在这儿下车。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

19. What do people usually call a taxi driver?

- ○ A) 老师 (lǎoshī)
- ○ B) 服务员 (fúwùyuán)
- ○ C) 老板 (lǎobǎn)
- ○ D) 师傅 (shīfu)

20. Listen. What should you do? (listen in the web app: 在下一站换乘。)

- ○ A) Get off at the last stop on this line
- ○ B) Buy a ticket here
- ○ C) Change lines at the next stop
- ○ D) Take a taxi

21. 堵车 means...

- ○ A) a car park
- ○ B) a traffic jam
- ○ C) a bus stop
- ○ D) a very fast train

22. How do you say “I'll get off here”?

- ○ A) 我在这儿上车。
- ○ B) 我去这儿。
- ○ C) 我在这儿下车。
- ○ D) 我在这儿换乘。

23. Which line is 四号线?

- ○ A) Line 4
- ○ B) Line 10
- ○ C) Line 14
- ○ D) Line 40

24. The driver says 一共三十五块. How much do you pay?

- ○ A) 53 yuan
- ○ B) 30 yuan
- ○ C) 350 yuan
- ○ D) 35 yuan

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UNIT 5 · LESSON 5 · 15 MINUTES

住 At the Hotel

Check in, ask about breakfast and Wi-Fi, and check out.

- Check in with a reservation
- Ask about breakfast, Wi-Fi and check-out time
- Read room numbers the Chinese way

A smooth check-in makes the whole trip easier. Here are the phrases you'll use at the front desk (前台, qiántái).

Key words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
酒店	jiǔdiàn	hotel
前台	qiántái	front desk, reception
预订	yùdìng	to book, reserve
房间	fángjiān	room
单人间	dānrénjiān	single room
双人间	shuāngrénjiān	twin room
护照	hùzhào	passport
押金	yājīn	deposit
早餐	zǎocān	breakfast
密码	mìmǎ	password
退房	tuì fáng	to check out

Checking in

Reception 您好，欢迎光临！
Nín hǎo, huānyíng guānglín!
Hello, welcome!

Anna 你好，我预订了一个房间。
Nǐ hǎo, wǒ yùdìng le yí ge fángjiān.
Hi, I booked a room.

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Reception 请问您贵姓?
Qǐngwèn nín guìxìng?
May I have your surname?

Anna 我姓史密斯，叫安娜。
Wǒ xìng Shǐmìsī, jiào Ānnà.
My surname is Smith, first name Anna.

Reception 好的，请给我看一下您的护照。
Hǎo de, qǐng gěi wǒ kàn yíxià nín de hùzhào.
OK, please show me your passport.

Anna 给您。早餐几点开始?
Gěi nín. Zǎocān jǐ diǎn kāishǐ?
Here you are. What time does breakfast start?

Reception 早上七点到十点，在二楼。
Zǎoshang qī diǎn dào shí diǎn, zài èr lóu.
From 7 to 10 a.m., on the second floor.

Anna 明天几点退房?
Míngtiān jǐ diǎn tuì fáng?
What time is check-out tomorrow?

Reception 中午十二点以前。这是您的房卡，八零六房间。
Zhōngwǔ shí'èr diǎn yǐqián. Zhè shì nín de fángkǎ, bā líng liù fángjiān.
Before 12 noon. Here is your key card, room 806.

无线网的密码是多少?

无线网	的	密码	是	多少
Wi-Fi	('s)	password	is	what (number)

Wúxiànwǎng de mìmǎ shì duōshao?

What's the Wi-Fi password?

房间里没有热水。

房间	里	没有	热水
room	in	there isn't	hot water

Fángjiān li méiyǒu rè shuǐ.

There's no hot water in the room.

可以帮我叫一辆出租车吗?

可以	帮	我	叫	一	辆	出租车	吗
can	help	me	call	one	(measure word for vehicles)	taxi	(question word)

Kěyǐ bāng wǒ jiào yí liàng chūzūchē ma?

Could you call a taxi for me?

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MEMORY TRICK

Room and phone numbers are read digit by digit, and 1 is often said 幺 (yāo) so it isn't confused with 7 (qī). Room 618 = liù yāo bā.

CULTURE NOTE

Hotels in China must register every guest, so the front desk will always ask for your passport. A refundable deposit (押金) is also common at check-in.

Role-play: check in and out

1 **Say you booked**

我预订了一个房间。

Wǒ yùdìng le yí ge fángjiān.

I booked a room.

2 **Give your name**

我姓林。

Wǒ xìng Lín.

My surname is Lin.

Use your own surname.

3 **Hand over your passport**

这是我的护照。

Zhè shì wǒ de hùzhào.

Here is my passport.

4 **Ask about breakfast**

有早餐吗?

Yǒu zǎocān ma?

Is there breakfast?

5 **Ask for the Wi-Fi**

无线网的密码是多少?

Wúxiànwǎng de mìmǎ shì duōshao?

What's the Wi-Fi password?

6 **Check out**

我要退房。

Wǒ yào tuì fáng.

I'd like to check out.

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Say it aloud

Read each line aloud.

我预订了一个房间。

这是我的护照。

早餐几点开始?

密码是多少?

我要退房。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

25. 退房 means...

- A) to check in
- B) to book a room
- C) to change rooms
- D) to check out

26. Listen. What does the receptionist want? (listen in the web app: 请给我看一下您的护照。)

- A) Your phone number
- B) Your passport
- C) The room key card
- D) Your breakfast order

27. How would hotel staff usually read room 618?

- A) liù yāo bā
- B) liùbǎi yīshíbā
- C) liù bǎi bā
- D) bā yāo liù

28. Why does the front desk ask for your passport?

- A) To keep it until you check out
- B) To check your online booking app
- C) Guests must be registered
- D) To give you a discount

29. A 单人间 is...

- A) a twin room
- B) a suite
- C) a single room
- D) a dormitory bed

30. 押金 is a...

- A) deposit
- B) discount
- C) receipt
- D) room service menu

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话

UNIT 5 · LESSON 6 · 15 MINUTES

Phone Calls & Messaging

Answer the phone, leave a message and swap WeChat contacts.

- Start and end a phone call
- Say phone numbers correctly
- Talk about messages, WeChat and batteries

Phones are at the centre of daily life in China. Learn how to answer a call, ask for someone, give your number and add friends on WeChat.

Key words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
打电话	dǎ diànhuà	to make a phone call
喂	wéi	hello? (on the phone only)
手机号	shǒujīhào	mobile number
微信	Wēixìn	WeChat
加微信	jiā Wēixìn	to add someone on WeChat
扫一扫	sǎo yi sǎo	to scan (a QR code)
发	fā	to send 我发给你。 (Wǒ fā gěi nǐ.) — I'll send it to you.
语音	yǔyīn	voice message
回电话	huí diànhuà	to call back
打错了	dǎcuò le	wrong number
没电了	méi diàn le	the battery is dead

Calling a teacher

Xiao Lin 喂，你好！请问是王老师吗?
Wéi, nǐ hǎo! Qǐngwèn shì Wáng lǎoshī ma?
Hello! Is this Teacher Wang?

Mr Wang 我就是。您是哪位?
Wǒ jiù shì. Nín shì nǎ wèi?
Speaking. Who's calling?

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Xiao Lin 我是小林，是您的学生。
Wǒ shì Xiǎo Lín, shì nín de xuésheng.
It's Xiao Lin, your student.

Mr Wang 哦，小林！有什么事？
Ò, Xiǎo Lín! Yǒu shénme shì?
Oh, Xiao Lin! What's up?

Xiao Lin 我明天不能来上课，我感冒了。
Wǒ míngtiān bù néng lái shàngkè, wǒ gǎnmào le.
I can't come to class tomorrow. I've caught a cold.

Mr Wang 没关系，好好休息。
Méi guānxi, hǎohǎo xiūxi.
That's OK. Get plenty of rest.

Xiao Lin 您能把作业发到我的微信上吗？
Nín néng bǎ zuòyè fā dào wǒ de Wēixìn shang ma?
Could you send the homework to my WeChat?

Mr Wang 可以。你的手机号是多少？
Kěyǐ. Nǐ de shǒujīhào shì duōshao?
Sure. What's your mobile number?

Xiao Lin 一三九，八八六七，二零五四。
Yāo sān jiǔ, bā bā liù qī, èr líng wǔ sì.
139 8867 2054.

Mr Wang 好，我一会儿加你。
Hǎo, wǒ yíhuìr jiā nǐ.
OK, I'll add you in a moment.

你打错了。

你	打错	了
you	dialled wrongly	(done)

Nǐ dǎcuò le.

You've got the wrong number.

我手机没电了。

我	手机	没	电	了
my	mobile phone	has no more	power	(change)

Wǒ shǒujī méi diàn le.

My phone battery is dead.

我们加个微信吧。

我们	加	个	微信	吧
we	add	(measure word)	WeChat	(suggestion)

Wǒmen jiā ge Wēixìn ba.

Let's add each other on WeChat.

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TIP

On the phone, 喂 is usually said with a rising tone (wéi) and means 'hello?'. Face to face it sounds like 'hey, you!', so don't use it to greet people in person.

CULTURE NOTE

WeChat (微信) is used for almost everything in China: chatting, voice messages, paying, booking and work groups. When people meet, they often scan each other's QR code instead of swapping numbers.

Role-play: call an office

1 **Answer or start**

喂，你好！

Wéi, nǐ hǎo!

Hello?

2 **Ask for someone**

请问李经理在吗？

Qǐngwèn Lǐ jīnglǐ zài ma?

Is Manager Li there, please?

3 **Ask who is calling**

请问您是哪位？

Qǐngwèn nín shì nǎ wèi?

May I ask who's calling?

4 **Leave a message**

请他给我回电话。

Qǐng tā gěi wǒ huí diànhuà.

Please ask him to call me back.

5 **Say goodbye**

好的，再见！

Hǎo de, zàijiàn!

OK, goodbye!

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Say it aloud

Read each line aloud. Then say your own phone number in Chinese!

喂，你好！

您是哪位？

你的手机号是多少？

我们加个微信吧。

我手机没电了。

请给我回电话。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

31. On the phone, 喂 means...

- ○ A) Goodbye
- ○ B) Hello?
- ○ C) Thank you
- ○ D) Wrong number

32. Listen. What is the problem? (listen in the web app: 你打错了。)

- ○ A) The phone is off
- ○ B) Please call me back later this evening
- ○ C) The signal is bad
- ○ D) Wrong number

33. How is the 1 in a phone number like 139 usually said?

- ○ A) yāo
- ○ B) yī
- ○ C) yí
- ○ D) shí

34. 我手机没电了 means...

- ○ A) I don't have a phone
- ○ B) My phone is new
- ○ C) I lost my mobile phone yesterday
- ○ D) My battery is dead

35. How do people often add each other on WeChat?

- ○ A) Exchange business cards
- ○ B) Write an email
- ○ C) Scan a QR code
- ○ D) Send a letter

36. 回电话 means...

- ○ A) to hang up
- ○ B) to call back
- ○ C) to make a video call
- ○ D) to send a text

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UNIT 5 · LESSON 7 · 15 MINUTES

约 Making Plans

Invite a friend, agree on a time and place, or say no politely.

- Ask if someone is free
- Suggest activities with 吧
- Set a time and place to meet
- Decline an invitation politely

Making plans with friends is great practice. Learn to invite, suggest, agree on a time and place, and politely say no.

Key words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
有空	yǒu kòng	to be free (have time)
周末	zhōumò	weekend
一起	yìqǐ	together
看电影	kàn diànyǐng	to see a film
见面	jiànmiàn	to meet
约	yuē	to arrange (to meet)
门口	ménkǒu	entrance, at the door
怎么样	zěnmeyàng	how about it?
改天	gǎitiān	another day
不见不散	bú jiàn bú sàn	see you there! (we won't leave until we meet)

A weekend plan

Xiao Zhang 米娅，这个周末你有空吗?
Mǐyà, zhège zhōumò nǐ yǒu kòng ma?
Mia, are you free this weekend?

Mia 星期六有事，星期天有空。怎么了?
Xīngqīliù yǒu shì, xīngqītiān yǒu kòng. Zěnme le?
I'm busy on Saturday, free on Sunday. Why?

Xiao Zhang 我们一起去看电影吧!
Wǒmen yìqǐ qù kàn diànyǐng ba!
Let's go and see a film together!

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Mia 好啊！看什么电影?
Hǎo a! Kàn shénme diànyǐng?
Sure! Which film?

Xiao Zhang 有一个新的中国电影，听说很好看。
Yǒu yí ge xīn de Zhōngguó diànyǐng, tīngshuō hěn hǎokàn.
There's a new Chinese film. I hear it's really good.

Mia 几点见面？在哪儿见?
Jǐ diǎn jiànmiàn? Zài nǎr jiàn?
What time shall we meet? Where?

Xiao Zhang 下午两点，在电影院门口，怎么样?
Xiàwǔ liǎng diǎn, zài diànyǐngyuàn ménkǒu, zěnmeyàng?
2 p.m. at the cinema entrance, how's that?

Mia 没问题。看完电影一起吃饭吧。
Méi wèntí. Kàn wán diànyǐng yìqǐ chī fàn ba.
No problem. Let's eat together after the film.

Xiao Zhang 好主意！星期天见，不见不散!
Hǎo zhǔyi! Xīngqītiān jiàn, bú jiàn bú sàn!
Good idea! See you Sunday. Be there!

Mia 不见不散!
Bú jiàn bú sàn!
See you there!

Suggest with 吧 (ba)

Put 吧 at the end of a sentence to make a friendly suggestion: 'Let's...'.

我们走吧。	一起去吧！	我们喝咖啡吧。
Wǒmen zǒu ba.	Yìqǐ qù ba!	Wǒmen hē kāfēi ba.

你明天晚上有空吗?

你	明天	晚上	有空	吗
you	tomorrow	evening	are free	(question word)

Nǐ míngtiān wǎnshang yǒu kòng ma?

Are you free tomorrow evening?

不好意思，我那天有事。

不好意思	我	那天	有事
sorry	I	that day	have something on

Bù hǎoyìsi, wǒ nà tiān yǒu shì.

Sorry, I'm busy that day.

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我们改天再约吧。

我们	改天	再	约	吧
we	another day	again	arrange	(suggestion)

Wǒmen gǎitiān zài yuē ba.

Let's make it another day.

CULTURE NOTE

A direct 'no' can feel harsh. People often decline with 我那天有事 ('I have something on that day') or 下次吧 ('next time'). If someone says 改天吧 without naming a day, it may simply be a polite no.

CULTURE NOTE

Whoever invites often pays, and friends may playfully 'fight' over the bill. Among young people, splitting the bill is also common: it's called AA制 (AA zhì).

Role-play: invite a friend hiking

1 **Ask if they're free**

你周六有空吗?

Nǐ zhōuliù yǒu kòng ma?

Are you free on Saturday?

2 **Suggest an activity**

我们去爬山吧!

Wǒmen qù pá shān ba!

Let's go hiking!

3 **Set a time**

早上九点怎么样?

Zǎoshang jiǔ diǎn zěnmeyàng?

How about 9 a.m.?

4 **Set a place**

在地铁站见。

Zài dìtiězhàn jiàn.

Let's meet at the subway station.

5 **Confirm**

不见不散!

Bú jiàn bú sàn!

See you there!

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Say it aloud

Read each line aloud.

你周末有空吗?

我们一起去吧!

几点见面?

在门口见。

不好意思，我有事。

不见不散!

Quick quiz

QUIZ

37. 有空 means...

- ○ A) to be busy
- ○ B) to be late
- ○ C) to be free
- ○ D) to be hungry

38. Listen. What is your friend suggesting? (listen in the web app: 我们一起去看电影吧！)

- ○ A) Did you see the film?
- ○ B) Seeing a film together
- ○ C) Shall we watch TV at my place tonight?
- ○ D) The cinema is closed

39. What does 吧 add to 我们走吧?

- ○ A) a question
- ○ B) past tense
- ○ C) makes it a negative sentence
- ○ D) a suggestion (let's)

40. People say 不见不散 when...

- ○ A) confirming a plan to meet
- ○ B) turning down an invite
- ○ C) apologising for being late
- ○ D) saying goodbye forever

41. A friend says 改天吧 with no date. It probably means...

- ○ A) yes, tomorrow
- ○ B) let's meet right now
- ○ C) maybe not this time
- ○ D) I'll pay for everything

42. Which word means “weekend”?

- ○ A) 周六
- ○ B) 周末
- ○ C) 晚上
- ○ D) 明天

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医

UNIT 5 · LESSON 8 · 15 MINUTES

At the Doctor

Say what's wrong, understand advice and get medicine.

- Say how you feel and what hurts
- Say how long you've been ill and mention allergies
- Understand how to take medicine

Nobody wants to get sick abroad, but knowing a few phrases makes it much less stressful. Learn to explain your symptoms and understand the doctor.

Key words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
医院	yīyuàn	hospital
医生	yīshēng	doctor
不舒服	bù shūfu	unwell, not feeling well
疼	téng	to hurt, ache 头疼 (tóuténg) — headache
发烧	fāshāo	to have a fever
咳嗽	késou	to cough
感冒	gǎnmào	a cold; to catch a cold
过敏	guòmǐn	allergic; allergy
药	yào	medicine
药店	yàodiàn	pharmacy
挂号	guàhào	to register (at a hospital)

Seeing the doctor

Doctor 你好，哪儿不舒服?
Nǐ hǎo, nǎr bù shūfu?
Hello, what's the problem?

David 我头疼，还有点儿发烧。
Wǒ tóuténg, hái yǒudiǎnr fāshāo.
I have a headache and a slight fever.

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Doctor 几天了?
Jǐ tiān le?
For how many days?

David 两天了。晚上一直咳嗽。
Liǎng tiān le. Wǎnshang yìzhí késou.
Two days. I keep coughing at night.

Doctor 我看看。张开嘴，说“啊”。
Wǒ kànkan. Zhāngkāi zuǐ, shuō “ā”.
Let me see. Open your mouth and say “ah”.

Doctor 你感冒了，不太严重。你对什么药过敏吗?
Nǐ gǎnmào le, bú tài yánzhòng. Nǐ duì shénme yào guòmǐn ma?
You have a cold, not too serious. Are you allergic to any medicine?

David 没有。
Méiyǒu.
No.

Doctor 这个药一天吃三次，一次两片。
Zhège yào yì tiān chī sān cì, yí cì liǎng piàn.
Take this medicine three times a day, two tablets each time.

David 我明天能上班吗?
Wǒ míngtiān néng shàngbān ma?
Can I go to work tomorrow?

Doctor 最好在家休息两天，多喝热水。
Zuìhǎo zài jiā xiūxi liǎng tiān, duō hē rè shuǐ.
Better rest at home for two days, and drink plenty of hot water.

Body part + 疼 = it hurts

Chinese	Pinyin	Meaning
头疼	tóuténg	headache
牙疼	yá téng	toothache
肚子疼	dùzi téng	stomach ache
嗓子疼	sǎngzi téng	sore throat
腿疼	tuǐ téng	my leg hurts

我肚子疼。

我 I | 肚子 stomach | 疼 hurts

Wǒ dùzi téng.

I have a stomach ache.

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我对花生过敏。

我	对	花生	过敏
I	to	peanuts	allergic

Wǒ duì huāshēng guòmǐn.

I'm allergic to peanuts.

附近有药店吗?

附近	有	药店	吗
nearby	there is	pharmacy	(question word)

Fùjìn yǒu yàodiàn ma?

Is there a pharmacy nearby?

CULTURE NOTE

In China people usually go to a hospital (医院) even for small problems, rather than to a family doctor. First you register (挂号), often on an app or a machine, then wait for your number to be called.

DID YOU KNOW?

'Drink more hot water' (多喝热水) is the classic Chinese advice for almost any illness. It's a caring thing to say, and a popular joke too!

WATCH OUT

In an emergency in mainland China, call 120 for an ambulance (110 is the police, 119 the fire service).

Role-play: at the clinic

1 **Say you feel unwell**

我不舒服。

Wǒ bù shūfu.

I don't feel well.

2 **Say what hurts**

我嗓子疼。

Wǒ sǎngzi téng.

My throat hurts.

3 **Say how long**

三天了。

Sān tiān le.

For three days.

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4 **Mention allergies**

我对青霉素过敏。

Wǒ duì qīngméisù guòmǐn.

I'm allergic to penicillin.

Learn the name of anything you are allergic to before you travel.

5 **Ask about the medicine**

这个药怎么吃?

Zhège yào zěnme chī?

How do I take this medicine?

Say it aloud

Read each line aloud.

我不舒服。

我头疼。

我发烧了。

我对花生过敏。

这个药怎么吃?

多喝热水!

Quick quiz

QUIZ

43. 发烧 means...

- ○ A) to cough
- ○ B) to have a headache
- ○ C) to sneeze
- ○ D) to have a fever

44. Listen. What's wrong? (listen in the web app: 我头疼。)

- ○ A) I have a headache
- ○ B) My stomach hurts
- ○ C) I have a fever
- ○ D) I'm allergic to peanuts

45. 一天吃三次 means take it...

- ○ A) for three days
- ○ B) three times a day
- ○ C) three tablets at once
- ○ D) once every three days

46. Which number calls an ambulance in mainland China?

- ○ A) 110
- ○ B) 119
- ○ C) 120
- ○ D) 999

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47. 我对花生过敏 means…

- ○ A) I love eating peanuts
- ○ B) I ate peanuts
- ○ C) Peanuts are good for you
- ○ D) I'm allergic to peanuts

48. How do you ask “Is there a pharmacy nearby?”

- ○ A) 附近有药店吗?
- ○ B) 医院在哪儿?
- ○ C) 你哪儿不舒服?
- ○ D) 这个药怎么吃?

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天

UNIT 5 · LESSON 9 · 15 MINUTES

Small Talk & the Weather

Chat with neighbours about the weather and daily life.

- Talk about the weather and temperature
- Use everyday greetings like 你吃了吗
- Handle personal questions with a smile

Small talk builds friendships. Chinese small talk is often about food, work and daily life, and of course the weather.

Key words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
天气	tiānqì	weather
晴天	qíngtiān	sunny day
下雨	xià yǔ	to rain
下雪	xià xuě	to snow
刮风	guā fēng	to be windy
冷	lěng	cold
热	rè	hot
度	dù	degree(s)
天气预报	tiānqì yùbào	weather forecast
伞	sǎn	umbrella
最近	zuìjìn	recently, lately

A cold morning

Auntie Liu 山姆，早啊！去哪儿啊？
Shānmǔ, zǎo a! Qù nǎr a?
Morning, Sam! Where are you off to?

Sam 刘阿姨，早！我去上班。
Liú āyí, zǎo! Wǒ qù shàngbān.
Morning, Auntie Liu! I'm going to work.

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Auntie Liu 今天真冷啊！你穿得太少了。
Jīntiān zhēn lěng a! Nǐ chuān de tài shǎo le.
It's so cold today! You're not wearing enough.

Sam 是啊，昨天还挺暖和的。
Shì a, zuótiān hái tǐng nuǎnhuo de.
Yes, yesterday it was still quite warm.

Auntie Liu 天气预报说下午要下雪。
Tiānqì yùbào shuō xiàwǔ yào xià xuě.
The forecast says it will snow this afternoon.

Sam 真的吗？那我带把伞吧。
Zhēn de ma? Nà wǒ dài bǎ sǎn ba.
Really? Then I'll take an umbrella.

Auntie Liu 最近工作忙不忙？
Zuìjìn gōngzuò máng bu máng?
Is work busy these days?

Sam 挺忙的，不过还好。您身体好吗？
Tǐng máng de, búguò hái hǎo. Nín shēntǐ hǎo ma?
Quite busy, but OK. Are you keeping well?

Auntie Liu 好着呢！快去吧，别迟到了。
Hǎo zhe ne! Kuài qù ba, bié chídào le.
Very well! Off you go, don't be late.

Sam 好，回头见！
Hǎo, huítóu jiàn!
OK, see you later!

今天多少度？

今天	多少	度
today	how many	degrees

Jīntiān duōshao dù?

What's the temperature today?

明天会下雨吗？

明天	会	下雨	吗
tomorrow	will	rain	(question word)

Míngtiān huì xià yǔ ma?

Will it rain tomorrow?

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你吃了吗?

你	吃	了	吗
you	eat	(done)	(question word)

Nǐ chī le ma?

Have you eaten?

A friendly greeting, especially from older people. Just answer 吃了 (chī le). It is not an invitation to lunch!

CULTURE NOTE

Many everyday greetings are really comments on what you're doing: 去哪儿啊? (Where are you off to?), 上班啊? (Off to work?), 你吃了吗? (Have you eaten?). They are greetings, not real questions, so a short answer is fine.

CULTURE NOTE

Chinese friends may ask your age, salary or whether you're married. This is usually friendly curiosity. If you'd rather not answer, smile and say 保密! (bǎomì, 'It's a secret!').

DID YOU KNOW?

Temperatures are given in Celsius. 零下五度 (língxià wǔ dù) means −5 °C.

Role-play: chat with a neighbour

1 **Greet them**

早啊!

Zǎo a!

Morning!

2 **Comment on the weather**

今天真热啊!

Jīntiān zhēn rè a!

It's so hot today!

3 **Ask about the forecast**

明天会下雨吗?

Míngtiān huì xià yǔ ma?

Will it rain tomorrow?

4 **Ask about their life**

最近忙吗?

Zuìjìn máng ma?

Busy lately?

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5 **Leave politely**

我先走了，回头见!

Wǒ xiān zǒu le, huítóu jiàn!

I'll be off, see you later!

Say it aloud

Read each line aloud with feeling.

今天真冷啊!

今天真热啊!

明天会下雨吗?

你吃了吗?

最近忙不忙?

回头见!

Quick quiz

QUIZ

49. 下雪 means...

- ○ A) to rain
- ○ B) to snow
- ○ C) to be windy
- ○ D) to be sunny

50. Listen. What is the speaker saying? (listen in the web app: 今天真冷啊！)

- ○ A) It's really hot today
- ○ B) It will rain today
- ○ C) Today is very busy
- ○ D) It's really cold today

51. A neighbour greets you with 你吃了吗？. A good reply is...

- ○ A) 吃了，你呢?
- ○ B) 我不饿。
- ○ C) 请我吃饭吧!
- ○ D) 不要。

52. 零下五度 is...

- ○ A) 5 °C
- ○ B) 15 °C
- ○ C) -5 °C
- ○ D) 50 °C

53. You'd rather not say your salary. You can smile and say...

- ○ A) 保密!
- ○ B) 没问题!
- ○ C) 不客气!
- ○ D) 再见!

54. 天气预报 is...

- ○ A) an umbrella
- ○ B) a sunny day
- ○ C) the weather forecast
- ○ D) the temperature in degrees Celsius

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学

UNIT 5 · LESSON 10 · 15 MINUTES

At School & Work

Introduce yourself to classmates and colleagues and talk about your day.

- Introduce yourself at a new class or job
- Talk about timetables, meetings and exams
- Use titles and polite set phrases

Starting at a new school or office? These words and phrases help you fit in from day one.

Key words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
学校	xuéxiào	school
同学	tóngxué	classmate
上课	shàngkè	to have class; class starts
作业	zuòyè	homework
考试	kǎoshì	exam
公司	gōngsī	company
同事	tóngshì	colleague
上班	shàngbān	to go to work, start work
下班	xiàbān	to finish work
开会	kāihuì	to have a meeting
加班	jiābān	to work overtime
请假	qǐngjià	to ask for time off

First day at the office

Manager Chen 大家好，这位是新同事李乐。
Dàjiā hǎo, zhè wèi shì xīn tóngshì Lǐ Lè.
Hi everyone, this is our new colleague, Li Le.

Li Le 大家好！我叫李乐，请多关照！
Dàjiā hǎo! Wǒ jiào Lǐ Lè, qǐng duō guānzhào!
Hello everyone! I'm Li Le. I look forward to working with you!

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Zhou Ting 欢迎欢迎！我叫周婷，坐你旁边。
Huānyíng huānyíng! Wǒ jiào Zhōu Tíng, zuò nǐ pángbiān.
Welcome! I'm Zhou Ting. I sit next to you.

Li Le 你好！我们几点上班？
Nǐ hǎo! Wǒmen jǐ diǎn shàngbān?
Hi! What time do we start work?

Zhou Ting 九点上班，六点下班，中午休息一个小时。
Jiǔ diǎn shàngbān, liù diǎn xiàbān, zhōngwǔ xiūxi yí ge xiǎoshí.
We start at 9 and finish at 6, with an hour's break at noon.

Li Le 经常加班吗？
Jīngcháng jiābān ma?
Do we often work overtime?

Zhou Ting 有时候。对了，下午三点要开会。
Yǒu shíhou. Duì le, xiàwǔ sān diǎn yào kāihuì.
Sometimes. Oh, and there's a meeting at 3 p.m.

Li Le 在哪个会议室？
Zài nǎge huìyìshì?
In which meeting room?

Zhou Ting 三楼的大会议室。中午一起去食堂吃饭吧！
Sān lóu de dà huìyìshì. Zhōngwǔ yìqǐ qù shítáng chī fàn ba!
The big one on the third floor. Let's go to the canteen together at lunch!

Li Le 好啊，谢谢你！
Hǎo a, xièxie nǐ!
Great, thank you!

老师，我可以问一个问题吗？

老师	我	可以	问	一	个	问题	吗
teacher	I	may	ask	one	(measure word)	question	(question word)

Lǎoshī, wǒ kěyǐ wèn yí ge wèntí ma?

Teacher, may I ask a question?

明天有考试，我得复习。

明天	有	考试	我	得	复习
tomorrow	there is	exam	I	have to	revise

Míngtiān yǒu kǎoshì, wǒ děi fùxí.

There's an exam tomorrow, so I have to revise.

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我想请一天假。

我	想	请	一	天	假
I	would like	ask for	one	day	leave

Wǒ xiǎng qǐng yì tiān jià.

I'd like to take a day off.

请假 splits around the length of time: 请两天假 = take two days off.

CULTURE NOTE

请多关照 (qǐng duō guānzhào, 'please look after me') is a polite set phrase for a first day at work or school. Saying it makes a great first impression.

CULTURE NOTE

Use titles: surname + job title, like 王经理 (Manager Wang) or 李老师 (Teacher Li). Calling a teacher or boss by their given name alone can sound too casual.

CULTURE NOTE

The 高考 (gāokǎo), the national university entrance exam, takes place every June. It's a huge event: families plan around it and even traffic is kept quiet near exam halls.

Role-play: your first day

1 **Greet everyone**

大家好!

Dàjiā hǎo!

Hello everyone!

2 **Say your name**

我叫马克。

Wǒ jiào Mǎkè.

My name is Mark.

Use your own name.

3 **Say who you are**

我是新来的同事。

Wǒ shì xīn lái de tóngshì.

I'm the new colleague.

At school, say 新同学 (new classmate) instead.

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4 **Ask something practical**

请问，打印机在哪儿?

Qǐngwèn, dǎyìnjī zài nǎr?

Excuse me, where's the printer?

5 **Finish politely**

请多关照!

Qǐng duō guānzhào!

I look forward to working with you!

Say it aloud

Read each line aloud.

大家好!

请多关照!

几点上班?

下午要开会。

明天有考试。

我想请一天假。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

55. 下班 means...

- ○ A) to start work
- ○ B) to work overtime
- ○ C) to have a meeting
- ○ D) to finish work

56. Listen. What's happening this afternoon? (listen in the web app: 下午三点要开会。)

- ○ A) Work ends at 3 p.m.
- ○ B) A meeting at 3
- ○ C) Class starts at 3 p.m.
- ○ D) The exam is at 3 p.m.

57. What do you say when you join a new team?

- ○ A) 请多关照!
- ○ B) 多少钱?
- ○ C) 不见不散!
- ○ D) 买单!

58. How should you address Manager Wang?

- ○ A) 王
- ○ B) 经理王
- ○ C) 小王经理
- ○ D) 王经理

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59. 同学 means...

- ○ A) colleague
- ○ B) classmate
- ○ C) teacher
- ○ D) manager

60. 请假 means...

- ○ A) to take an exam
- ○ B) to work late overtime
- ○ C) to ask for leave
- ○ D) to do homework

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UNIT 5

Answer key

1. C) The bill, please!
2. D) Is it spicy?
3. A) 几位?
4. B) 菜单
5. D) 打包
6. C) No, not usually
7. B) It's too expensive
8. A) 块 (kuài)
9. A) At a street market
10. C) cheap
11. B) 我只是看看。
12. D) 120 yuan
13. C) turn right
14. B) Go straight ahead
15. D) 银行在超市对面。
16. A) 近
17. A) an intersection
18. B) North
19. D) 师傅 (shīfu)
20. C) Change lines at the next stop
21. B) a traffic jam
22. C) 我在这儿下车。
23. A) Line 4
24. D) 35 yuan
25. D) to check out
26. B) Your passport
27. A) liù yāo bā
28. C) Guests must be registered
29. C) a single room
30. A) deposit
31. B) Hello?
32. D) Wrong number
33. A) yāo
34. D) My battery is dead
35. C) Scan a QR code
36. B) to call back
37. C) to be free
38. B) Seeing a film together
39. D) a suggestion (let's)
40. A) confirming a plan to meet
41. C) maybe not this time
42. B) 周末
43. D) to have a fever
44. A) I have a headache
45. B) three times a day
46. C) 120
47. D) I'm allergic to peanuts
48. A) 附近有药店吗?
49. B) to snow
50. D) It's really cold today
51. A) 吃了，你呢?
52. C) -5 °C
53. A) 保密!
54. C) the weather forecast
55. D) to finish work
56. B) A meeting at 3
57. A) 请多关照!
58. D) 王经理
59. B) classmate
60. C) to ask for leave

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读

UNIT 6

Reading & Culture

Graded stories, a Tang poem, chengyu, festivals and customs.

1. Story 1: Xiao Ming's Sunday
2. Story 2: The Umbrella
3. Story 3: The Birthday Present
4. Poem: Quiet Night Thoughts
5. Chengyu & Everyday Sayings
6. Chinese Festivals
7. Culture Tips: Names, Gifts, Numbers & Table Manners
8. Final Review Lab

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日

UNIT 6 · LESSON 1 · 15 MINUTES

Story 1: Xiao Ming's Sunday

A first graded story (HSK 1): one boy, one relaxing day.

- Read a short story in characters
- Understand time words: morning, afternoon, evening
- Answer questions about the story

Time for your first story! It uses only beginner (HSK 1) words. Read one sentence at a time, tap words you don't know, then read the whole story aloud.

Words in this story

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
星期天	xīngqītiān	Sunday
起床	qǐchuáng	to get up
早饭	zǎofàn	breakfast
包子	bāozi	steamed bun (with filling)
商店	shāngdiàn	shop
东西	dōngxi	thing(s), stuff
电视	diànshì	TV
累	lèi	tired
睡觉	shuìjiào	to sleep, go to bed

TIP

Time words like 早上, 下午 and 晚上 come at the start of the sentence or right after the subject, never at the end as in English.

The story

小明的星期天 (Xiǎo Míng de Xīngqītiān): Xiao Ming's Sunday

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今天是星期天。

今天	是	星期天
today	is	Sunday

Jīntiān shì xīngqītiān.

Today is Sunday.

小明早上八点起床。

小明	早上	八点	起床
Xiao Ming	in the morning	eight o'clock	gets up

Xiǎo Míng zǎoshang bā diǎn qǐchuáng.

Xiao Ming gets up at eight in the morning.

他和妈妈一起吃早饭。

他	和	妈妈	一起	吃	早饭
he	with	mum	together	eat	breakfast

Tā hé māma yìqǐ chī zǎofàn.

He has breakfast with his mum.

他们吃包子，喝牛奶。

他们	吃	包子	喝	牛奶
they	eat	steamed buns	drink	milk

Tāmen chī bāozi, hē niúnǎi.

They eat steamed buns and drink milk.

上午，小明去商店买东西。

上午	小明	去	商店	买	东西
in the morning	Xiao Ming	goes to	shop	buy	things

Shàngwǔ, Xiǎo Míng qù shāngdiàn mǎi dōngxi.

In the morning, Xiao Ming goes to the shop to buy things.

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他买了一个苹果和三本书。

他	买了	一个	苹果	和	三	本	书
he	bought	one	apple	and	three	(measure word for books)	books

Tā mǎi le yí ge píngguǒ hé sān běn shū.

He buys an apple and three books.

下午，他的朋友来他家。

下午	他的	朋友	来	他	家
in the afternoon	his	friend	comes to	his	home

Xiàwǔ, tā de péngyou lái tā jiā.

In the afternoon, his friend comes to his home.

他们一起看电视，很高兴。

他们	一起	看	电视	很	高兴
they	together	watch	TV	very	happy

Tāmen yìqǐ kàn diànshì, hěn gāoxìng.

They watch TV together and are very happy.

晚上，小明很累，九点就睡觉了。

晚上	小明	很	累	九点	就	睡觉	了
in the evening	Xiao Ming	very	tired	nine o'clock	already	sleep	(done)

Wǎnshang, Xiǎo Míng hěn lèi, jiǔ diǎn jiù shuìjiào le.

In the evening Xiao Ming is tired, and he's asleep by nine.

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Read the whole story

Now read the whole story aloud without looking at the English.

今天是星期天。

小明早上八点起床。

他和妈妈一起吃早饭。

他们吃包子，喝牛奶。

上午，小明去商店买东西。

他买了一个苹果和三本书。

下午，他的朋友来他家。

他们一起看电视，很高兴。

晚上，小明很累，九点就睡觉了。

Did you understand?

QUIZ

1. What day is it in the story?
   - ○ A) Saturday
   - ○ B) Monday
   - ○ C) Sunday
   - ○ D) Friday
2. What time does Xiao Ming get up?
   - ○ A) 9:00
   - ○ B) 7:00
   - ○ C) 10:00
   - ○ D) 8:00
3. What do they have for breakfast?
   - ○ A) Steamed buns and milk
   - ○ B) Fried rice and green tea
   - ○ C) Noodles and juice
   - ○ D) Dumplings and coffee
4. What does he buy at the shop?
   - ○ A) Three apples and a book
   - ○ B) An apple and three books
   - ○ C) Some bread and two pens for school
   - ○ D) A TV
5. Listen. What are they doing? (listen in the web app: 他们一起看电视。)
   - ○ A) Reading books
   - ○ B) Eating breakfast
   - ○ C) Going to the shop
   - ○ D) Watching TV
6. Why does he go to bed at nine?
   - ○ A) He is ill
   - ○ B) He is sad
   - ○ C) He is tired
   - ○ D) He has school

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UNIT 6 · LESSON 2 · 15 MINUTES

Story 2: The Umbrella

A graded story (HSK 1–2) about a rainy day and a new friend.

- Read a longer story with past events
- Learn the pattern 一边…一边… (while…)
- Answer comprehension questions

This story is a little longer and uses some HSK 2 words. Many Chinese names have a meaning: the girl's name, 小雨 (Xiǎoyǔ), means 'light rain'.

Words in this story

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
大学生	dàxuéshēng	university student
名字	míngzi	name
可是	kěshì	but
带	dài	to take, bring along
伞	sǎn	umbrella
下课	xiàkè	class is over
外边	wàibian	outside
怎么办	zěnme bàn	what to do?
聊天	liáotiān	to chat
开始	kāishǐ	to begin, start

一边…一边… (while…)

Two actions happening at the same time: Subject + 一边 + action 1 + 一边 + action 2.

他们一边走一边聊天。
Tāmen yìbiān zǒu yìbiān liáotiān.

我一边吃饭一边看电视。
Wǒ yìbiān chī fàn yìbiān kàn diànshì.

The story

一把雨伞 (Yì bǎ yǔsǎn): The Umbrella

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王小雨是大学生。

王小雨	是	大学生
Wang Xiaoyu (a name)	is	university student

Wáng Xiǎoyǔ shì dàxuéshēng.

Wang Xiaoyu is a university student.

她的名字里有“雨”，可是她不喜欢下雨。

她的	名字	里	有	雨	可是	她	不	喜欢	下雨
her	name	in	has	rain	but	she	doesn't	like	raining

Tā de míngzi li yǒu “yǔ”, kěshì tā bù xǐhuan xià yǔ.

Her name has “rain” in it, but she doesn't like rain.

星期一早上天气很好，她没带伞就去上课了。

星期一	早上	天气	很	好	她	没	带	伞	就	去	上课	了
Monday	morning	weather	very	good	she	didn't	take	umbrella	then	go	to class	(done)

Xīngqīyī zǎoshang tiānqì hěn hǎo, tā méi dài sǎn jiù qù shàngkè le.

On Monday morning the weather was lovely, so she went to class without an umbrella.

下午下课的时候，外边下大雨了。

下午	下课	的时候	外边	下	大雨	了
afternoon	class ends	when	outside	falls	heavy rain	(now)

Xiàwǔ xiàkè de shíhou, wàibian xià dà yǔ le.

In the afternoon, when class ended, it was pouring outside.

小雨站在门口，不知道怎么办。

小雨	站	在	门口	不	知道	怎么办
Xiaoyu	stood	at	the door	not	know	what to do

Xiǎoyǔ zhàn zài ménkǒu, bù zhīdào zěnme bàn.

Xiaoyu stood at the door, not knowing what to do.

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这时候，一个男同学走了过来。

这时候	一个	男	同学	走	了	过来
just then	a	male	classmate	walked	(done)	over (here)

Zhè shíhou, yí ge nán tóngxué zǒu le guòlai.

Just then, a classmate came over.

他说：“我的伞很大，我们一起走吧！”

他	说	我的	伞	很	大	我们	一起	走	吧
he	said	my	umbrella	very	big	we	together	walk	(let's)

Tā shuō: “Wǒ de sǎn hěn dà, wǒmen yìqǐ zǒu ba!”

He said: “My umbrella is big. Let's walk together!”

他叫林阳，是她的同班同学。

他	叫	林阳	是	她的	同班	同学
he	is called	Lin Yang	is	her	same class	classmate

Tā jiào Lín Yáng, shì tā de tóngbān tóngxué.

His name was Lin Yang, a classmate from her class.

他们一边走一边聊天，路好像变短了。

他们	一边	走	一边	聊天	路	好像	变	短	了
they	while	walk	while	chat	road	seemed to	become	short	(change)

Tāmen yìbiān zǒu yìbiān liáotiān, lù hǎoxiàng biàn duǎn le.

They chatted as they walked, and the way home seemed to get shorter.

从那天起，小雨开始喜欢下雨天了。

从	那天	起	小雨	开始	喜欢	下雨天	了
from	that day	on	Xiaoyu	began	to like	rainy days	(change)

Cóng nà tiān qǐ, Xiǎoyǔ kāishǐ xǐhuan xià yǔ tiān le.

From that day on, Xiaoyu began to like rainy days.

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Read the whole story

Read the whole story aloud. Try to keep a smooth rhythm.

王小雨是大学生。
她的名字里有“雨”，可是她不喜欢下雨。
星期一早上天气很好，她没带伞就去上课了。
下午下课的时候，外边下大雨了。
小雨站在门口，不知道怎么办。
这时候，一个男同学走了过来。
他说：“我的伞很大，我们一起走吧！”
他叫林阳，是她的同班同学。
他们一边走一边聊天，路好像变短了。
从那天起，小雨开始喜欢下雨天了。

Did you understand?

QUIZ

7. What does 雨 in Xiaoyu's name mean?
   - ○ A) snow
   - ○ B) rain
   - ○ C) sun
   - ○ D) wind

8. Why didn't she take an umbrella?
   - ○ A) The morning was sunny
   - ○ B) Her umbrella was broken at home
   - ○ C) She lost it on the bus
   - ○ D) She doesn't own one

9. When did it start to pour?
   - ○ A) In the afternoon
   - ○ B) Early on Monday morning
   - ○ C) Late on Sunday night
   - ○ D) During her lunch break

10. What did Lin Yang offer?
    - ○ A) To lend her his coat
    - ○ B) To call a taxi
    - ○ C) To share his umbrella
    - ○ D) To wait inside until the rain stopped

11. Listen. What did he say? (listen in the web app: 我们一起走吧！)
    - ○ A) Let's take a taxi
    - ○ B) Let's walk together
    - ○ C) Let's wait here
    - ○ D) Let's go home separately

12. 一边走一边聊天: they walked and chatted...
    - ○ A) one after the other
    - ○ B) only on rainy days
    - ○ C) in different places
    - ○ D) at the same time

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13. How does Xiaoyu feel about rainy days at the end?

- ○ A) She still hated them
- ○ B) She was afraid of them
- ○ C) She began to like them
- ○ D) She never thought about them again

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礼

UNIT 6 · LESSON 3 · 18 MINUTES

Story 3: The Birthday Present

A graded story (HSK 2) about choosing a gift in China.

- Read a longer HSK 2 story
- Learn why some gifts are avoided in China
- Answer comprehension questions

Your third story mixes reading with real culture. Anna wants to find the perfect birthday present for a Chinese friend, but some gifts are not what they seem!

Words in this story

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
汉语	Hànyǔ	Chinese (language)
已经	yǐjīng	already
生日	shēngrì	birthday
送	sòng	to give (as a gift)
礼物	lǐwù	present, gift
钟	zhōng	clock
告诉	gàosu	to tell
蛋糕	dàngāo	cake
卡片	kǎpiàn	card
感动	gǎndòng	moved, touched

The story

生日礼物 (Shēngrì lǐwù): The Birthday Present

安娜在北京学习汉语已经一年了。

安娜	在	北京	学习	汉语	已经	一年	了
Anna	in	Beijing	study	Chinese	already	one year	(so far)

Ānnà zài Běijīng xuéxí Hànyǔ yǐjīng yì nián le.

Anna has been studying Chinese in Beijing for a year now.

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下个星期六是她的中国朋友小美的生日。

下个	星期六	是	她的	中国	朋友	小美	的	生日
next	Saturday	is	her	Chinese	friend	Xiaomei	('s)	birthday

Xià ge xīngqīliù shì tā de Zhōngguó péngyou Xiǎoměi de shēngrì.

Next Saturday is her Chinese friend Xiaomei's birthday.

安娜想送她一个礼物，可是不知道送什么。

安娜	想	送	她	一个	礼物	可是	不	知道	送	什么
Anna	wants	give	her	a	present	but	doesn't	know	give	what

Ānnà xiǎng sòng tā yí ge lǐwù, kěshì bù zhīdào sòng shénme.

Anna wants to give her a present, but she doesn't know what to give.

她想买一个漂亮的钟。

她	想	买	一个	漂亮的	钟
she	wants	buy	a	pretty	clock

Tā xiǎng mǎi yí ge piàoliang de zhōng.

She thinks of buying a pretty clock.

可是同学告诉她：“在中国，不能送钟。”

可是	同学	告诉	她	在	中国	不能	送	钟
but	classmate	tells	her	in	China	can't	give	clock

Kěshì tóngxué gàosu tā: “Zài Zhōngguó, bù néng sòng zhōng.”

But a classmate tells her: “In China, you can't give a clock.”

送钟 (sòng zhōng, give a clock) sounds just like 送终 (sòngzhōng), caring for someone at their death.

安娜又想送一把伞，同学说这也不太好。

安娜	又	想	送	一把	伞	同学	说	这	也	不太	好
Anna	then (again)	thinks of	giving	an	umbrella	classmate	says	this	also	not very	good

Ānnà yòu xiǎng sòng yì bǎ sǎn, tóngxué shuō zhè yě bú tài hǎo.

Then Anna thinks of an umbrella, but her classmate says that's not great either.

伞 (sǎn) sounds like 散 (sàn), ‘to break up, separate’.

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最后，安娜自己做了一个蛋糕，还写了一张中文卡片。

最后	安娜	自己	做了	一个	蛋糕	还	写了	一张	中文	卡片
in the end	Anna	herself	made	a	cake	also	wrote	a (measure word for flat things)	Chinese	card

Zuìhòu, Ānnà zìjǐ zuò le yí ge dàngāo, hái xiě le yì zhāng Zhōngwén kǎpiàn.

In the end, Anna bakes a cake herself and writes a card in Chinese.

卡片上写着：“祝你生日快乐，天天开心！”

卡片	上	写着	祝	你	生日	快乐	天天	开心
card	on	is written	wish	you	birthday	happy	every day	happy

Kǎpiàn shang xiězhe: “Zhù nǐ shēngrì kuàilè, tiāntiān kāixīn!”

The card says: “Happy birthday! Be happy every day!”

小美看了很感动：“这是我最喜欢的礼物！”

小美	看了	很	感动	这	是	我	最	喜欢	的	礼物
Xiaomei	read it	very	touched	this	is	my	most	liked	(that)	present

Xiǎoměi kàn le hěn gǎndòng: “Zhè shì wǒ zuì xǐhuan de lǐwù!”

Xiaomei reads it and is very touched: “This is my favourite present!”

CULTURE NOTE

Hand-made gifts and cards written in Chinese are always appreciated. Your effort matters more than the price.

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Read the whole story

Read the whole story aloud.

安娜在北京学习汉语已经一年了。
下个星期六是她的中国朋友小美的生日。
安娜想送她一个礼物，可是不知道送什么。
她想买一个漂亮的钟。
可是同学告诉她："在中国，不能送钟。"
安娜又想送一把伞，同学说这也不太好。
最后，安娜自己做了一个蛋糕，还写了一张中文卡片。
卡片上写着："祝你生日快乐，天天开心！"
小美看了很感动："这是我最喜欢的礼物！"

Did you understand?

QUIZ

14. How long has Anna studied Chinese in Beijing?

- ○ A) One month
- ○ B) One year
- ○ C) Two years
- ○ D) Six months

15. Why shouldn't you give a clock?

- ○ A) Clocks are too cheap
- ○ B) Clocks are much too expensive
- ○ C) Nobody uses clocks now
- ○ D) It sounds unlucky

16. What's the problem with giving an umbrella?

- ○ A) It sounds like "split up"
- ○ B) It's only a gift for old people
- ○ C) It means bad weather
- ○ D) It's too big

17. What does Anna give in the end?

- ○ A) A cake she made and a card
- ○ B) An expensive clock from a shop
- ○ C) A big red umbrella and a hat
- ○ D) A book

18. Listen. What does the card say? (listen in the web app: 祝你生日快乐！)

- ○ A) Happy New Year
- ○ B) Happy birthday to you
- ○ C) Thank you for the present
- ○ D) Good luck in your exam

19. 感动 means...

- ○ A) a little bit angry
- ○ B) very surprised
- ○ C) really tired
- ○ D) moved, touched

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月

UNIT 6 · LESSON 4 · 15 MINUTES

Poem: Quiet Night Thoughts

Li Bai's famous Tang poem 《静夜思》, line by line.

- Read and understand 《静夜思》 line by line
- Recite the poem with a natural rhythm
- Compare poetic words with modern ones

《静夜思》 (Jìng Yè Sī, 'Quiet Night Thoughts') was written by **Li Bai** (李白, 701–762), one of the greatest poets of the Tang dynasty. Almost every Chinese child learns it by heart. It's short, simple and beautiful: a traveller sees moonlight and misses home.

Words in the poem

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
李白	Lǐ Bái	Li Bai, Tang dynasty poet
明月	míngyuè	bright moon
光	guāng	light
霜	shuāng	frost
举头	jǔ tóu	to raise your head
低头	dī tóu	to lower your head
故乡	gùxiāng	hometown (literary)

The poem, line by line

静夜思 · 李白 (Jìng Yè Sī · Lǐ Bái)

床前明月光，

床	前	明	月	光
bed	in front of	bright	moon	light

Chuáng qián míng yuè guāng,

Before my bed, the bright moonlight shines;

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疑是地上霜。

疑	是	地	上	霜
wonder, suspect	is	ground	on	frost

yí shì dì shàng shuāng.

I wonder if it's frost upon the ground.

举头望明月，

举	头	望	明	月
raise	head	gaze at	bright	moon

Jǔ tóu wàng míng yuè,

I raise my head and gaze at the bright moon;

低头思故乡。

低	头	思	故乡
lower	head	think of, miss	hometown

dī tóu sī gùxiāng.

I lower my head and think of home.

Poetic vs everyday words

望

wàng (poetic)

To gaze into the distance. In everyday speech: 看 (kàn).

思

sī (literary)

To think of, to miss. In everyday speech: 想 (xiǎng).

故乡

gùxiāng (literary)

Hometown. In everyday speech: 老家 (lǎojiā).

DID YOU KNOW?

The poem has 4 lines of 5 characters, a form called 五言绝句 (wǔyán juéjù). Lines 1, 2 and 4 rhyme: guāng, shuāng, xiāng.

CULTURE NOTE

Scholars still debate what 床 means here. Today it means ‘bed’, but some think Li Bai meant a folding seat or the railing around a well. Either way, the feeling of homesickness is the same.

CULTURE NOTE

The poem is a favourite at the Mid-Autumn Festival, when the moon is full and people think of family far away.

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How to recite it

1 **Read slowly in 2 + 3 beats**

床前，明月光，

Chuáng qián, míng yuè guāng,

Before my bed, bright moonlight,

Make a tiny pause after the second character of every line.

2 **Stretch the rhyme**

疑是地上霜。

Yí shì dì shàng shuāng.

I wonder if it's frost on the ground.

Let the last syllable of lines 1, 2 and 4 ring a little longer.

3 **Look up as you say line 3**

举头望明月，

Jǔ tóu wàng míng yuè,

I raise my head and gaze at the moon,

Acting it out helps you remember.

4 **Look down for line 4**

低头思故乡。

Dī tóu sī gùxiāng.

I lower my head and think of home.

Copy each line in your notebook, saying it aloud as you write.

床前明月光

床前明月光

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疑是地上霜

疑是地上霜

举头望明月

举头望明月

低头思故乡

低头思故乡

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Recite the poem

Recite the whole poem. Then try it from memory!

床前明月光，
疑是地上霜。
举头望明月，
低头思故乡。

Quick quiz

QUIZ

20. Who wrote 《静夜思》?

- ○ A) Du Fu (杜甫)
- ○ B) Confucius (孔子)
- ○ C) Li Bai (李白)
- ○ D) Lu Xun (鲁迅)

21. At first, what does the poet think the moonlight is?

- ○ A) Snow falling on the mountains
- ○ B) Frost on the ground
- ○ C) A lamp by the bed
- ○ D) Water in the river

22. 故乡 means...

- ○ A) old friend
- ○ B) far away
- ○ C) hometown
- ○ D) the night sky

23. Listen. Which line is this? (listen in the web app: 举头望明月)

- ○ A) 举头望明月
- ○ B) 低头思故乡
- ○ C) 床前明月光
- ○ D) 疑是地上霜

24. Li Bai lived during which dynasty?

- ○ A) Song
- ○ B) Ming
- ○ C) Qing
- ○ D) Tang

25. Which words rhyme in the poem?

- ○ A) 床, 月, 头
- ○ B) 前, 是, 望
- ○ C) 明, 举, 低
- ○ D) 光, 霜, 乡

26. In everyday Chinese, 思 (to miss) is usually...

- ○ A) 看 (kàn)
- ○ B) 想 (xiǎng)
- ○ C) 说 (shuō)
- ○ D) 听 (tīng)

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成

UNIT 6 · LESSON 5 · 15 MINUTES

Chengyu & Everyday Sayings

Four-character idioms and sayings that make your Chinese shine.

- Know what a chengyu is
- Use a few common chengyu and sayings
- Learn two famous idiom stories

A 成语 (chéngyǔ) is a fixed idiom, usually four characters long. Many come from old stories or classic books. Using one at the right moment always impresses Chinese speakers!

What makes a chengyu

Usually 4 characters, fixed word order, a meaning that is more than the sum of its parts.

How to say it: Learn the literal meaning AND the real meaning, plus when to use it.

一举两得 yì jǔ liǎng dé

入乡随俗 rù xiāng suí sú

Useful chengyu

一路平安
yí lù píng'ān
Have a safe trip!
Literally: 'the whole road, peace'. Say it to someone setting off.

熟能生巧
shú néng shēng qiǎo
Practice makes perfect.
Literally: 'familiarity gives birth to skill'.

入乡随俗
rù xiāng suí sú
When in Rome, do as the Romans do.
Literally: 'enter a village, follow its customs'.

一举两得
yì jǔ liǎng dé
Kill two birds with one stone.
Literally: 'one action, two gains'.

马马虎虎
mǎmǎhūhū
So-so; careless.
Literally: 'horse horse tiger tiger'.

对牛弹琴
duì niú tán qín
To talk to the wrong audience.
Literally: 'play the zither to a cow'.

半途而废
bàn tú ér fèi
To give up halfway.
Literally: 'stop halfway along the road'.

马到成功
mǎ dào chéng gōng
Instant success! (a good-luck wish)
Literally: 'the horse arrives, success'.

Story: waiting by the stump

DID YOU KNOW?

守株待兔 (shǒu zhū dài tù): A farmer saw a rabbit run into a tree stump and die. He stopped farming and waited by the stump every day for another rabbit. None came, and his fields went to weeds. It means waiting for luck instead of working.

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Story: drawing feet on a snake

DID YOU KNOW?

画蛇添足 (huà shé tiān zú): Some friends raced to draw a snake to win a cup of wine. The fastest finished, then decided to add feet. Another man finished and took the wine: 'Snakes don't have feet!' It means spoiling something by adding what isn't needed.

Everyday sayings

慢慢来

màn màn lái

Take your time; no rush.

活到老，学到老

huó dào lǎo, xué dào lǎo

You're never too old to learn.

百闻不如一见

bǎi wén bù rú yí jiàn

Seeing once beats hearing a hundred times.

千里之行，始于足下

qiān lǐ zhī xíng, shǐ yú zú xià

A journey of a thousand li begins with a single step. From the 道德经 (Dào Dé Jīng). A 里 (lǐ) is a traditional unit of distance.

三人行，必有我师

sān rén xíng, bì yǒu wǒ shī

Among any three people, one can teach me something.
Adapted from the Analects of Confucius.

学汉语要慢慢来。

学	汉语	要	慢慢来
learn	Chinese	need to	take it slowly

Xué Hànyǔ yào màn màn lái.

Learning Chinese takes time; go step by step.

熟能生巧，每天练习吧！

熟能生巧	每天	练习	吧
practice makes perfect	every day	practise	(let's)

Shú néng shēng qiǎo, měitiān liànxí ba!

Practice makes perfect, so practise every day!

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祝你一路平安!

祝	你	一路平安
wish	you	a safe journey

Zhù nǐ yí lù píng'ān!

Have a safe trip!

WATCH OUT

Chengyu are powerful but easy to overuse. One well-chosen chengyu in a conversation is great; five in a row sounds like a textbook!

Say it aloud

Read each chengyu and saying aloud. Say the meaning in English after each one.

一路平安

熟能生巧

入乡随俗

一举两得

马马虎虎

慢慢来

活到老，学到老

Quick quiz

QUIZ

27. How many characters does a typical chengyu have?

- ○ A) Four
- ○ B) Two
- ○ C) Six
- ○ D) Eight

28. Which chengyu means “When in Rome, do as the Romans do”?

- ○ A) 一举两得
- ○ B) 半途而废
- ○ C) 入乡随俗
- ○ D) 对牛弹琴

29. 画蛇添足 (drawing feet on a snake) describes...

- ○ A) working hard until the job is done
- ○ B) being lucky
- ○ C) adding something useless
- ○ D) drawing well

30. Listen. What does this mean? (listen in the web app: 熟能生巧)

- ○ A) Practice makes perfect
- ○ B) Have a safe trip
- ○ C) Take your time
- ○ D) Never too old to learn

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31. A friend is leaving for the airport. What do you say?

- ○ A) 马马虎虎!
- ○ B) 一路平安!
- ○ C) 半途而废!
- ○ D) 对牛弹琴!

32. 守株待兔 warns against…

- ○ A) hunting rabbits in the forest
- ○ B) cutting down old trees
- ○ C) farming in winter
- ○ D) waiting for luck

33. 马马虎虎, literally 'horse horse tiger tiger', means…

- ○ A) so-so, careless
- ○ B) very brave
- ○ C) fast and strong
- ○ D) wild animals

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UNIT 6 · LESSON 6 · 18 MINUTES

Chinese Festivals

Spring Festival, Mid-Autumn and Dragon Boat: food, customs and greetings.

- Name the three big traditional festivals
- Know their foods, customs and greetings
- Understand puns behind festival traditions

Traditional Chinese festivals follow the lunar calendar, so their dates change every year on the Western calendar. Each one has its own food, stories and greetings.

Three big festivals

Festival	When	Food	Greeting
春节 Spring Festival	1st day of the 1st lunar month (late Jan to mid Feb)	饺子, fish, 年糕	新年快乐！ 过年好！
中秋节 Mid-Autumn Festival	15th day of the 8th lunar month (Sept or early Oct)	月饼 mooncakes	中秋快乐！
端午节 Dragon Boat Festival	5th day of the 5th lunar month (usually June)	粽子 sticky rice in bamboo leaves	端午安康！

Festival words

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
春节	Chūn Jié	Spring Festival, Chinese New Year
除夕	Chúxī	New Year's Eve (lunar)
年夜饭	niányèfàn	New Year's Eve reunion dinner
红包	hóngbāo	red envelope (with money)
春联	chūnlián	New Year couplets (red door poems)
恭喜发财	gōngxǐ fācái	wishing you prosperity!
中秋节	Zhōngqiū Jié	Mid-Autumn Festival
月饼	yuèbing	mooncake
赏月	shǎng yuè	to admire the moon
端午节	Duānwǔ Jié	Dragon Boat Festival

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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
粽子	zòngzi	sticky rice wrapped in bamboo leaves
龙舟	lóngzhōu	dragon boat

Going home for the New Year

Mia 春节你回老家吗?
Chūn Jié nǐ huí lǎojiā ma?
Are you going back to your hometown for Spring Festival?

Xiao Zhang 回！我们全家一起吃年夜饭。
Huí! Wǒmen quán jiā yìqǐ chī niányèfàn.
Yes! My whole family has the reunion dinner together.

Mia 你们吃什么?
Nǐmen chī shénme?
What do you eat?

Xiao Zhang 饺子、鱼，还有很多菜。年年有余嘛！
Jiǎozi, yú, hái yǒu hěn duō cài. Nián nián yǒu yú ma!
Dumplings, fish and lots of dishes. 'Surplus every year', you know!

Mia 你会收到红包吗?
Nǐ huì shōudào hóngbāo ma?
Will you get red envelopes?

Xiao Zhang 当然！奶奶每年都给我红包。
Dāngrán! Nǎinai měi nián dōu gěi wǒ hóngbāo.
Of course! Grandma gives me one every year.

Mia 那我先祝你新年快乐！
Nà wǒ xiān zhù nǐ xīnnián kuàilè!
Then let me wish you a happy New Year in advance!

Xiao Zhang 谢谢！也祝你新年快乐！
Xièxie! Yě zhù nǐ xīnnián kuàilè!
Thanks! Happy New Year to you too!

MEMORY TRICK

Fish (鱼, yú) sounds like 余 (yú, 'surplus'), so 年年有余 means 'may you have more than enough every year'. That's why fish is served at the New Year's Eve dinner.

CULTURE NOTE

You'll see 福 (fú, good fortune) hung upside down on doors. 'Upside down' is 倒 (dào), which sounds like 到 (dào, 'to arrive'): good fortune has arrived!

CULTURE NOTE

Red envelopes (红包) are given by older relatives to children, and by married adults to younger unmarried relatives. Amounts with 8 are popular and amounts with 4 are avoided. Many people now also send digital red envelopes on WeChat.

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中秋节我们一起吃月饼、赏月。

中秋节	我们	一起	吃	月饼	赏月
Mid-Autumn Festival	we	together	eat	mooncakes	admire the moon

Zhōngqiū Jié wǒmen yìqǐ chī yuèbing, shǎng yuè.

At Mid-Autumn we eat mooncakes and admire the moon together.

CULTURE NOTE

Mid-Autumn is a time for family reunion (团圆, tuányuán). The legend says the goddess 嫦娥 (Cháng'é) lives on the moon with a jade rabbit. China's moon probes are named Chang'e after her.

端午节有龙舟比赛。

端午节	有	龙舟	比赛
Dragon Boat Festival	there are	dragon boat	races

Duānwǔ Jié yǒu lóngzhōu bǐsài.

There are dragon boat races at the Dragon Boat Festival.

CULTURE NOTE

The Dragon Boat Festival remembers the poet 屈原 (Qū Yuán), who drowned himself in the Miluo River about 2,300 years ago. Legend says people raced out in boats to find him. Because of this sad origin, many people prefer the greeting 端午安康 ('peace and health').

DID YOU KNOW?

The Spring Festival season ends with the Lantern Festival (元宵节, Yuánxiāo Jié) on the 15th day, with lanterns, riddles and sweet rice balls (汤圆, tāngyuán).

Role-play: Spring Festival greetings

1 **Greet friends**

新年快乐!

Xīnnián kuàilè!

Happy New Year!

2 **Greet older relatives**

过年好!

Guònián hǎo!

Happy New Year!

A warm, traditional greeting, often said to elders.

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3 **Wish prosperity**

恭喜发财！

Gōngxǐ fācái!

Wishing you prosperity!

Children sometimes cheekily add 红包拿来！: 'now hand over the red envelope!'

4 **Wish good health**

身体健康！

Shēntǐ jiànkāng!

Good health!

5 **Wish surplus**

年年有余！

Nián nián yǒu yú!

Plenty every year!

Say it aloud

Read each festival greeting aloud.

新年快乐！

过年好！

恭喜发财！

中秋快乐！

端午安康！

年年有余！

Quick quiz

QUIZ

34. When is the Spring Festival?

- ○ A) Always on 1 January every year
- ○ B) In the middle of summer
- ○ C) Every October 1st
- ○ D) Late Jan to mid Feb

35. What do people eat at the Mid-Autumn Festival?

- ○ A) 粽子 rice in leaves
- ○ B) 汤圆 sweet rice balls
- ○ C) 月饼 mooncakes
- ○ D) 饺子 dumplings

36. Listen. What is the greeting? (listen in the web app: 新年快乐！)

- ○ A) Happy birthday
- ○ B) Happy New Year
- ○ C) Happy Mid-Autumn
- ○ D) Have a safe trip

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37. Why is 福 hung upside down?

- ○ A) It's an old printing mistake
- ○ B) To keep away the winter cold
- ○ C) A pun on “arrived”
- ○ D) So children can read it

38. The Dragon Boat Festival remembers…

- ○ A) the moon goddess Chang'e
- ○ B) the poet Qu Yuan
- ○ C) the first emperor
- ○ D) Confucius

39. Why is fish served at the New Year's Eve dinner?

- ○ A) It's the cheapest dish
- ○ B) Fish is the national animal
- ○ C) Children love fish most of all
- ○ D) Its name sounds like “surplus”

40. A 红包 is…

- ○ A) a red envelope with money
- ○ B) a red paper lantern for the door
- ○ C) a New Year poem
- ○ D) a firecracker

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UNIT 6 · LESSON 7 · 18 MINUTES

Culture Tips: Names, Gifts, Numbers & Table Manners

Everyday customs that help you make a great impression.

- Understand Chinese names and titles
- Give and receive gifts politely
- Know lucky and unlucky numbers
- Follow basic table manners

Good manners open doors everywhere. These tips cover the situations visitors meet most: names, gifts, numbers and meals. Customs vary by region and family, so watch what others do and follow along.

Names

In Chinese names the **surname comes first**. In 王小明, 王 (Wáng) is the surname and 小明 (Xiǎomíng) the given name. The most common surnames include 王, 李, 张, 刘 and 陈.

Titles and forms of address

Title	Pinyin	Use it for
王先生	Wáng xiānsheng	Mr Wang
王女士	Wáng nǚshì	Ms Wang
王老师	Wáng lǎoshī	Teacher Wang (also polite for respected professionals)
小王	Xiǎo Wáng	a younger friend or colleague
老王	Lǎo Wáng	an older friend or colleague (friendly, not rude)
阿姨 / 叔叔	āyí / shūshu	auntie / uncle: any adult of your parents' age

您贵姓?

您 — you (polite)

贵姓 — honourable surname

Nín guìxìng?

What's your surname? (very polite)

Answer with 我姓....., e.g. 我姓李 (My surname is Li).

Gifts

Bring a small gift when you visit someone's home: fruit, tea, sweets or something from your country. Give and receive gifts **with both hands**.

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一点儿小意思，请收下。

一点儿	小意思	请	收下
a little	small token	please	accept

Yìdiǎnr xiǎo yìsi, qǐng shōuxià.

Just a little something, please accept it.

CULTURE NOTE

People may politely refuse a gift once or twice before accepting, so offer again kindly. Gifts are often not opened in front of the giver.

WATCH OUT

Traditionally avoided gifts: clocks (钟, sounds like 'end of life'), umbrellas (伞, sounds like 'separate'), pears to share (梨 lí sounds like 离 lí, 'to part') and green hats (a joke about an unfaithful partner). Red and gold wrapping is festive; plain white or black is linked to funerals.

Lucky and unlucky numbers

八
bā
8: sounds like 发 (fā, to prosper). The luckiest number!

六
liù
6: 六六大顺, 'everything goes smoothly'.

九
jiǔ
9: sounds like 久 (jiǔ, long-lasting). Lucky for love and long life.

四
sì
4: sounds like 死 (sǐ, death). Some buildings skip 4th floors.

五二零
wǔ èr líng
520: sounds a bit like 我爱你 (I love you). 20 May is an online 'love day'.

DID YOU KNOW?

The Beijing Olympics opened on 8 August 2008 at 8:08 p.m. Lucky eights everywhere!

Table manners

At a meal, wait for the host or the eldest person to start. The host often orders and may put food in your bowl as a kind gesture.

At the table

Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
筷子	kuàizi	chopsticks
干杯	gānbēi	cheers! (literally 'dry the glass')

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Mandarin	Say it	Meaning
敬酒	jìngjiǔ	to propose a toast
随意	suíyì	as you like (drink as much as you want)
请客	qǐngkè	to treat (pay for others)

我敬您一杯！

我	敬	您	一杯
I	respectfully toast	you (polite)	a glass

Wǒ jìng nín yì bēi!

Let me drink a toast to you!

大家慢慢吃。

大家	慢慢	吃
everyone	slowly	eat

Dàjiā mànmàn chī.

Enjoy your meal, everyone.

Say this if you finish and leave the table before others.

WATCH OUT

Never stand your chopsticks upright in a bowl of rice: it looks like incense sticks at a funeral. Don't tap your bowl with them or point them at people either.

CULTURE NOTE

When clinking glasses with an older person or a boss, hold your glass a little lower than theirs to show respect. If you don't want to drink it all, say 随意 and just take a sip.

CULTURE NOTE

Hosts traditionally order more than everyone can eat, to show generosity. Today many people also support the 'Clean Plate' campaign (光盘行动, guāngpán xíngdòng) against food waste, so finishing your rice is fine.

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Role-play: visiting a Chinese family

1 **Give your gift**

一点儿小意思。

Yìdiǎnr xiǎo yìsi.

Just a little something.

Use both hands.

2 **Greet the parents**

叔叔好！阿姨好！

Shūshu hǎo! Āyí hǎo!

Hello, uncle! Hello, auntie!

3 **Praise the food**

太好吃了！

Tài hǎochī le!

It's delicious!

4 **Toast your host**

我敬您一杯！

Wǒ jìng nín yì bēi!

A toast to you!

Hold your glass a little lower than theirs.

5 **Thank them and leave**

谢谢款待，我先走了。

Xièxie kuǎndài, wǒ xiān zǒu le.

Thank you for your hospitality. I'll be going now.

Say it aloud

Read each line aloud.

您贵姓?

我姓李。

一点儿小意思，请收下。

我敬您一杯！

干杯！

大家慢慢吃。

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Quick quiz

QUIZ

41. In the name 王小明, which part is the surname?

- ○ A) 小明
- ○ B) 明
- ○ C) 王
- ○ D) 小

42. Which number is considered unlucky?

- ○ A) 8
- ○ B) 4
- ○ C) 6
- ○ D) 9

43. Why is 8 a lucky number?

- ○ A) Its shape looks like a dragon
- ○ B) It's the emperor's age
- ○ C) It's the number of festivals
- ○ D) It sounds like “prosper”

44. What should you NOT do with chopsticks?

- ○ A) Stand them up in your rice
- ○ B) Use them to pick up vegetables
- ○ C) Put them down on the chopstick rest
- ○ D) Hold them near the top

45. How do you give or receive a gift politely?

- ○ A) With your left hand only
- ○ B) With both hands
- ○ C) Without looking at the person
- ○ D) Quickly and silently

46. Listen. What does it mean? (listen in the web app: 干杯！)

- ○ A) Enjoy your meal!
- ○ B) Thank you!
- ○ C) Cheers!
- ○ D) Goodbye!

47. 520 is popular online because it sounds like...

- ○ A) “I'm hungry”
- ○ B) “Happy birthday”
- ○ C) “Goodbye”
- ○ D) “I love you”

48. Which gift is traditionally avoided?

- ○ A) A clock
- ○ B) A basket of fruit
- ○ C) A box of tea
- ○ D) Chocolate

☐ Lesson done Date: _____

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UNIT 6 · LESSON 8 · 20 MINUTES

复 Final Review Lab

Bring everything together: conversation, reading, culture and the poem.

- Follow a longer conversation that mixes many topics
- Check your listening and writing
- Review culture, chengyu and the poem

Congratulations on reaching the final lab! This lesson mixes everything from Units 5 and 6. Read, listen, write and test yourself. Don't worry about mistakes: 慢慢来!

Plans for Mid-Autumn

Xiaomei 安娜，中秋节你有什么打算?
Ānnà, Zhōngqiū Jié nǐ yǒu shénme dǎsuan?
Anna, what are your plans for Mid-Autumn?

Anna 还没想好。你呢?
Hái méi xiǎng hǎo. Nǐ ne?
I haven't decided yet. And you?

Xiaomei 来我家吧！我妈妈会做很多菜。
Lái wǒ jiā ba! Wǒ māma huì zuò hěn duō cài.
Come to my place! My mum will cook lots of dishes.

Anna 太好了！我带什么礼物好呢?
Tài hǎo le! Wǒ dài shénme lǐwù hǎo ne?
Great! What gift should I bring?

Xiaomei 带一盒月饼就行，别带钟啊！
Dài yì hé yuèbing jiù xíng, bié dài zhōng a!
A box of mooncakes is fine. Just don't bring a clock!

Anna 哈哈，我知道！晚上我们一起赏月吧。
Hāhā, wǒ zhīdào! Wǎnshang wǒmen yìqǐ shǎng yuè ba.
Haha, I know! Let's admire the moon together in the evening.

Xiaomei 好啊。天气预报说那天是晴天。
Hǎo a. Tiānqì yùbào shuō nà tiān shì qíngtiān.
Sure. The forecast says it'll be sunny that day.

Anna 那我们可以一起念《静夜思》！
Nà wǒmen kěyǐ yìqǐ niàn "Jìng Yè Sī"!
Then we can recite "Quiet Night Thoughts" together!

Sentence puzzle 1

你周末想去哪儿玩?

你	周末	想	去	哪儿	玩
you	weekend	want	go	where	have fun

Nǐ zhōumò xiǎng qù nǎr wán?

Where do you want to go this weekend?

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Sentence puzzle 2

我在中国学了很多东西。

我	在	中国	学了	很多	东西
I	in	China	learned	a lot of	things

Wǒ zài Zhōngguó xué le hěn duō dōngxi.

I learned a lot in China.

Sentence puzzle 3

请问，附近有好吃的饭馆吗?

请问	附近	有	好吃的	饭馆	吗
excuse me	nearby	is there	tasty	restaurant	(question word)

Qǐngwèn, fùjìn yǒu hǎochī de fànguǎn ma?

Excuse me, is there a good restaurant nearby?

Listen and write

A teacher or friend reads each item aloud, or press "Listen" in the web app. Write what you hear; answers are at the end of the unit.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____

Challenge: a day out in China

1 **Ask the way**

请问，地铁站怎么走?

Qǐngwèn, dìtiězhàn zěnme zǒu?

Excuse me, how do I get to the subway station?

2 **Take the subway**

去西单坐几号线?

Qù Xīdān zuò jǐ hào xiàn?

Which line goes to Xidan?

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3 **Go shopping**

太贵了，便宜一点儿吧！

Tài guì le, piányi yìdiǎnr ba!

Too expensive. Make it cheaper!

4 **Order lunch**

来一碗牛肉面，不要太辣。

Lái yì wǎn niúròu miàn, bú yào tài là.

A bowl of beef noodles, not too spicy.

5 **Message a friend**

我们晚上见吧，不见不散！

Wǒmen wǎnshang jiàn ba, bú jiàn bú sàn!

Let's meet tonight. See you there!

Can you do it?

Check yourself

☐ I can order food, ask about spice and pay the bill.

☐ I can ask prices and bargain politely.

☐ I can ask for and follow directions.

☐ I can take a taxi or the subway.

☐ I can make plans and say no politely.

☐ I can tell a doctor what's wrong.

☐ I can read a short story in characters.

☐ I can recite 《静夜思》 from memory.

☐ I can explain three festivals and a few customs.

Give your work today some stars ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆

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Final read-aloud

Read these favourite lines from the course aloud.

买单！

便宜一点儿吧。

不见不散！

多喝热水！

熟能生巧。

床前明月光，疑是地上霜。

举头望明月，低头思故乡。

Final quiz

QUIZ

49. You're at a restaurant and want the bill. You say…

- A) 打包！
- B) 买单！
- C) 点菜！
- D) 干杯！

50. Listen. What is the shopper asking? (listen in the web app: 便宜一点儿吧。)

- A) It's too small
- B) I'll take two
- C) Do you have any other colours?
- D) Make it a bit cheaper

51. 往左拐 means…

- A) turn left
- B) turn right
- C) go straight
- D) get off

52. Which festival has dragon boat races?

- A) 春节
- B) 中秋节
- C) 端午节
- D) 元宵节

53. Complete the poem: 举头望明月，……

- A) 低头思故乡
- B) 疑是地上霜
- C) 床前明月光
- D) 低头看月亮

54. Which gift should you avoid?

- A) 茶 (tea)
- B) 水果 (fruit)
- C) 钟 (a clock)
- D) 月饼 (mooncakes)

55. Listen. What does the speaker say? (listen in the web app: 我对花生过敏。)

- A) I like peanuts
- B) I have a cold
- C) Peanuts are cheap here
- D) I'm allergic to peanuts

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56. 熟能生巧 means...

- ○ A) Take your time
- ○ B) Practice makes perfect
- ○ C) Safe journey
- ○ D) Never too old to learn anything

☐ Lesson done Date: _____

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UNIT 6

Answer key

Dictation

1. 多少钱？ (Duōshao qián?)
2. 往左拐。 (Wǎng zuǒ guǎi.)
3. 我头疼。 (Wǒ tóuténg.)
4. 你有空吗？ (Nǐ yǒu kòng ma?)
5. 新年快乐！ (Xīnnián kuàilè!)
6. 举头望明月。 (Jǔ tóu wàng míng yuè.)

Quiz

1. C) Sunday
2. D) 8:00
3. A) Steamed buns and milk
4. B) An apple and three books
5. D) Watching TV
6. C) He is tired
7. B) rain
8. A) The morning was sunny
9. A) In the afternoon
10. C) To share his umbrella
11. B) Let's walk together
12. D) at the same time
13. C) She began to like them
14. B) One year
15. D) It sounds unlucky
16. A) It sounds like “split up”
17. A) A cake she made and a card
18. B) Happy birthday to you
19. D) moved, touched
20. C) Li Bai (李白)
21. B) Frost on the ground
22. C) hometown
23. A) 举头望明月
24. D) Tang
25. D) 光, 霜, 乡
26. B) 想 (xiǎng)
27. A) Four
28. C) 入乡随俗
29. C) adding something useless
30. A) Practice makes perfect
31. B) 一路平安!
32. D) waiting for luck
33. A) so-so, careless
34. D) Late Jan to mid Feb
35. C) 月饼 mooncakes
36. B) Happy New Year
37. C) A pun on “arrived”
38. B) the poet Qu Yuan
39. D) Its name sounds like “surplus”
40. A) a red envelope with money
41. C) 王
42. B) 4
43. D) It sounds like “prosper”
44. A) Stand them up in your rice
45. B) With both hands
46. C) Cheers!
47. D) “I love you”
48. A) A clock
49. B) 买单!
50. D) Make it a bit cheaper
51. A) turn left
52. C) 端午节
53. A) 低头思故乡
54. C) 钟 (a clock)
55. D) I'm allergic to peanuts
56. B) Practice makes perfect

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WORD SEARCH 1

Pinyin Reading Lab

Find and circle the words in the grid. They run left to right or top to bottom.

员	同	色	礼	外	约	晚	车
金	书	喜	没	客	面	车	下
你	印	双	关	喜	音	钱	上
好	文	好	系	下	北	飞	动
么	名	谢	对	朋	妈	谢	谢
奶	买	兴	不	友	外	友	月
车	再	见	起	学	中	退	客
头	女	蛋	开	生	老	师	气

1. 你好 — hello
2. 谢谢 — thank you
3. 再见 — goodbye
4. 对不起 — sorry
5. 没关系 — it does not matter
6. 老师 — teacher
7. 学生 — student
8. 朋友 — friend

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WORD SEARCH 2

Greetings & Politeness

Find and circle the words in the grid. They run left to right or top to bottom.

见	您	好	晚	安	便	门	爷
你	伞	店	饭	早	哪	银	头
好	横	雨	生	上	学	咳	行
霜	节	晚	上	好	肉	订	车
零	有	租	咳	早	好	饭	易
苹	再	见	儿	午	拐	明	喂
发	绿	好	客	刮	校	天	点
系	你	们	好	联	预	见	天

1. 你好 — hello
2. 您好 — hello (polite)
3. 你们好 — hello, everyone
4. 早上好 — good morning
5. 晚上好 — good evening
6. 晚安 — good night (before bed)
7. 再见 — goodbye
8. 明天见 — see you tomorrow

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WORD SEARCH 3

Introducing Yourself

Find and circle the words in the grid. They run left to right or top to bottom.

早	服	星	外	印	中	国	色
果	用	钟	大	不	年	起	天
高	改	色	色	手	学	样	城
兴	间	名	号	色	间	饭	会
美	车	字	撇	月	饼	筷	雪
国	冒	学	学	认	识	多	美
预	地	生	号	下	行	老	看
冷	子	朋	友	作	么	师	中

1. 名字 — name
2. 学生 — student
3. 老师 — teacher
4. 朋友 — friend
5. 认识 — to know (a person), to meet
6. 高兴 — happy, glad
7. 中国 — China
8. 美国 — the USA

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WORD SEARCH 4

Dates & Time

Find and circle the words in the grid. They run left to right or top to bottom.

课	天	节	昨	好	明	早	卖
爷	橙	上	天	那	天	上	间
河	现	在	市	周	飞	饭	今
信	爸	拐	早	末	星	法	天
贵	行	微	早	在	岁	桌	国
长	节	谢	不	牛	生	点	卖
打	上	疼	多	台	日	订	星
师	现	怎	饭	那	冷	印	期

1. 今天 — today
2. 明天 — tomorrow
3. 昨天 — yesterday
4. 星期 — week
5. 周末 — weekend
6. 生日 — birthday
7. 现在 — now
8. 早上 — early morning

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WORD SEARCH 5

Family

Find and circle the words in the grid. They run left to right or top to bottom.

天	好	起	行	见	菜	哥	哥
乡	已	名	姐	大	吃	门	妹
鸭	假	差	姐	人	子	爷	妹
弟	弟	洗	走	雪	会	爷	妈
饼	码	昨	好	西	奶	奶	感
再	爸	爸	校	霜	口	两	药
年	酒	岁	拿	么	妈	妈	下
师	票	请	妹	易	在	冷	起

1. 爸爸 — dad
2. 妈妈 — mum
3. 哥哥 — older brother
4. 姐姐 — older sister
5. 弟弟 — younger brother
6. 妹妹 — younger sister
7. 爷爷 — grandpa (dad's father)
8. 奶奶 — grandma (dad's mother)

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WORD SEARCH 6

Food & Drink

Find and circle the words in the grid. They run left to right or top to bottom.

外	旧	鸡	饺	容	绿	卖	早
中	护	蛋	子	棕	儿	猪	肉
了	星	期	雨	少	中	书	从
床	个	色	折	干	人	四	外
右	直	请	天	谁	色	面	条
问	地	天	后	高	路	啡	饭
国	包	子	儿	卖	牛	鱼	鸡
色	起	米	饭	星	肉	色	肉

1. 米饭 — (cooked) rice
2. 面条 — noodles
3. 饺子 — dumplings
4. 包子 — steamed buns
5. 鸡蛋 — egg
6. 鸡肉 — chicken (meat)
7. 牛肉 — beef
8. 猪肉 — pork

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WORD SEARCH 7

Colours

Find and circle the words in the grid. They run left to right or top to bottom.

聊	榴	一	子	外	员	黄	色
雨	卖	行	颜	色	大	下	国
红	色	绿	色	蓝	司	诉	亚
电	色	天	上	色	再	下	姓
除	在	银	电	话	人	红	子
橙	老	块	山	去	卖	龙	奶
色	捺	冒	孩	色	白	毛	黑
怎	办	节	天	意	色	片	色

1. 颜色 — colour
2. 红色 — red
3. 黄色 — yellow
4. 蓝色 — blue
5. 绿色 — green
6. 白色 — white
7. 黑色 — black
8. 橙色 — orange

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WORD SEARCH 8

Places & Transport

Find and circle the words in the grid. They run left to right or top to bottom.

线	医	院	银	行	菜	多	交
开	问	错	市	号	伞	天	肉
一	友	打	你	商	银	酒	店
爸	不	起	春	店	学	校	莲
公	园	赏	没	单	杯	起	早
饭	照	直	超	发	二	饼	黄
馆	车	谢	市	友	京	影	朋
口	色	桌	好	冒	见	多	杯

1. 学校 — school
2. 医院 — hospital
3. 银行 — bank
4. 商店 — shop
5. 超市 — supermarket
6. 饭馆 — restaurant
7. 公园 — park
8. 酒店 — hotel

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WORD SEARCH 9

Everyday Objects

Find and circle the words in the grid. They run left to right or top to bottom.

拐	哥	敬	色	机	漂	横	桌
雨	伞	高	问	杯	子	课	子
衣	服	十	粽	椅	线	下	您
不	事	上	钥	子	铁	开	见
手	钩	往	匙	十	过	老	天
书	拿	电	五	面	喜	午	了
是	请	脑	姐	果	车	手	机
月	加	出	钥	报	本	猪	认

1. 手机 — mobile phone
2. 电脑 — computer
3. 桌子 — table, desk
4. 椅子 — chair
5. 杯子 — cup, glass
6. 钥匙 — key
7. 雨伞 — umbrella
8. 衣服 — clothes

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WORD SEARCH 10

在: Where & What's Happening

Find and circle the words in the grid. They run left to right or top to bottom.

自	下	旁	七	机	小	那	弟
哪	喂	电	有	后	面	儿	书
服	日	微	晚	棕	色	旁	面
经	少	字	前	车	口	边	女
子	火	课	面	下	花	间	星
下	护	号	好	色	周	试	八
大	容	试	坐	钟	卖	月	喝
上	兴	爬	见	午	这	儿	酒

1. 旁边 — next to
2. 前面 — in front
3. 后面 — behind
4. 这儿 — here
5. 那儿 — there

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WORD SEARCH 11

了: Completed Actions

Find and circle the words in the grid. They run left to right or top to bottom.

诉	果	哥	年	苹	糕	物	蓝
午	烧	蓝	热	早	春	人	天
饭	半	爷	毛	饭	服	筷	红
子	馆	棕	发	服	电	京	气
电	书	新	有	差	热	车	谢
影	还	东	好	女	下	雨	一
早	没	粉	手	姐	号	晚	哪
颜	累	好	冒	拿	电	饭	币

1. 电影 — film, movie
2. 早饭 — breakfast
3. 午饭 — lunch
4. 晚饭 — dinner
5. 下雨 — to rain
6. 还没 — not yet

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WORD SEARCH 12

Where Do Time Words Go?

Find and circle the words in the grid. They run left to right or top to bottom.

语	民	自	下	个	月	车	以
嗽	单	啡	月	粉	务	单	后
店	周	明	手	么	口	举	半
刚	往	年	房	每	天	以	前
才	上	个	星	期	敬	片	夫
笔	以	洗	爸	没	么	务	饭
子	菜	十	单	三	约	树	再
去	年	节	七	孩	司	末	直

1. 每天 — every day
2. 以前 — before, in the past
3. 以后 — after, later, in future
4. 去年 — last year
5. 明年 — next year
6. 上个星期 — last week
7. 下个月 — next month
8. 刚才 — just now

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SENTENCE PUZZLES

Rebuild each sentence

Write the correct order number under each word (first word = 1). Use the English meaning as a clue, then write the whole sentence on the line below.

1. How are you?

好 ◯ 吗 ◯ 你 ◯

2. I am very well.

好 ◯ 很 ◯ 我 ◯

3. I am not a teacher.

老师 ◯ 是 ◯ 我 ◯ 不 ◯

4. I study Chinese.

中文 ◯ 学 ◯ 我 ◯

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5. My name is Li Ming.

叫 ○ 李明 ○ 我 ○

6. What's your name?

叫 ○ 你 ○ 什么 ○ 名字 ○

7. Nice to meet you.

高兴 ○ 认识 ○ 很 ○ 你 ○

8. Which country are you from?

是 ○ 国 ○ 人 ○ 哪 ○ 你 ○

9. How much is this?

这个 ○ 钱 ○ 多少 ○

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10. What's the date today?

今天 几 月 号 几

11. What day is it today?

几 今天 星期

12. What time is it now?

点 现在 几

13. How many people are in your family?

几 口 家 人 你 有

14. I'd like a bowl of rice.

一 碗 我 要 米饭

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15. What colour do you like?

颜色 ○ 什么 ○ 喜欢 ○ 你 ○

16. Where are you going?

去 ○ 你 ○ 哪儿 ○

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APPENDIX

Radicals

Characters that share a radical often share part of their meaning. On each card, add one more word you find yourself.

日 sun

早上好 good morning
晚上好 good evening
是 to be (am, is, are)
日本 Japan
明天 tomorrow
昨天 yesterday

女 woman

姓 surname; to be surnamed
妈妈 mum
姐姐 older sister
妹妹 younger sister
奶奶 grandma (dad's mother)
外婆 grandma (mum's mother)

口 mouth

名字 name
叫 to be called; to call
号 day of the month (spoken)
哥哥 older brother
咖啡 coffee
喝 to drink

饣 food

米饭 (cooked) rice
饺子 dumplings
饿 hungry
饭馆 restaurant
早饭 breakfast
午饭 lunch

木 wood

面条 noodles
飞机 plane
手机 mobile phone
桌子 table, desk
椅子 chair
杯子 cup, glass

口 enclosure

美国 the USA
英国 the UK
法国 France
德国 Germany
四 4, four
公园 park

钅 metal

钱 money
银行 bank
地铁 subway, metro
高铁 high-speed train
钥匙 key
钱包 wallet, purse

氵 water

没有 not have
果汁 juice
啤酒 beer
渴 thirsty
洗手间 restroom, toilet
漂亮 beautiful, pretty

讠 speech

不用谢 no need to thank me
请 please (inviting, asking politely)
请问 excuse me, may I ask...
认识 to know (a person), to meet
谁 who

土 earth

块 yuan (spoken)
机场 airport
坐 to sit; to take (bus, train, plane)
在 to be at, to be in
长城 the Great Wall

艹 grass

菜 vegetables; a dish
苹果 apple
香蕉 banana
茶 tea
蓝色 blue

木 tree

水果 fruit
橙色 orange
棕色 brown
学校 school
榴莲 durian (a very smelly fruit)

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车 vehicle

车 vehicle, car
公交车 city bus
出租车 taxi
自行车 bicycle
开车 to drive

纟 silk

红色 red
绿色 green
紫色 purple
纸 paper

火 fire

灰色 grey
火车站 train station
火车 train
北京烤鸭 Peking duck

宀 roof

晚安 good night (before bed)
不客气 you're welcome
容易 easy

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APPENDIX

My Mandarin journal

Three new Mandarin words I learned today

A sentence about me in Mandarin

What I did today (in Mandarin)

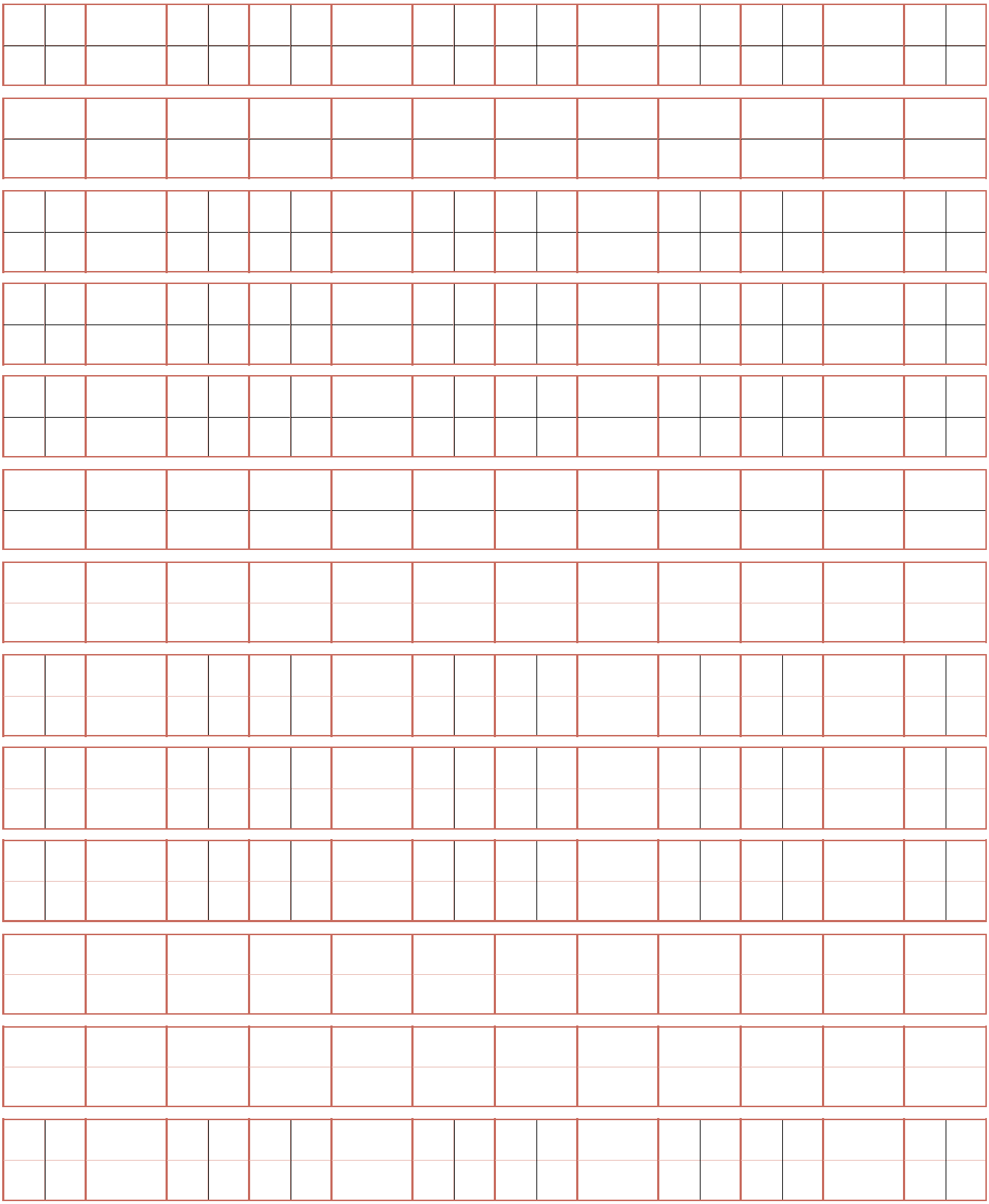
A question I want to ask a Mandarin speaker

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APPENDIX

Blank copybook pages

Write one character in each box. The dashed cross helps you keep the parts balanced.



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APPENDIX

Puzzle answers

Sentence puzzles

1. 2, 3, 1 — 你好吗?

2. 3, 2, 1 — 我很好。

3. 4, 3, 1, 2 — 我不是老师。

4. 3, 2, 1 — 我学中文。

5. 2, 3, 1 — 我叫李明。

6. 2, 1, 3, 4 — 你叫什么名字?

7. 2, 3, 1, 4 — 很高兴认识你。

8. 2, 4, 5, 3, 1 — 你是哪国人?

9. 1, 3, 2 — 这个多少钱?

10. 1, 2, 3, 5, 4 — 今天几月几号?

11. 3, 1, 2 — 今天星期几?

12. 3, 1, 2 — 现在几点?

13. 4, 5, 2, 6, 1, 3 — 你家有几口人?

14. 3, 4, 1, 2, 5 — 我要一碗米饭。

15. 4, 3, 2, 1 — 你喜欢什么颜色?

16. 2, 1, 3 — 你去哪儿?

Word search

1. Pinyin Reading Lab

员	同	色	礼	外	约	晚	车
金	书	喜	**没**	客	面	车	下
你	印	双	**关**	喜	音	钱	上
好	文	好	**系**	下	北	飞	动
么	名	谢	**对**	**朋**	妈	**谢**	**谢**
奶	买	兴	**不**	**友**	外	友	月
车	**再**	**见**	**起**	**学**	中	退	客
头	女	蛋	开	**生**	**老**	**师**	气

2. Greetings & Politeness

见	**您**	**好**	**晚**	**安**	便	门	爷
你	伞	店	饭	**早**	哪	银	头
好	横	雨	生	**上**	学	咳	行
霜	节	**晚**	**上**	**好**	肉	订	车
零	有	租	咳	早	好	饭	易
苹	**再**	**见**	儿	午	拐	**明**	喂
发	绿	好	客	刮	校	**天**	点
系	**你**	**们**	**好**	联	预	**见**	天

3. Introducing Yourself

早	服	星	外	印	**中**	**国**	色
果	用	钟	大	不	年	起	天
高	改	色	色	手	学	样	城
兴	间	**名**	号	色	间	饭	会
美	车	**字**	撇	月	饼	筷	雪
国	冒	**学**	学	**认**	**识**	多	美
预	地	**生**	号	下	行	**老**	看
冷	子	**朋**	**友**	作	么	**师**	中

4. Dates & Time

课	天	节	**昨**	好	**明**	**早**	卖
爷	橙	上	**天**	那	**天**	**上**	间
河	**现**	**在**	市	**周**	飞	饭	**今**
信	爸	拐	早	**末**	星	法	**天**
贵	行	微	早	在	岁	桌	国
长	节	谢	不	牛	**生**	点	卖
打	上	疼	多	台	**日**	订	**星**
师	现	怎	饭	那	冷	印	**期**

5. Family

天	好	起	行	见	菜	**哥**	**哥**
乡	已	名	**姐**	大	吃	门	**妹**
鸭	假	差	**姐**	人	子	**爷**	**妹**
弟	**弟**	洗	走	雪	会	**爷**	妈
饼	码	昨	好	西	**奶**	**奶**	感
再	**爸**	**爸**	校	霜	口	两	药
年	酒	岁	拿	么	**妈**	**妈**	下
师	票	请	妹	易	在	冷	起

6. Food & Drink

外	旧	**鸡**	**饺**	容	绿	卖	早
中	护	**蛋**	**子**	棕	儿	**猪**	**肉**
了	星	期	雨	少	中	书	从
床	个	色	折	干	人	四	外
右	直	请	天	谁	色	**面**	**条**
问	地	天	后	高	路	啡	饭
国	**包**	**子**	儿	卖	**牛**	鱼	**鸡**
色	起	**米**	**饭**	星	**肉**	色	**肉**

7. Colours

聊	榴	一	子	外	员	**黄**	**色**
雨	卖	行	**颜**	**色**	大	下	国
红	**色**	**绿**	**色**	**蓝**	司	诉	亚
电	色	天	上	**色**	再	下	姓
除	在	银	电	话	人	红	子
橙	老	块	山	去	卖	龙	奶
色	捺	冒	孩	色	**白**	毛	**黑**
怎	办	节	天	意	**色**	片	**色**

8. Places & Transport

线	**医**	**院**	**银**	**行**	菜	多	交
开	问	错	市	号	伞	天	肉
一	友	打	你	**商**	银	**酒**	**店**
爸	不	起	春	**店**	**学**	**校**	莲
公	**园**	赏	没	单	杯	起	早
饭	照	直	**超**	发	二	饼	黄
馆	车	谢	**市**	友	京	影	朋
口	色	桌	好	冒	见	多	杯

9. Everyday Objects

拐	哥	敬	色	机	漂	横	**桌**
雨	**伞**	高	问	**杯**	**子**	课	**子**
衣	**服**	十	粽	**椅**	线	下	您
不	事	上	**钥**	**子**	铁	开	见
手	钩	往	**匙**	十	过	老	天
书	拿	**电**	五	面	喜	午	了
是	请	**脑**	姐	果	车	**手**	**机**
月	加	出	钥	报	本	猪	认

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10. 在: Where & What's Happening

自	下	旁	七	机	小	**那**	弟
哪	喂	电	有	**后**	**面**	**儿**	书
服	日	微	晚	棕	色	**旁**	面
经	少	字	**前**	车	口	**边**	女
子	火	课	**面**	下	花	间	星
下	护	号	好	色	周	试	八
大	容	试	坐	钟	卖	月	喝
上	兴	爬	见	午	**这**	**儿**	酒

11. 了: Completed Actions

诉	果	哥	年	苹	糕	物	蓝
午	烧	蓝	热	**早**	春	人	天
饭	半	爷	毛	**饭**	服	筷	红
子	馆	棕	发	服	电	京	气
电	书	新	有	差	热	车	谢
影	**还**	东	好	女	**下**	**雨**	一
早	**没**	粉	手	姐	号	**晚**	哪
颜	累	好	冒	拿	电	**饭**	币

12. Where Do Time Words Go?

语	民	自	**下**	**个**	**月**	车	**以**
嗽	单	啡	月	粉	务	单	**后**
店	周	**明**	手	么	口	举	半
刚	往	**年**	房	**每**	**天**	**以**	**前**
才	**上**	**个**	**星**	**期**	敬	片	夫
笔	以	洗	爸	没	么	务	饭
子	菜	十	单	三	约	树	再
去	**年**	节	七	孩	司	末	直

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APPENDIX

Progress tracker

#	Lesson	Date	Quiz	✓
1	How a Mandarin Syllable Works		/6	
2	The Four Tones + the Neutral Tone		/8	
3	Initials, Group by Group		/7	
4	The Tricky Initials		/8	
5	Finals and the ü Sound		/7	
6	Where the Tone Mark Goes		/6	
7	Tone Changes		/7	
8	Pinyin Spelling Rules		/7	
9	Pinyin Reading Lab		/6	
10	What Are Chinese Characters?		/6	
11	The Basic Strokes		/6	
12	Stroke-Order Rules		/7	
13	First Characters: Numbers, People, Sun and Moon		/7	
14	First Characters: Nature and Family		/7	
15	Common Radicals		/7	
16	Building Characters from Parts		/7	
17	Simplified and Traditional Characters		/6	
18	Copywork and Dictation		/7	
19	Greetings & Politeness		/7	
20	Introducing Yourself		/7	
21	Numbers 0–10 & Hand Signs		/7	
22	Numbers to 100 & Money		/7	
23	Dates & Time		/7	
24	Family		/7	
25	Food & Drink		/7	
26	Colours		/6	

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#	Lesson	Date	Quiz	✓
27	Places & Transport		/7	
28	Everyday Objects		/7	
29	Word Order: Subject–Verb–Object		/7	
30	是: To Be		/6	
31	Adjectives with 很		/7	
32	Yes/No Questions with 吗		/7	
33	Question Words		/8	
34	Saying No: 不 vs 没		/7	
35	Measure Words		/8	
36	的: Possession & Description		/6	
37	在: Where & What's Happening		/7	
38	了: Completed Actions		/7	
39	Want, Can, May: 想 要 会 能 可以		/7	
40	Comparisons with 比		/6	
41	Where Do Time Words Go?		/6	
42	过: Have You Ever…?		/6	
43	Ordering at a Restaurant		/6	
44	Shopping & Bargaining		/6	
45	Asking for Directions		/6	
46	Taxi & Subway		/6	
47	At the Hotel		/6	
48	Phone Calls & Messaging		/6	
49	Making Plans		/6	
50	At the Doctor		/6	
51	Small Talk & the Weather		/6	
52	At School & Work		/6	
53	Story 1: Xiao Ming's Sunday		/6	
54	Story 2: The Umbrella		/7	

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#	Lesson	Date	Quiz	✓
55	Story 3: The Birthday Present		/6	
56	Poem: Quiet Night Thoughts		/7	
57	Chengyu & Everyday Sayings		/7	
58	Chinese Festivals		/7	
59	Culture Tips: Names, Gifts, Numbers & Table Manners		/8	
60	Final Review Lab		/8	

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